



PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

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THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

SECOND MEETING, 2025

Wednesday, 30th July, 2025

*The House met at the Chamber of
Parliament at 3.03 p.m.*

[THE FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER,
MR BERNARD AHIAFOR, IN THE
CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us turn to the item numbered 5 — *Correction of Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*.

**VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND
THE OFFICIAL REPORT**

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I have in my hand the *Votes and Proceedings* of Thursday, 29th July, 2025, for corrections.

Hon Members, page 1...7—

Prof Kingsley Nyarko: Mr Speaker, with respect, on page 7, the item numbered 5, “Recognition of School/Visitors”, I suggest we add “s” to the “SCHOOL”, to make it “SCHOOLS”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Table, please take note. In other words, delete “s” after “VISITORS”. Then we would know you are using a singular approach.

Page 8—

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, there is a minor observation at the apex of the page, the item numbered 5(b), if you look at the last line, “...Schools, Maxwel, Dagadu;”, I would suggest that Table checks the spelling of “Maxwel” because Maxwell normally has double “l”, but this has a single “l”. So, if they can cross check to be sure—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

That is a good observation; Table, take note.

Page 9...13—

Mr Frank Afriyie: Mr Speaker, on page 13, the item numbered 1, the name of the group is referenced as “West African Action Network on Small Arms, Ghana”. If you go to the item numbered 3, the same group is referenced quite differently; for instance, the item numbered 3(iii), “Mr Ken Kenny, President, West African Network on Small Arms”. Over here, the word “Action” is omitted, so I do not know which is correct. The Clerks-at-Table could take notes for the sake of consistency.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

That is a good observation. Thank you, Hon Member.

Page 14—

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, on page 14, if we look at the item numbered 1, “Opening”, it reads:

“The Committee met on Sunday, 13th July, 2025, at 9:00 a.m. and held a stakeholder engagement with the following...”

Mr Speaker, you would see that the Committee met about five stakeholders, so I want to know if it is possible for us to make it, “The Committee held stakeholder engagements”. Instead of “...a stakeholder engagement”, we could make it plural, “...held stakeholder engagements with the following...”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Table, kindly take note.

Page 15—

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, I was on my feet for page 15, the item numbered 2(ix), the name of the Hon Member, “Michael Kwesi Aidoo”. The “Micheal” has been spelt wrongly. That could be deleted and then Michael properly be inserted.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: How does he spell it?

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, he spells it, “M-i-c-h-a-e-l”. Over here, we have “e” before the “a”. It should be the “a” before “e”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Table, take note.

Page 16—

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, with respect, page 16, the item numbered 3(xi) “Ms Mavis Lamisi Apeliba, Technical Aid...”. The “Aid” should be “A-i-d-e”, not “A-i-d”. As in “Aid” which means support given to persons or individuals. So, it should be Technical Aide, as in a supporter, not “A-i-d”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Technical Aid?

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, it should be “A-i-d-e”, not “A-i-d”. Aid is like donation that is given, but this is a Technical Aide, so it should be “A-i-d-e”. We should delete “A-i-d” and insert “A-i-d-e”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Is that the designation under the Ministry of Youth Development and Empowerment?

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, if it is “Technical Aid”, that would be a bit strange.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Table, cross-check.

Page 17...20—

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, page 20, the item numbered 3(i) “...Executive Secretary, Public Services Housing Loan Scheme Board”—But on page 19, the same institution has been captured as Public Services Housing Loans..., so I do not know; one comes with “Loans” and the other comes with “Loan”. I do

not know if the Clerks-at-the-Table could—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Table, cross check for consistency.

Page 22—

3.13 p.m.

Mr Nana Osei-Adjei: Mr Speaker, page 22, under “Public Accounts Committee”, the item numbered 2(iii), “Nana Osei-Ajei”, the letter “d” is missing. It should be A-D-J-E-I.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well, Table, take note of the spelling and use the correct spelling.

Page 23?

Hon Members, the *Votes and Proceedings* of Tuesday, 29th July, 2025, as corrected, is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we have two *Official Reports*; one is dated 21st July, 2025 and the other, 22nd July, 2025.

We shall, therefore, first consider 21st July, 2025. The floor is now open for corrections.

Yes, Hon Kingsley Nyarko?

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, with respect, at column 74, the last but one line of the last paragraph, says “...valuable player award...”. If you read further, you will see that the Member was talking about three

different awards that our female players received. So, with respect, the “award” should be “awards”. It should read:

“...the women from our side have received the most valuable player awards, with Grace Asantewaa winning the Woman of the Match award against Algeria. Also, Chantelle Boye-Hlorkah won the Woman of the Match award against Tanzania with Jennifer Cudjoe winning Woman of the Match against Mali.”

So, I think that “award” should be plural.

Mr Speaker, then, at column 90, this is an insertion that I suggest we make; paragraph 3, after the quotation,

“Mr Speaker, in 2006, my home team, Berekum Arsenal, qualified for CAF Confederation Cup...”

Mr Speaker, it should be “...qualified for ‘the’ CAF Confederation Cup...”

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Table, take note.

Any further corrections?

Hon Members, the *Official Report* of Monday, 21st July, 2025, as corrected, is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, now, the *Official Report* of Tuesday, 22nd July, 2025, under corrections. The floor is now open.

Hon Kpotosu, are you on your feet?

[No correction was made to the Official Report of Tuesday, 22nd July, 2025.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, by agreement, we are to vary the order of Business to do Presentation of Papers.

Yes, Deputy Majority Leader?

[Pause]

Hon Members, do we go to the item numbered 7 at the Commencement of Public Business – Presentation of Papers?

Deputy Majority Leader (Mr George Kweku Ricketts-Hagan): Yes, Mr Speaker. I am trying to find the one for—Mr Speaker, we will want to do laying of some Papers. *[Pause]*

Mr Speaker, just a second, we are just conferring—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, let me use the opportunity to acknowledge the presence of students in our midst.

First is Golden Bridge STEM Academy, led by Arthur Wilson Alfred, a teacher. They are from Ajumako/Enyan/Essiam and are 80 in number.

[Pupils of Golden Bridge STEM Academy were acknowledged.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Second is Bonaboto Students Association, University of Ghana, led by Ajaka Asogla Aka Abdul-Rahman, President. They are from Ayawaso West Wuogon.

[Students of Bonaboto Students Association, University of Ghana, were acknowledged.]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: On behalf of the House, I welcome you to the Parliament of the Republic of Ghana. May you enjoy your stay. Have a fruitful visit.

Yes, any indication?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, at the commencement of Public Business, as you mentioned earlier, we want to look at the item numbered 7(e), to present a Joint Committee Report by the Chairman of the Committee.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Yes, Chairman of the Committee?

PAPERS

By the Chairman of the Committee —

Report of the Joint Committee on Budget and Finance on the Request for the Multi-Year Commitments for the Selected Road Projects under the “Big Push” Programme Contained in the Mid-Year Fiscal Policy Review of the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana.

First Deputy Minority Whip (Alhaji Habib Iddrisu): Mr Speaker, if we could do the item numbered 7(d) on page 4 of the Order Paper.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Chairman of the Committee?

By the Chairman of the Committee —

Report of the Committee on Subsidiary Legislation on the

Environmental Protection (Petroleum) Regulations, 2025.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, can we turn to the Order Paper *Addendum* and present the Reports numbered 1(i) and (ii).

By the Chairman of the Committee —

- (i) Report of the Committee on Subsidiary Legislation on the Public-Private Partnership Regulations 2025.
- (ii) Report of the Committee on Subsidiary Legislation on the Immigration Service (Amendment) Regulations 2025.

Yes, Hon Member?

3.23 p.m.

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Thank you Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, can we go back to the item numbered 7(a) to lay a Paper. It was supposed to be done by the Minister for Food and Agriculture. The Minister is not here but we have a Minister here present. So, I was going to crave your indulgence to permit us—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Second Deputy Whip, the application is for leave.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, we do not have any objection.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well, the item numbered 7(a), Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection?

By the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection on behalf of the Minister for Food and Agriculture.

Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ghana Irrigation Development Authority for the year 2024.

Referred to the Committee on Food, Agriculture and Cocoa Affairs.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, can we get the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection to do same for the item numbered 7(b) which was to be done by the Minister for Trade, Agribusiness and Industry?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, consequentially item numbered 7(b),

Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection.

By the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection on behalf of the Minister for Trade, Agribusiness and Industry.

Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ghana Export Promotion Authority for the year 2024.

Referred to the Committee on Trade, Industry and Tourism.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, the item numbered 7(c)?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection will do that on behalf of the Minister for Education.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us take all of them together.

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Yes. There are 20 of them, roman numerals i to xx.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, as much as we might not have a problem with the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection laying the Papers, the

leader has not been able to tell us where the Ministers are that they are not available in the Chamber to do their own Business. I think he needs to tell us that, so that the Minister can proceed and do that. Or is it the case that they are not here so she has to do it? Where are the Ministers?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Habib, let us allow the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection to lay the Paper. You know the Minister for Education is always in the Chamber.

Yes, Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection?

By the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection on behalf of the Minister for Education.

- (i) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Wesley College of Education for the year 2024.
- (ii) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Sunyani Technical University for the year 2024.
- (iii) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Tumu College of Education for the year 2024.

- (iv) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the St. Joseph College of Education for the year 2024.
- (v) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Berekum College of Education for the year 2024.
- (vi) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the St Monica College of Education for the year 2024.
- (vii) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Gbewaa College of Education for the year 2024.
- (viii) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the University of Energy and Natural Resources for the year 2024.
- (ix) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the University of Cape Coast for the year 2024.
- (x) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Evangelical Presbyterian College of Education, Amedzofe for the year 2024.

- (xi) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Institute of Chartered Accountant for the year 2024.
- (xii) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Jasikan College of Education for the year 2024.
- (xiii) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the St Vincent College of Education for the year 2024.
- (xiv) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Akatsi College of Education for the year 2024.
- (xv) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the St Ambrose College of Education for the year 2024.
- (xvi) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Cape Coast Technical University for the year 2024.
- (xvii) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the University of Professional Studies, Accra for the year 2024.

(xviii) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ghana Library Authority for the year 2024.

(xix) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Ghana Academy of Arts and Sciences for the year 2024.

(xx) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Simon Diedong Dombo University of Business and Integrated Development Studies for the year 2024.

Referred to the Committee on Education.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, yesterday we were doing the Social Protection Bill, 2025, but we got to the Consideration Stage and we want to continue with that. So, Mr Speaker, I will indulge you to take the item numbered 14.

BILL — CONSIDERATION STAGE

Social Protection Bill, 2025

Clause 1 and 2 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 3 — Eligibility of social protection intervention.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairperson of the Committee?

Rev Ntoso: No advertised amendments.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of the House. Yes, Hon Kojo Oppong Nkrumah?

Mr Kojo Oppong Nkrumah: Mr Speaker, I am of the view that the first line in clause 3 should read, “schedule 1”, not “section 1”. I imagine that they are referring to the schedule which outlines the vulnerability criteria examples of affected persons. If that is the case, then that is “schedule 1”, not “section 1”. I stand corrected.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, if you look at Section 1, it says,

(a) chronically poor,

(b) economically at-risk,

(c) socially vulnerable; and

(d) a person affected by a national or local emergency.

So that is what exactly they are referring to, not to the schedule.

Clause 3 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 4 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 5 — Role of the Ministry in social protection.

3.33 p.m.

Mr Matthew Nyindam: Mr Speaker, I beg to move, clause 5, subclause (1), paragraph (c), *insert* “individuals” to the list. Mr Speaker, if you look at line (c), “the national budget, development partners, civil society organisations and the private sector”. If an individual intends to also assist, what happens? Is an individual a private sector? I do not think the individual is a private sector? So my proposal is to add individuals who would also want to contribute.

Mr Speaker, that is my view for now.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, the proposal is to add “individuals”. The argument is that the individual is not a private sector.

Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama: Mr Speaker, “private sector” includes individuals.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Exactly.

Dr Mahama: I will urge my Senior, maybe in reading, he was looking at private companies. But when you look at “private sector”, it includes private companies and individuals.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That is so.

Dr Mahama: I think the current rendition should suffice, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: In fact, in law, a private company is even a person.

Mr Nyindam: Mr Speaker, that is alright.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Yes, Hon Oppong Nkrumah?

Mr Kojo Oppong Nkrumah: Mr Speaker, I beg to move that clause 5, subclause (1), paragraph (d), *insert* line “iii” to say “prevent duplication of social protection programmes”.

Mr Speaker, the reason is that sometimes you have the same person benefiting from different social protection programmes. So, you have social protection programmes that appear to provide overlapping benefits for the same category of persons. So, I am proposing we introduce “prevent duplication of social protection programmes” as an addition under clause 5, subclause (1), paragraph (d), line (iii).

Mr Isaac Adongo: Mr Speaker, the essence of social protection is to target the vulnerable and provide them with enough interventions that can get them out of poverty. That may require that the same person gets more than one. So, I think that is alright.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes. You did not get him clearly.

Mr Adongo: What I am saying is that the principle underlying social protection is to target the poor and the vulnerable with several interventions that can eventually equip them to get out of poverty, which would then require that in some instances one person may be targeted by several other interventions as a means of getting him out of poverty.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: If your rendition is carried out, in those instances it becomes very difficult.

Mr Nkrumah: Mr Speaker, understand it is so, but it is precisely for that reason that I am proposing that rendition, so that those who are designing these social protection programmes will design them in a manner that is efficient and able to address some of the issues without necessarily duplicating multiple programmes. If you look at some of the programmes that are currently being run, you have the same person benefiting from multiple programmes when you could, for example, put them, let us say, under productive inclusion, under one programme that will put them on an economic path so that they do not require multiple social protection programmes. And so, I am proposing that we do not necessarily create the model we are trying to create, where the same person is benefiting from different programmes, but the designers of the programmes are more efficient, put them in a programme that can get them back on a certain economic path and then they do not keep benefiting from multiple programmes.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon former Minister, looking at the “Application of the Act” as in clause

1, it is targeting people who are “chronically poor”. Is your suggestion to the effect that if a chronically poor person is benefiting from national health insurance, the same person should not benefit from the livelihood empowerment programme because that is also a social protection programme?

Yes, Hon Kabiru?

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, I wanted to find out from my Senior, if clause 5, subclause 1, paragraph (d), line 1 has not addressed his concern because his concern is duplication. Here, we are saying that the protection would develop leakages among social protection programmes to enable the integrated delivery. Mr Speaker, emphasis is “integrated delivery”. I think that that is a point that probably addresses his concerns about duplication of programmes and if he will find answer in this, that may not be necessary.

I am just trying to find out from the Senior.

Mr Nkrumah: Mr Speaker, no, in my view, it does not address it. But you can put the Question for the House to decide.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. So, I am putting the Question on the amendment proposed by Hon Kojo Oppong Nkrumah.

Question put and amendment negatived.

Clause 5 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 6 — Co-ordination of social protection.

Ing Surv Maxwell Kwame Lukutor: Mr Speaker, I beg to move, clause 6, subclause (1) *insert* “activities” or “interventions” after “social protection”. So that it reads, “The Ministry shall co-ordinate social protection activities through the Social Protection Directorate of the Ministry”.

Rev Ntoso: Mr Speaker, it is not harmful but we can do without it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, have you looked at page 44, the definition of social protection? “Social protection means a range of actions carried out by the state and other organisations”. In view of the definition of “social protection” in page 44, do you still believe that “activities” should be included?

Ing Surv Lukutor: Mr Speaker, if you look at clause 3 — Eligibility for social protection intervention. And so, I feel that maybe for the sake of consistency, it is either “interventions” or “activities” coming along with the social protection will not be harmful.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Clause 6(1) is saying, “The Ministry shall co-ordinate social protection” and the social protection that the Ministry is going to coordinate is a social protection as defined in page 44.

Ing Surv Lukutor: Yes, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: And if you look at page 44, it does not include “intervention”. It says

“‘social protection’ means a range of actions carried out by the State and other organisations”.

That is the definition for social protection.

Ing Surv Lukutor: Mr Speaker, I am guided. Withdrawn.

Clause 6 to 8 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 7 to 12 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 13 — Community targeting.

3.43 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairperson of the Committee?

Chairperson of the Committee (Rev Helen Adjoa Ntoso): Mr Speaker, no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, is there any proposed amendment to clause 13?

Yes, Hon Dr Kabiru Mahama?

Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama: Mr Speaker, may I seek leave from you to ask the Chairperson of the Committee a question before I propose my amendment. What do they mean when clause 13 says “any other statutory body”?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairperson of the Committee?

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, the latter part of the rendition says, “or any other statutory body” and I am seeking the clarity as to what is in contemplation here.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, Hon Member, the rendition says:

“The selection of communities for a social intervention or a social protection programme shall be guided by the National Household Registry and statistics published by Ghana Statistical Service or any other statutory body”.

For instance, if there are statistics published by National Health Insurance Scheme which is a statutory body, that should also be taken into consideration. That is my understanding of any other statutory body. So, it is not only the Statistical Service.

Dr Mahama: So, Mr Speaker, it may well be that community targeting could be done by agencies just like individual beneficiaries in clause 12. This is because sometimes, programme targeting of a community is not from Government but from other private people. So, when it is couched this way, it means that when a community is targeted by the private sector, it will not fall within this Bill or within this particular law.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, as to whether the law is contemplating taking statistics from

other bodies apart from statutory bodies, is a matter for us to determine.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, I get the explanation. I am well pleased with your explanation. I am just trying to further say that the current rendition limits the ability of private people to target communities by way of community being beneficiaries because this is in contemplation of communities benefiting from social protection programmes. So, once it is contemplating a community benefiting and we are relying on data from Ghana National Registry or the Ghana Statistical Service and any other statutory body, that means that if a private programme targets a community, it would not be captured under this Bill. I was just thinking that if we can address that fear by way of an amendment to this particular Bill or it is addressed in other parts. Mr Speaker, I seek your guidance.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, my understanding here is that the source that should guide the National Household Registry is the statistics published by the Ghana Statistical Service or any other statutory body that will serve as a guide. So, if, let us say, a civil society organisation has undertaken a project, that is not being envisaged here.

Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Mahama Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I think the provision is first about the selection of communities for targeting social protection and the information that should guide the selection. So essentially, the objective is to make sure that the statistics, data, and information that guides the selection is from statutory agencies, that is public agencies established by law. So, it should either be the Household Registry, which is under the Ministry of Gender, Children and Social Protection, or Ghana Statistical Service, or any other statutory agency.

Mr Speaker, I can understand the Hon Member. If a private entity gathers data, that data cannot bind or be used to guide the selection of communities. But what I understand the Hon Member to be saying is that this prevents private entities from targeting communities. No, it does not stop private entities from targeting communities, unless it discourages them from gathering data on communities, because the data may not be used by the State. But if the data is to be used by international NGOs, by academics, and *et cetera*, they may as well go and gather their data as private entities, like ActionAid, and all those NGOs that also do some work around

gathering data about vulnerable communities for their own purposes. The information gathered does not become amenable to be used by the state agencies and that is all that this clause is talking about.

Clause 13 to 20 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 21 — Termination of cash transfer.

3.53 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairperson of the Committee?

Rev Ntoso: Mr Speaker, no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of the House. Any proposed amendment?

Ing Surv Lukutor: Mr Speaker, may I enquire from the Chairperson 21(a) and (b)—

“(a) the cash transfer was obtained through misrepresentation, deceit, fraud, or failure to disclose information;

(b) the cash transfer was approved or paid in error;”.

What is the difference between the (a) and (b) and what is the definition of error here in (b)?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: One is dealing with the cash transfer obtained through misrepresentation, deceit, fraud, or failure to disclose information and the other one is the cash transfer was approved or paid. One is talking about receipt of the information and the other one is about transfer of the payments. They are two different things.

Clause 21 to 27 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 28 — Education interventions.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairperson of the Committee?

Rev Ntoso: Mr Speaker, no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of the House.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, the 28(1)(b) says nutrition support, if I might just start from 28(1)(b), it reads:

“The Ministry shall, in collaboration with the Ministry responsible for Education,

ensure that nutrition support programmes are effectively implemented in schools in vulnerable communities”.

I am not sure what is in reference to vulnerable communities here. I need clarity on that.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Chairperson of the Committee?

Rev Ntoso: Mr Speaker, “vulnerable communities” here means communities that have been identified as vulnerable, being economically at risk or chronically poor. Those are the communities we are looking at.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I intend to direct that when we get to Interpretation, we provide a definition for vulnerable communities, so Hon Dr Kabiru Mahama, take note when we get to Interpretation.

Clause 28 to 35 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

4.03 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Habib?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I just wanted to give an

indication that we will truncate at clause 37, then we zoom into the debate and come back.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, in high gear, I would want to plead with you that we stop at clause 45. We are now at clause 35 and we are moving to clause 36. After, then we come to the Motion.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, with respect, if we could do up to clause 37, then zoom into the debate. We will come back to the Bill, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, but my plea is that let us stop at clause 45; it is a convenient place to stop. In no time, we will be done.

Clause 36 to 38 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes?

Mr Dominic Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, I advise that once we move to the debate and come back to this, they should amend the Order Paper *Addendum*, so that it will reflect tomorrow. As it stands today, it ends at clause 33. So, they can do the Order Paper *Addendum* to reflect all that we are doing.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No, the Social Protection Bill, 2025, is under consideration. If we are not able to finish the consideration today, we will continue the consideration.

Mr Nitiwul: So, there is no amendment at all?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No, there is no amendment. That was what necessitated the withdrawal and re-introduction of the Bill to integrate the amendments into the Bill. Hon Nitiwul, that was why when we were debating the urgency, we justified it by the fact that—

Mr Nitiwul: So, there is no advertised amendment?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: There is no advertised amendment. The proposed amendments were all integrated into the Bill, withdrawn and the new one was relaid.

Mr Nitiwul: That is why they took it under a certificate of urgency yesterday?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, that is why.

Clause 39 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes?

Mr Kojo Oppong Nkrumah: So, Mr Speaker, since we have completed the financial matters, there is a clarification that I want to get.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Mr Nkrumah: On the financial matters, clause 32(1)(b), under “Role of the Ministry responsible for Finance”. There is a confusion here that I would want clarified. It says to

“(b) make specific allocation for the social protection interventions and the Social Protection Fund;”

Mr Speaker, I need some clarity: is it the case that we are setting up this Fund that this Fund will now be the one responsible for funding the interventions or that this Fund is being set up parallel to the Ministry of Finance’s financing of the social protection interventions?

And I ask this question because of the earlier issue of duplication that I realised.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Chairperson?

Rev Ntoso: Mr Speaker, the Fund will run alongside what the Ministry of Finance will give.

Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah: Then, obviously, there will be duplication of activities of the Fund. If the sources and objects of the Fund are clearly established by this clause, I think clause 34, then the Fund ought to be very specific as to what it is going to do to fund social protection activities. But if we say to “make allocations for social protection interventions and the Social Protection Fund”, then it means there is a duplication there that we must correct.

What are we seeking to do from the same Fund that is being established? To fund social protection interventions and what? Chairperson, do you get the argument? So, we need to be very clear on what we are doing. Otherwise, there will be some form of duplication there. So, we can flag it and discuss with the Minister, so that when we get to the Second Consideration Stage, we can look at it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Let us look at it at the Second Consideration Stage, as indicated.

Clause 40 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 41 — Composition of the National Social Protection Committee. Chairperson of the committee.

Rev Ntoso: Mr Speaker, there is no advertised amendment.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, reading through the composition of the National Social Protection Committee, we have the Ministry being represented. We also have the Director of the Social Protection Directorate, which is also under the Ministry of Gender, Children and Children Affairs, but conspicuously missing is a representative of the most important directorate or unit, which is the Livelihood Empowerment Against Poverty (LEAP) unit.

I do not know whether it has expression in other areas, but if we have the Social Protection Directorate represented here, I think that, clearly, LEAP should have representation.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, what will be your rendition?

Dr Mahama: So, the proposal is that we have the Director of the Livelihood Empowerment Against

Poverty Programme Unit to also be a member.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Do we have a director for that position?

Dr Lartey: Mr Speaker, under the Ministry, the LEAP programme is under Social Protection as a secretariat, so it is covered under the Social Protection Directorate.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is under this directorate.

Yes, Hon Member?

4.13 p.m.

Mr Boamah: Mr Speaker, just some clarification. The establishment of the National Social Protection Committee has the Minister or her representative. I do not know who is going to chair that committee. Secondly, I do not understand why the Ministers listed under (b) (i) to (vii). I do not know what they will be doing on this committee. They are very important Ministries and have functions to perform. So, I think their representatives must sit on the committee.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: If you look at the rendition carefully, it says “the Minister or representative

of the Minister not below the rank of Director as chairperson.” The rendition ends with “as chairperson”. Then when you come to (b), “a representative each of the Ministries responsible for ... not below the rank of Director, nominated by the respective Ministers”. Then it is just mentioning the Ministries, not the Minister himself. Any further issue?

Clause 41 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 42 — Functions of the National Social Protection Committee.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, I propose, after (h) an omnibus function that seeks to cover— Because there may be other things ancillary to the social protection work of the country. But the current function does not provide for that. So, if the drafters—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, propose a rendition. How do you want it to be?

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, I thought that the Legislative Drafters would so that while I have given the—But once you want me to propose, I would propose that after (h), insert —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You see, though this is a committee, it is not like a board sub-committee where they are to perform any other function assigned by the Board. This is the highest decision-making body involving the Minister. So, if you have the omnibus clause, who then determines that omnibus clause for them to perform? Or we should just say “Any other function ancillary to the object”—

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, rightly so because when you are giving functions to the Committee and limit it to what is being specified, it limits the hand of the Committee in terms of what other things they can do ancillary to the achievement of the object of that particular committee. So that was the proposal. So “They perform any other function ancillary to the object of the Committee.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes. Drafters, take note, “Any other function ancillary to the object.”

Clause 42 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 43 — Tenure of office of members of the National Social Protection Committee.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker at clause 43(1), I propose we *delete* “three” and *insert* “four”.

Mr Speaker, it is my view that members of the committee should hold office for a period of four years which is well enough for the members to be able to learn the industry and can make meaningful contribution to such. But if we limit it to three years and it is not even coterminous with the tenure of the President, it becomes problematic. So I beg to move, clause 43, subclause (1), *delete* “three” and *insert* “four”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, the proposal is that the tenure of office should be four years instead of three years.

Yes, Ms Zuwera?

Ms Zuwera Mohammed Ibrahimah: Mr Speaker, this particular clause was debated extensively at Committee and we looked at all the various variables and we came to the conclusion that indeed this is July. So if we want to make the term of the committee coterminous to that of the President, we would have already lost 6 months. So there is no way we could gain four years. We also agreed that it seems

to be the procedure at every time when there is a change of Government, that it takes a while for the Government to settle, to enable the Government to put together all these boards. So the committee agreed that three years was a more practical period for the board.

Mr Speaker, thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Habib?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I also want to speak in support of the four years. As much as the Committee might deliberate looking at the fact that we are in July, we are making a law and the law will stay for long.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, this House is guided by precedence in other committees and boards that we have established. How many years do we have as tenure of office? Is it not four years?

So, Hon Members, let us give consideration to the proposal made by Dr Kabiru. There should be a further amendment to clause 43(1). May a Member adopt that rendition and then let us make progress. Hon Members, we always say, “for reappointment for another term only”

but that is missing in the rendition. So, a Member should own the amendment and let me put the Question. If you read 43(1), “A member of the Committee shall hold office for a period of three years and is eligible for re-appointment...”. Then full stop— well, then what I have, there is full stop there.

So, Chairperson, furnish me with the new Bill. Yes, it is there.

Clause 43 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 44 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 45 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

4.23 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, the agreement is to stop at clause 45. The rest of the clauses— Clause 46 deals with the Secretariat of the National Social Protection Committee. So, I guess we are bringing the Consideration Stage temporarily to an end at clause 45. We will continue later.

Majority Leader, any indication?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, we will continue with the debate; that is the item numbered 8 on the Order Paper.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. The item numbered 8, Motion; continuation of the debate.

Hon Members, I will proceed to give the floor to Hon Kwabena Darko-Mensah. You have 15 minutes.

Mr Richard Acheampong: Mr Speaker, respectfully, when we started the debate, we started from the Majority Side and yesterday, we went to the Minority Side. [**Some Hon Members:** Why?] So, today, we should start from the Majority Side. That was the arrangement.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, it does not change anything, so they can go ahead.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I recall that the first day, I started with the Majority Side and the following day, I started with the Minority Side. So, today, it is good my attention has been drawn to that. I will therefore start with the Majority Side.

I will now give the floor to Hon George Kweku Ricketts-Hagan; you have 30 minutes.

MOTIONS

Mid-Year Budget Review, 2025

[Resumption of debate from Tuesday, 29/07/2025]

Deputy Majority Leader (Mr George Kweku Ricketts-Hagan): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the Mid-Year Fiscal Policy Review.

Mr Speaker, first of all, I would want to commend the Minister for Finance, Hon Dr Cassiel Ato Baah Forson, for what he has been able to do since the last time that he read the actual Budget somewhere in March.

Mr Speaker, I think that what is happening at the moment, in terms of the economic situation that we find ourselves in, is too much for some to take. They actually find it unbelievable that within the shortest possible time, we have been able to turn around the economy and put all indicators on the right path to growth. Mr Speaker, it may surprise them because he has done in a few months what they could not do for eight years. And I am not surprised that

they doubt that this is a flash in the pan, as they put it. They think it is something that cannot be sustained. And it is either they have got their economics upside down, or they do not want to agree that things are different.

Mr Speaker, I think what we should look at is what has really happened. Something has happened to this country in the last few months that, as I said before, has never happened for almost 70 years. And if my Hon friends will listen, they will actually understand what is going on.

Because they are looking at something completely different, and thinking that it is not possible for the currency to appreciate up to the extent that it is now. Because if they could not do that for eight years, how can it be possible that it could be done in three months? Now let me explain to them what is going on that they are not looking at.

Mr Speaker, as I said, something has happened in this country in the last few months, under the NDC Government, under His Excellency John Dramani Mahama, and the pragmatism of Hon Dr Cassiel Ato Baah Forson as the Minister for Finance.

We have listened to a lot of theories from the other Side, and it did not amount to anything. Mr Speaker, this country— this our country, is one of the largest producers of gold in the world for over hundred years. Yet, we are one country that has no control over its gold since independence. Because if you go to Dubai, for instance, in time past, and ask for how much gold they have received from Ghana, it is actually more than the official gold that we have exported to them. But that does not seem to tell us anything, or we do not hear anything. It simply meant that gold was taken away from this country, and the proceeds actually did not come back here.

Mr Speaker, the formation of the Gold Board is something that has not happened in this country for nearly 70 years. And it is what has turned this economy around so quickly that people believe that it is impossible. We have full control of our gold, which we never did. And it is not surprising that it baffles people that within these few months, we have actually been able to rake in, in terms of inflows, US\$5 billion worth of gold.

Mr Speaker, I heard the former Minister for Finance saying that if we have actually brought in that much money, why is it that the gross reserve is US\$11 billion? Because they left US\$8.9 billion. I am really surprised that he would even ask that question. It is simple, the gold that brought us the US\$5 million was bought with some capital. So, when they say US\$5 million inflows, those are inflows, and you are going to take off other costs to be able to arrive at

what went to the Central Bank. So, US\$2.2 billion that was added to our gross reserves came purely from gold. This has never happened in the history of Ghana. When our friends were in office, their US\$2 billion came from borrowing from the Eurobond. The only thing that they know how— they borrowed the US\$2 billion from Eurobond.

Today, Ghana gets its US\$2 billion from its own gold. This is simply what has happened. Ghana probably would not need to return to the Eurobond market again because the Gold Board is going to give us what they were collecting from Eurobond which puts this country in a mess.

4.33 p.m.

Mr Speaker, our friends on the other Side lived on three things. It is three things that kept them alive, and they were all loans. Our friends lived on the International Monetary Fund (IMF) drawdowns when we were on the IMF Programme. Because in the last decade, we have actually been on an IMF Programme almost in and out and they were getting money. I do not know if they have forgotten those days when the cedi had depreciated so much, they would tell you that they are waiting for IMF proceeds to come in. When the cedi had depreciated so much, the other thing they depended on was the cocoa syndicated loan. Everything was loan when they were in office. The third thing, as I said, the Eurobond, Cocoa syndication and IMF was what they lived on. That is what the Gold Board is bringing us today.

So, anyone who thinks that the cedi will depreciate again to the extent that it did, either does not understand what this Government is doing or they need some kind of a training to understand exactly what is happening. Ghana will never return to where the New Patriotic Party (NPP) Government left us. Because we would not be in a situation where the cedi would depreciate to the extent that it did again. If we carry on with the Gold Board, all the money that we were borrowing will come from our own resources.

Mr Speaker, the gold reserve is now US\$11 billion. As the former Minister for Finance said, the explanation is that we have added US\$2.2 billion from our own gold to that, and that is why we have over four months of export-import cover. Mr Speaker, if we have that much reserves, and if our currency is controlled the way we are controlling it, we would not need to throw any reserves to try and hold our currency. So, if we are getting our own resources into our reserves to manage our currency, we would not need to throw the money at the Central Bank in correcting the currency. This is what they were doing and that is why they failed.

Mr Speaker, the other thing that they talk about is that the Minister for Finance is not spending money. If the Minister for Finance is not spending recklessly or bringing a wasteful expenditure—Because that is the only way they know. When they say spending, they are spending on frivolous and wasteful expenditure. Those are the things they

do. The Minister for Finance is not doing that now, so they see it as no spending.

The oil for gold, or gold for oil, whatever they call it, that they were doing turned out to be one of the unbelievable and unthinkable policies that can ever be implemented in this modern age. We have a world market for gold and oil, and they were sitting in some little corner and doing a barter trade of oil and gold. How? And they said it is an economic policy. Gold has a world market price. If anybody wants to buy gold, they go to the market. Oil has a market price. If anybody wants to buy oil, they go to the market.

Why would they call somebody in Dubai and do a barter trade in this day and age? I mean, did they set up their own price in that barter trade? Did they have a different price for gold and oil than what was being given in the world market? What was in for them and what was in for the other person? Nobody in their right senses will sell oil to us at a price lower than the market. And then we may want to sell gold to other people below the world market. It is not surprising.

We have lost US\$2.4 billion in that unthinkable deal that they did and they said it is a barter trade in this day and age, when we have a trade market in the world. It is no wonder that we do not know who was supplying the oil that they sank US\$4.9 billion into. We do not know the price. There were so many things we did not know about that transaction. The government itself did not know. All we found out is that they

had lost US\$2.4 billion. This is money that should become the money of someone who has caused a financial loss to this country, and that money must be paid, and it will be, eventually, one day.

Mr Speaker, the cedi has appreciated against the U.S. dollar by 42 per cent in this short span of time, and they said they do not know why. If they do not know why, they should ask the Gold Board. It has appreciated against the British pound by 32 per cent and they said they do not know why. They should ask the Gold Board. Against the Euro, the cedi is 24 per cent.

This country will never be the same again—*[Hear! Hear!]*—because this country's currency will not reverse to where it used to be again. This country does not need to go to the Eurobond market to borrow again—*[Hear! Hear!]*—because the Eurobond money will come from the Gold Board.

When they were doing the Eurobond, the US\$13 billion Eurobond debt that they had, they alone borrowed US\$11 billion of that money in seven years. What did they do? They stopped paying. They did not pay the Eurobond debt, but they are asking Dr Cassiel Ato Forson why he is not spending. The US\$700 million that he paid to the Eurobond market was the money they should have paid when they were in office. They refused.

Let me remind them in case they have forgotten. They may pretend to have forgotten, but we still have the records. Let me find and show to the what they

were doing in office that they have probably forgotten. They have three Eurobonds here. One was due in September 2022 for US\$750 million, which they never paid. The second Eurobond that was due for payment was for August 2023, which they never paid and that was also for US\$1 billion. The third one they never paid was another billion for 2024. So, when they alone were in office, they never paid the maturity of Eurobond of US\$2.75 billion. Dr Ato Forson had to come and pay US\$700 million of it after they had done their external debt exchange programme. That is the external one; we have not even talked about the local one.

Mr Speaker, the economy we are building today will not be understood by our Hon Friends on the other Side. That is why they should be out of power for a very long time, not to take us back to where we have been.

Mr Speaker, they talked about National Investment Bank (NIB). I heard them saying that Dr Ato Forson had spent money on NIB, but they say he is not spending. They were never able to resolve NIB's problem. They took some fancy financial instrument and told us that they were using it to correct the NIB situation, meanwhile they never did.

Mr Speaker, I would like to refer them to something they did which they thought we had forgotten. During what they call crisis, the banking crisis, where they used 30 billion to collapse banks that could have been saved with 9 billion, and they said it was a clean-up, they created something called Ghana

Amalgamated Trust. Nobody knows where the money that went into that area was from. Let me remind them what they did at NIB.

4.43 p.m.

This is from the Budget of 2020 and if they can check on their phones or their system; it was at pages 50 and 51 of that Budget they read to us in this House. This is what they said about NIB which nobody actually knows what happened. Mr Speaker, with your permission, I read from paragraph 221 of the 2020 Budget, page 50, it says:

“Mr Speaker, Government took a decision to deal with NIB separately from the other 4 participating banks because of its unique challenge and the fact that it was almost 100% owned by the state. Over the past months, Government has worked to strengthen the management, ensure regulatory compliance and beef up the financial reporting framework of the bank to enable it participate more effectively under the GAT programme”.

Mr Speaker, nothing was done, only money was siphoned. NIB had shares from Nestle of GH¢500 million. Mr Speaker, what did the NPP Government do? They sold it. The bank—They sold the juice or the crown in the bank that was collapsing and it says here—And it is from their own Budget.

“October 2019, they entered into a swap arrangement with NIB with

respect to its Nestle shares, giving NIB GH¢500 million of new liquidity for the Nestle shares. The final assessment of the bank, however, showed a much wider capital shortfall...”

Mr Speaker, they did something funny, which is a derivative product in the financial world called “Put Call Option” and they got this House to approve GH¢2.2 billion. Supposedly, it was used to restructure NIB; that never materialised and nobody knows where that money went up to date. That is in the Budget of 2020; it is here. It is in their own Budget. If they pick their Budget and read it, they will find it there. Eventually, they will answer for that. It is on paper and they put it in that paper. They thought we had forgotten, but they will soon answer.

Today, Dr Forson put in an injection of about GH¢2 billion or so into NIB to restructure it and to put it back on a path of growth. They are saying that he is not spending; that kind of spending will never happen again. We will put the money in the productive sector of the economy—[Hear! Hear!]
—We will spend for growth, not waste. We will not dig a hole with spending and abandon it. We would not choose to fly on planes we can have a bath in. Those are the expenditures they will not see again. So, if their idea of expenditure is that, then I am afraid they will not see it again. They will see proper expenditure. Expenditure that will grow the economy; expenditure that will clear your mess; expenditure that will bring our credit ratings down; expenditure that will make our currency

stronger and stronger; and expenditure that will give Ghanaians a relief. They have done so much to this country. Please, they should give us a break and let us fix this economy and make it the country that it should be.

This is a rich country — a country that sits on gold. I remember, in those days when they were in office, we used to tell them to put gold on our reserves. They would not listen. At the eleventh hour, they started doing that, but, at that time, Ghanaians had shown them the exit door and they were on their way out. Though they started that, that is what this Government has come to intensify. Can you imagine? Something that also has not happened for 70 years and they sit down and ask themselves why did they not even think about that?

Mr Speaker, Ghana is one of the largest producers of gold in the world, but we were one of the countries in the world that did not back its reserves with gold. The people we borrow money from—The Europeans and Americans who we were borrowing money from do not even produce gold, but they have gold reserves in their central banks. We were producing gold, but we never had reserves. And this never happened for 70 years. Today, the reason why H. E. John Dramani Mahama and the pragmatist, Dr Cassiel Ato Forson, are succeeding is because we are beginning to correct the mess. We are resetting the economy of Ghana and that is why we are where we are.

If they do not understand why the cedi has strengthened and why it will

stay that way, please, the Ministry of Finance is just here. They can go and get some explanation. When the former Minister for Finance was speaking yesterday, I was not in the Chamber, but I was listening to him and I was actually watching him and I could see that he looked confused. He cannot understand why the economy has turned around so well—*[Interruption]*—Personal view on the facial expression.

Mr Speaker, interest rate is low. When our Colleagues were in office, when all the borrowing had dried up, when the capital markets stopped giving us money, they then resorted to treasury bills. Mr Speaker, in the last six months of 2024, this country was living on treasury bills. Mr Speaker, the graphs are here and I will table this in. This is from Bank of Ghana and this is the treasury bills that Dr Ato Forson had taken in the last six months and you can see the graph if you choose to see. You can see that it has been descending, which means that the country, today, is living on less and less on treasury bills. That is why the rate is going down. When they were in office and treasury bills were going up, it was because they were living on it. But that is a thing of the past and it will not happen again.

Mr Speaker, President Mahama has reset the economy and then the 24-Hour Economy will be the icing on the cake. I know they do not want to hear 24-Hour Economy, but in their own small corner, I know you talk about 24-Hour Economy. It will reach them and they will benefit from it. Their children will benefit from it and their relatives will

benefit from it because the jobs that the economy will create will be created for all of us.

Mr Speaker, if you look at all the graphs, whether it is inflation or interest rate—And I will turn this in. This is from Bank of Ghana—*[Interruption]*—Mr Speaker, let those who want to hear listen.

4.53 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the economy is on the right path. Gone are the days when they said they have turned the corner, but they were still in the bush. They were lost; they never found their way. Today, we have got a Government—When I hear my Friends on the other Side talk about wanting their roads fixed and some projects completed, I ask myself, where have they been in the last eight years? They have got so much, but they have shown so little and that is why Ghanaians showed them the exit.

Mr Speaker, I know they will stay in opposition for a long time, if we continue to do what we are doing. I know that frightens them, but they should brace themselves, because this economy is not going to turn around to where they used to be. It is never going to happen. If they really understand what is going on today, things have changed. The economy of Ghana has changed.

Gold Board is a game changer. For the last 70 years, this country has never had anything like Gold Board. For the last 70 years, we have not backed our reserves the way we have. Therefore, we

will never go below three months of import cover. No amount of intimidation will change the Ghana we are resetting. *[Hear! Hear!]* Ghana will continue to go on the right path. No amount of press conference as well—*[Laughter]*—will change anything.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, conclude.

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: If they want to govern this country one day, they should look at what is being done today and learn from it. They talked about we paying statutory funds; they were not paying those moneys. We have uncapped it.

They said when President Mahama comes, he is going to abolish the Free Senior High School policy (Free SHS). What has he done? He has provided a reliable source of funding for this Free SHS by uncapping a statutory fund; something they could not do. From day one, they were never able to explain to us how they were going to fund that free education. They never did before they left office.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up. *[Hear! Hear!]*

I will proceed to give the floor—Yes, Hon Habib?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I understand that we do not need to interject in this debate. Yesterday, you guided Hon Kabiru when he used the word “dishonesty”. Even though he continued, you directed that the words

should be expunged from the record and he withdrew.

The Deputy Majority Leader said the former Minister for Finance was very confused. That is unparliamentary. He should withdraw that or it should be expunged from the record just like you directed and guided us yesterday. This is because, Mr Speaker, if you do not take this cue, if somebody from our Side also says something against them, it will be difficult to tell them to withdraw. He cannot say the former Minister for Finance was very confused. He cannot say that. He should withdraw that or it should be expunged from the record.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, there is a vast distinction of you being classified as a dishonest person and you being confused. As for confusion, everybody can be confused, but when they say you are dishonest, it imputes criminality.

So, Hon Members, I will give the floor to Hon Kwabena Okyere Darko-Mensah? You are speaking for 15 minutes.

Mr Kwabena Okyere Darko-Mensah (NPP — Takoradi): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for this opportunity to contribute to this lively debate on the economy.

First and foremost, the Hon Minister talked about the current growth rate and the input of the agriculture and fisheries sectors: 26.4 per cent and 16.4 per cent in supporting that growth. Clearly, the Minister for Finance and the John

Mahama Administration, clearly, know that they have not grown any agricultural produce. These growth figures had come from our Planting for Food and Jobs Phase II (PFJ II) and the work that was done by Hon Hawa Koomson in the fisheries sector. So, if they are taking the credit for these inputs and growth, they should give the NPP Government the credit for the work we have done in supporting the growth.

Mr Speaker, this Budget Review is clear on the issue of the National Investment Bank (NIB). In fact, if we look at page 23, paragraph 139, it is very clear and it states that we wrongly spent over GHC30 billion in reorganising the banks. This statement is very rich. It is extremely rich, especially coming from the NDC when they know that their cronies, especially Dr Duffour is part and parcel of those who have—[...*Expunged by order of Mr Speaker*]—misused Government money of over GHC5.7 billion.

Mr Speaker, the Attorney-General (AG) recently did a press conference on this subject matter and I can tender that in evidence. I have it on my phone and I can tender that in evidence. In fact, under this Attorney-General, under the NDC, they have recalibrated the money from GHC5.7 billion to GHC3.3 billion, when they knew the case in court was GHC5.7 billion. This GHC5.7 billion can do so much for this country—

Mr Ayariga — rose —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Majority Leader? Hon Member, let me recognise the Hon Majority Leader.

Mr Mahama Ayariga: Mr Speaker, you gave an earlier indication of previous rulings about words that can be used by Members to describe individuals during debates. He said the former Minister for Finance, Dr Duffour dishonestly mismanaged. Dishonesty is a criminal offence.

The Government actually instituted criminal prosecutions and could not convict him. After close to eight years of trial, they could not convict him. Just a couple of days ago, the state entered a *nolle prosequi*, so to stand here and impute criminality to a person that they had an opportunity for eight good years to establish the criminality and did not establish the criminality, until that person benefited from a *nolle prosequi*, that clearly breaches our Rules and so he has to withdraw that.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, did you say “dishonestly misused” or “misused”?

Mr Darko-Mensah: Mr Speaker, I used the phrase “— misused” because the case is in court and they have taken part of the money and there is a plea bargain. The AG himself has said it. There is a 60–40 plea bargain, so there is nothing wrong with the usage of my language.

5.03 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, in the Constitution, in our criminal offences, we have an offence of dishonesty, fraud, and moral turpitude as

a criminal offence and we do not impute criminality. So, when the choice of your word is dishonesty, then really, you are imputing criminality and it offends our rules. So, I will urge upon you to withdraw the word “dishonesty”.

Mr Darko-Mensah: Mr Speaker, I think that the person has already paid part of the money and there is a plea bargain—[Uproar]—Please, let me speak to the Speaker— What were the charges? What were the basis for the charges?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, based on the rules, even if Hon Kwabena Okyere Darko-Mensah is a criminal, the rules do not permit me to come and stand on this particular Floor and say you are a criminal. That is why the rules simply say you do not impute criminal motive. That is not up to you.

Yes, Hon Habib?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, this is part of the reason for which I was drawing your attention to something — [Uproar]—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, Hon Habib, let us settle the issue this way. Look at our Criminal Offences Act and look at our Constitution. Tell me where the word “confusion” is a crime.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I want to be guided. We need to help you to manage this House. Mr Speaker, in the debate, we all agree, and yesterday, you guided Hon Dr Kabiru Mahama and the rest. So, what I was saying is that, when

the Deputy Majority Leader said the former Minister for Finance was very confused, do you think it is parliamentary to say that a Colleague is very confused? Mr Speaker, what my Colleague just said —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, that is why I am saying that, if he had used the word “confused” or “misused”, I would not have a problem, but my problem is the use of the word “dishonesty”.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I think the matter in question, is that the former Governor and the former Minister for Finance were charged for that offence.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon available leader, the rules do not permit us to come to this particular House and refer to a criminal as criminal. If that is what the rules permit, tell me that is what the rules say we should do. Because as a Leader, you helped me guide the House. If that is what the rules say, tell me that is what the rules say.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, guide us with the Standing Orders so that we can guide ourselves very well. Which part of our Standing Orders says that? Then we will be able to guide ourselves.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: As a Leader, are you saying that you do not know the provision in our rules that say one does not impute criminal motive? Is that what you are telling me today?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, not when a person is charged with ... and

the person went on plea bargain. It is an established fact, so that is why I want you to guide me. The person was charged with ...

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, kindly withdraw.

Mr Darko-Mensah: Thank you, Mr Speaker. Can I use the word [*Expunged by Order of Mr Speaker*] so that I can take away the ...? Can I use that word? If I can use that word, I can go on with that.

So, Mr Speaker, that amount of money, GH¢5.7 billion —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I am urging upon you; you can decide to disobey my order to withdraw the word ...

Mr Darko-Mensah: Mr Speaker, I have withdrawn ... and replaced it with ...

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Criminally what?

Mr Darko-Mensah:

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, withdraw the word ... [*Uproar*]

Mr Darko-Mensah: Mr Speaker, I am guided and I have withdrawn it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The word is withdrawn and expunged from the record.

Mr Darko-Mensah: Mr Speaker, that amount of money — I have withdrawn

the ... based on your guidance. Mr Speaker, can I use the word? That amount of money, GH¢5.7 billion could have been used to make sure that NIB survived. So, what the Government of Ghana has currently done is no news because there were other banks that have gone in the red that we were able to support them to stand. Examples are OmniBSIC, UMB, ADB, and Prudential Bank. So, Mr Speaker, whatever has been done for NIB is worthwhile because we have done it for other banks and there is nothing wrong doing it for NIB. Mr Speaker, this has always been in the works and I believe that that is the way to go.

Mr Speaker, one other area that Hon George Weku Ricketts-Hagan have deliberated on has to do with the issue of Gold Board. Mr Speaker, we know for a fact that he was a Minister in the first government of President John Dramani Mahama. He never brought up the idea of gold reserves.

Mr Speaker, I was a Minister in the Western Region when we started working on the gold reserve optimisation that led to the accumulation of gold of over 31 tonnes. Everybody knows that it is this gold that has been the anchor for the stabilisation of the Ghana cedi. Mr Speaker, we are clear in our mind what the Gold Reserve Programme did, what the Ghana Gold Purchase Programme did, and what the Gold for Oil programme did.

Mr Speaker, we are all in this country when the Business Development Companies (BDCs) were exchanging the

Ghana cedi for 1:19 until the Gold for Oil came into being, that reduced these figures up to 14.5 as of the time of us leaving office. Mr Speaker, it is good that the Gold Board has been put in place to consolidate the work that has already been done in the system by the Bank of Ghana which is now currently on the Gold Board and the Precious Minerals Marketing Company in Ghana (PMMC) whose name has now been changed into the Gold Board. So, they are not doing anything new. All that they are doing now is virtually accumulating more of the gold.

Mr Speaker, this country has been mining for gold for over 1,025 years when the Akan people moved and the Gonja people and Guan people moved into this part of the world. Mr Speaker, it took the ingenuity of the NPP Government to start this programme and we are improving upon it. So there is nothing wrong if we are doing such a programme for this country.

But Mr Speaker, as we speak and before that Bill became law, we said it in this House that they should wait for us and not do this overnight so we can all contribute and make it a bigger success.

Mr Speaker, one of the biggest challenges we have with the Gold Board currently is that all the miners are complaining that they are being shortchanged. The exchange rate they are getting is not helping the work they are doing. Mr Speaker, it is not the market. We need to have a market solution to this problem.

Mr Speaker, as we speak, we have said and said again that the structure and the ownership of the Gold Board itself have to change. Mr Speaker, if we take the work that COCOBOD has done with cocoa farmers and the problems they have created in cocoa communities, we know, year in, year out, cocoa farmers are crying about pricing, because the structure we have used at the COCOBOD is not working because virtually, everybody on the Board is government appointed.

Mr Speaker, if you go to Cote d'Ivoire, the structure of Cocoa and Coffee Council of Cote d'Ivoire is different. Government owns 40 per cent of the Cocoa and Coffee Council. The farmers own 30 per cent and the traders also own 30 per cent. So, when prices are being determined, it is collective. It is cooperative and then the system runs very well so, there are no complaints.

5.13 p.m.

Mr Speaker, today, in the whole of Ghana, there is one aggregator. And the aggregator, even in his hometown, there is no mining there. So, he does not even understand the system. Mr Speaker, in the Western Region, we produce 60 per cent of Ghana's gold. Yet, there is not a single aggregator in the Western Region. This is not fair because a sole aggregator would always lead to bureaucracy, and bureaucracy will lead to corruption. We need to change this if we want to sustainably ensure the Gold Board is doing its job into the long term.

Mr Speaker, I have always said, and I will say it again, that we need to decentralise the licensing of mining. We need to make sure that for every licence that we give, we have an engineer. We should make sure that the district mining committees come into being and possibly do a mobile licensing regime so that we know that every single gold that is mined can be traced and sold on the market consistently with a better Ghana gold brand, so that we are sure that people will not tag wrongly our gold.

So, Mr Speaker, this issue of traceability is something that we need to talk about. We know for a fact that the Gold Board even accept that currently they are buying some of the gold from *galamsefers*, and we need to work on it now before it becomes an international problem; before people start rejecting our gold. We need to start working now on this matter and I strongly believe that the time is now to help us move this issue forward.

Mr Speaker, the menace of *galamsefer*— The NDC made a huge promise that they would use AI to solve the *galamsefer* problem. Mr Speaker, with AI, when one asks an AI a question, within one minute, one gets an answer. It has been six months, and they have still not been able to do it. They say charity begins at home, and now that people are reporting *galamsefer* activities in the President's hometown, Bole Bamboi; they are reporting *galamsefer* activities escalation in Ellembele, I believe that the Minister and the President should go back to their hometowns and stop *galamsefer*, because we are still waiting

for the AI that the NDC promised. Ghanaians are still waiting for them to deliver on that mandate.

Mr Speaker, other issues that the Minister for Finance had raised are related to the issue of the Big Push. The Big Push, by the definition—The source of funding is oil and gas revenues and they are dedicating all that to the Big Push. So clearly the Big Push is not anything new because the oil revenues have always existed in our books to be used for infrastructure, education and the like. So, if today we decide to use all that money, the 13 billion for the Big Push, then clearly, we should all understand that it is not anything new.

Mr Speaker, if you look at the list of the Big Push, virtually every region is getting just one project. And I want to know how that would impact—Because these projects are going to be done multi-year. So, I am wondering how this is not something extraordinarily new, that the Minister should be promoting, as if nothing has happened or something new is actually going to happen in this country. So, Mr Speaker, I strongly believe that even though these are being done, they have to be careful about the Big Push Programme.

Mr Speaker, the Takoradi-Agona Nkwanta Road is a Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo project. They should not take it from us. When I was a Deputy Minister for Aviation, NDC had only done 27 per cent of Terminal 3. We never took over and said it was a NPP project. We did 73 per cent of that project, we

paid for it, but we never took it as our project. So, the NDC should not use the Big Push to swallow Nana Addo's project.

In Akan, there is a saying that goes *w'anya bi amma w'ase a emmo no korono*; do not take Nana Addo's projects as the Big Push because the sources of the funding of the Big Push are coming from—And all that they have been saying is that they do not have direct sources of funding for this. Mr Speaker, the Big Push, the revenue which is oil and gas is already there.

Mr Speaker, but did they also pay GH¢1.00 for Terminal 3? What are they talking about? They did not pay anything for Terminal 3. They know they did not pay. The Hon Member was the Ranking Member. They did not pay anything for Terminal 3. But we gave them the crown.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion, I want to say that the Minister—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I will then proceed to give the floor to Hon Emmanuel Kwasi Bedzrah. Hon Member, you have 15 minutes.

Mr Emmanuel Kwasi Bedzrah: Mr Speaker, let me use this opportunity to thank you so much and contribute to the Motion, and also make some comments on the Mid-Year Budget Review.

Mr Speaker, last year, by this time, we were told in this House that the Mid-Year Budget Review need not to be debated. Those who were in this House knew very well that the Mid-Year

Budget Review is supposed to be debated. My Colleagues today are debating the Mid-Year Budget Review, but when they were on this Side, they told us that the Mid-Year Budget Review should not be debated. What has changed? Power has changed, and we are resetting Ghana.

Mr Speaker, they were not even here when the Mid-Year Budget Review was read out. They were outside doing other things. But today, they are here debating the Mid-Year Budget Review.

Mr Speaker, I am happy to state that the resetting of Ghana is not only in our mouths, but also, we are resetting the economy. This economic resetting is affecting every area of our lives, and I can tell you that GETFund has been able to pay contractors. This has never happened before that by 2023, all contractors who are being owed up to 2023 have been paid as of now. It has never happened before. The NPP left a whopping gap in debt at GETFund.

But this Government uncapped GETFund, and as we speak, GHC4.6 billion has been paid to GETFund. That money has been used to settle the debt that the NPP Government left. This alone, Mr Speaker, tells us that we have reset Ghana and we will continue to reset Ghana.

Mr Speaker, with the Free Senior High School Programme, we all know that before the NPP left power, there were talks all over town. Students were

not fed, and things were not going well. Today, as we speak now, have they heard from any student that they have not received food? [**Some Hon Members:** No.] It is because, Mr Speaker, we are releasing money to the schools. We are not giving it to a buffer stock person to go and give them dirty or food that is rotten. Expired rice—

Mr Speaker, we are issuing cheques to the schools themselves to go to the producers and buy food that will nourish our brothers and sisters in school. This is the proper resetting we are talking about, where the economy is being reset, and not only that, but the economy is also affecting the lives of everyday Ghanaians in this country.

Mr Speaker, that is not all. When it comes to the Energy sector, I am happy to announce that from January this year to this time, 63 communities have been connected to the national grid. And if you take that, Mr Speaker, it shows clearly that in the next four years, every community in this country will be connected to the national grid. It has never happened. And they did not do it, either. NPP did not do it. We have come and we are resetting. Sixty-three communities of our various rural areas have been connected to the national grid. And I am sure, very soon, your community that does not have light will also have light.

Mr Speaker, the Electricity Company of Ghana (ECG), we all know, has problems.

5.23 p.m.

The debt ECG left is so much that if we are not careful, if we do not reset ECG, it will collapse Ghana. His Excellency John Dramani Mahama, through the Minister, has advised that we should have a private sector to support ECG to collect at least the units that we consume.

Mr Speaker, I can say that when we give the private sector participation in ECG, we can recover our debts in totality. We all know that the oil sector was plagued with a lot of trouble and most of our players in the industry have left the country, all because of one decision; to unitarize our oil bloc. When this Government came, His Excellency decided that we leave that policy and open it up. Today, as we speak now, we have major players like ExxonMobil which has come back into the industry. We have major players that have come into this country to support us. I can tell that Tullow Oil has decided to continue, and if we give them the go-ahead, new blocs will be drilled again and there will be more oil in their country.

Mr Speaker, having said that, we have noticed that the US\$1.7 billion debt that was left before our Colleagues left, that has to do with the power sector levy, we have cleared most of the debt. That is why today we can have electricity hanging on our walls. There are no power outages as it used to be. This alone tells us that this Government is doing what needed to be done.

Having said that, one of the things that I noticed was that, last three years, the Minister for Finance came to this House with all kinds of quotations. In fact, this year's Budget and even the Review, there was no quotation in it. There is no Bible quotation, but the last two years and three years, there were quotations and all those quotations did not amount to anything. It was rather throwing dust into the eyes of Ghanaians. People were wearing white to give us economic policies with biblical directions. Today, I have only one quotation to quote. Even though the Minister for Finance did not come out with a quotation, I have only one quotation. That quotation is found in the book of Proverbs 29:2. Mr Speaker, with your permission, it says:

“When the righteous rule, the people rejoice.”

We could see the joy of God in the life of Ghanaians. All because the quotation is not in the Budget Statement, but it is in the heart of the leader and the leader does good to the people.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, I thank you so much for the opportunity.

Nana Agyei Baffour Awuah (NPP — Manhyia South): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity.

It is obvious that after eight years in opposition, our learned Friends have not learnt anything. They are back to their unprecedented ways and touting of achievements that do not even exist. We saw it. Before they were booted out in

2016, they told Ghanaians that they had done what was unprecedented. They published green books and were dancing in supposed glory that did not exist. Ghanaians quietly watched them and booted them out. They are back. It is obvious that they have not learnt anything. That is why they are touting gains that they have not contributed to in seven months.

Mr Speaker, the Deputy Majority Leader is an economist; he knows very well that no economic programme or policy bears fruit in seven months. They know it. So, when they stand here and tout supposed gains and achievements, they know that it is born out of confusion. Because no economic programme bears fruit in seven months. It is obvious that they are back to their propaganda ways. For them, governance is government of propaganda, of propagandists with propaganda. So, they are back to it again. Even before the Gold Board Bill was passed, they were telling the people of this country, that because of the operations of the Gold Board, the cedi has stabilised. How can they operationalise something which is not in operation? Tell us, how? It is only with them, because for them, governance is all about propaganda. They are back at it again. They are so fixated with the New Patriotic Party (NPP) that they have suddenly taken up a course of study known as NPP Governance and Economic Studies. So instead of focussing on Government, instead of governing, all they talk about is NPP did this or NPP did that. They have the power, so they should govern and let us see.

Mr Speaker, on 20th March this year, when they brought the Budget to this House, we told them that the Big Push did not have details. But because they have the numbers, they sat there and said, “*Hear! Hear!*”. Today, we have been vindicated by the Minister for Finance. He has now provided the details of the supplementary Budget he brought. They have numbers; we have insights. What we see sitting down, they standing on each other in multitudes of 187 do not even see.

Mr Speaker, it is obvious that they are still stuck in their propaganda ways and so, with the details of their Big Push, and priority projects, they have told everybody and have made everybody believe that they are going to complete the military hospital in Kumasi, in the Ashanti Region, but they brought their Budget for the Ashanti Region and it is not even here. It is not part of the priority projects. Yet, His Excellency the President, went to Manhyia to promise Otumfuo that he was going to complete it. During the graduation of the Officers Cadet, the President again said it, on the 11th April, that he was going to complete the military hospital. Yet, their priority projects which they have planned to complete by 2028, the military hospital, is not here. They are deceiving the people that gave them the second highest number of votes in this country.

5.33 p.m.

All the things they told them were not true; they were not true. They are not even here; they gave them more than

715,000 votes which is the second highest. Yet, they are deceiving them.

Mr Speaker, we need to move away from the propaganda and govern. They are back at it; we are learning in humility and we will come back better. They told us they were going to establish the Women's Development Bank, but there is nothing in the Budget. The 24-Hour Economy Policy is zero. All the things they said they were going to do, they are pursuing and pushing them with propaganda. It is just a matter of time and they will be exposed. I do not need facts; do I need facts? It is enough that all the things are not here. I do not need further evidence to demonstrate to the people of Ghana that they are back at their propaganda ways. 419—They are back at their propaganda ways. Government of settings—QNET Government.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, what is “419”?

Nana Baffour Awuah: Mr Speaker, very respectfully, you are entitled to take judicial notice of “419”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, the *Hansard* will bear me out that while at this Side, I used the word “419” and I was asked to withdraw. So, kindly do the same by withdrawing.

Nana Baffour Awuah: All right, Mr Speaker, I withdraw and substitute it with QNET. It is important that we give meaning to democracy and let Ghanaians begin to have hope in democracy and not make it seem that it is government as usual and not make it seem that it was

because they desperately wanted to come to government that is why they made all those promises to them. That is what it seems now: that because they desperately wanted to come into government, they kept making promises to them; that is what it seems—*[Interruption]*—They have the steer; they should govern and let us see. Ghanaians are watching them.

Mr Speaker, we need to protect our democracy by keeping our word. It is increasingly becoming obvious that the confidence of Ghanaians in politicians is running out because of things like these. So, Mr Speaker, very respectfully, I would commend the Minister for Finance for taking a cue from us; he should continue to take a cue and I would urge, in conclusion, my Brothers on the other Side that instead of joining the chorus of “Hear! Hear!”, they should open their eyes—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I will then proceed to give the floor to Hon Zuwera Ibrahimah. You have ten minutes.

Ms Zuwera Mohammed Ibrahimah (NDC — Salaga South): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the debate on the Mid-Year Fiscal Policy Review submitted to this august House by the very able Minister for Finance, Hon Dr Ato Forson.

I have been listening to my Brother and you can see because it is very clear and everyone can see how worked up he is. Mr Speaker, Dr Ato Forson is causing

stress; he is causing pressure and our Brothers and Sisters are under serious pressure. I do not drink alcohol; as you know, I am a Muslim. But anytime I have gone out with my friends, I have heard them tell their friends who are drinking wine to make sure that they have a glass of water close by, just in case they get dehydrated. So, it looks to me like our Brother over there, probably, has a—
[Expunged by orders of Mr Speaker]. All I heard, Mr Speaker, in his submission—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Ibrahimah Zuwera, do the needful. Please, withdraw.

Ms Ibrahimah: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I am guided.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is accordingly ordered expunged from the record.

Ms Ibrahimah: All I heard over and over, Mr Speaker, was propaganda again and I am wondering how this beautiful document that they ran away from represents propaganda. Mr Speaker, when you refuse to attend lectures and you enter the lecture room and the question that is thrust to you says you should describe an antelope and because you did not come for the lecture and your father rears rabbits at home, you say, “At this juncture, what is a rabbit?” That is exactly what my Brother is doing.

Mr Speaker, instead of focusing on the substance of the Budget Statement, he is beating about the bush, talking about propaganda all over. Dr Ato

Forson did not engage in propaganda on the 24th July, 2025. He came to this very respected House and presented to us the true state of this country what he and the Mahama Government have done since 7th January when they assumed office as Government of this country.

Mr Speaker, how do they walk out of a Budget presentation and come back to debate it? Mr Speaker, I am not a lawyer, but I know that when you run away from service, judgement will be made against you and that is why our Brothers are found wanting. They realised that, yes, they ran away, but the debate was going to ensue, so they have come and they are trying very hard but unsuccessfully to—
[Interruption]—No, they would try but make zero impact of their debate.

Mr Speaker, in communication theory, face-to-face communication is always the best method; nothing comes close to face-to-face communication. The Hon Minister was here; he presented a Statement. We all sat here and watched him. We saw him; we saw the cues; we examined the body language; we heard his choice of words and they resonated with us. It is the most enduring form of communication. So, if they choose not to engage in a face-to-face but decide to rely on two-step flow, again, another communication theory, hearsay—I take it and I tell Hon Rachel; then we add pepper here; we take out sugar; we put too much milk and then we distort the communication. That is what our Brothers are suffering: *akεε akεε*. They should have sat here, listened to Dr Ato Forson and watched him as he presented the Budget. They would have made more

meaning of what the Minister for Finance said.

5.43 p.m.

Mr Speaker, I will urge my brothers that yes, walkout and boycott remain a tool, but they must watch it.

Their constituents are watching them. By walking out on the Mid-Year Review of the Budget Statement, they told their constituents that they are not happy for them, but I know that their constituents are very happy with the work of Dr Ato Forson. Everybody in this country is very happy with the work of Dr Ato Forson in managing the economy.

Mr Speaker, this morning, on *Atinka Radio*, as I drove here, a gentleman called in; he says he is called Frimpong Nana. He said,

Ah, na ye se Minorityfoɔ no se Budget no nnye? Na aden enye Ghana ha na yen nyinaa ye te? Na me ba kɔ sukuu a, me de GH¢600 ye shito a, me nnya bottles four. Enne, the same GH¢600 me de ye shito no, me nya eight bottles. Ekyere se anwa boɔ aba fɔm; tomatoes boɔ aba fɔm; Keta school boys boɔ aba fɔm; mako boɔ aba fɔm; ginger boɔ aba fɔm.

That is what the man said on radio. Mr Speaker, to wit, he said the Minority cannot pretend that they have not seen what is happening in this country. That he used to spend GH¢600 to prepare

shito for his child before January this year and he always got four bottles. With the same GH¢600 today, Mr Speaker, he makes eight bottles of *shito*. What that means is that the price of Frytol oil, tomatoes, pepper, ginger, garlic and everything has reduced, so he is making more *shito* with GH¢600.

So, if they sit in this Chamber — and these people voted for them to come here to protect their interests — and they say that as for them, that news is not good news for them, as the Akans will say, *enie woara wo gyegyeregye*. They will go and meet them there. I challenge my Brothers and Sisters on the other Side to go to their constituencies and call town hall meetings and listen to what their constituents will tell them and check whether it resonates with their own activities in this Chamber. They are the people who brought us here and we have a duty to protect their interests.

Mr Speaker, on premix fuel, I have managed the Salaga South Constituency for four years and this is my fifth year and at every turn, the issue of premix was a huge headache. Everybody who picked their phone called the Member of Parliament (MP) to find out why they were not getting premix.

Mr Speaker, they bought petrol and diesel and mixed it in a certain ratio to fuel their engine boats to go fishing. Today, premix is all over the place. Nobody is quarrelling about premix. Our fisherfolks are able to go on their fishing activities without stress to the MP. So, if one is an MP on the Minority Side and their constituency sits along the Volta

Lake or at Elmina and they are not happy, then I do not know what will make them happy.

Mr Speaker, the Hon Minister for Finance announced the construction of a bridge across the Volta Lake at Dambai and the people of the Eastern Corridor, including my beloved Salaga South people, are over-whelmed; we are excited. We are excited because, Mr Speaker, once that bridge is constructed— I travel seven hours from Accra to Salaga.

I do not have to go and wait at Dambai for the ferry and be told that the ferry is broken down. Sometimes the ferry comes, but an articulated truck full of yams and other goodies has blocked the way, created a problem, the raft cannot be lifted and one is stuck behind the lake.

This is a crossing that takes just 25 minutes, but people who travel in commercial vehicles from Accra to my constituency leave Accra at 4.00 p.m. and only arrive in Salaga between 11.00 a.m. and 1.00 p.m. the following day. Why? They get to Dambai and they have to sleep behind the lake until the next morning. There are lactating mothers, pregnant women and women—

Mr Shaib —*rose*—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up. Yes, I will give the floor to Hon Asenso-Boakye; you are speaking for 15 minutes.

Yes, Hon Ahmed Shaib?

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Mr Speaker, this is just to, first of all, commend you for directing our Sister to withdraw those unprintable words. I am just calling your attention to this House; it is an august House, so our debates should flow and it should be free of any insults or any form of unprintable words. I think that we should be very decorous in our submissions so that we can move on. We are brothers and sisters and that is my prayer. If a person stands here and says certain things, when we go out, people take them differently.

Mr Speaker—*[Interruption]*—he does not want me to repeat that. Let us just be decorous, that is all.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you are right. I entreat everybody to read Standing Order 123.

Yes, Hon Asenso-Boakye, you have the floor.

Mr Francis Asenso-Boakye (NPP — Bantama): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the debates on the 2025 Mid-Year Fiscal Policy Review, particularly on the important subject matter of road development.

Mr Speaker, as a former Minister for Roads and Highways and also a member of the Committee on Roads and Transportation, I have had the opportunity to carefully look at the list of projects presented under what the Government calls the “Big Push” Programme. And I must say, Mr Speaker, with the greatest of respect, this so-much-talked-about push is not balanced, big or strategic. I say this

because I believe strongly that it is just a political programme, rather than an economic-efficient programme.

Mr Speaker, the list of roads is heavily skewed towards certain regions in the country, completely neglecting Greater Accra and the Ashanti Region. These regions are the most urbanised and densely populated regions. The two regions alone account for over 35 per cent of the Ghanaian population and the economic heartbeat of our country. If they are embarking on a road programme to promote economic development and they conspicuously eliminate these particular regions, how are they going to explain this to Ghanaians?

Mr Speaker, earlier, the Hon Minister was in the Northern Region and said that the deployment of roads by the previous Administration was concentrated on certain regions. I believe he was referring to the Ashanti and Greater Accra Regions. I think that it makes sense, but he went ahead to say that this time around, he was going ahead to also do other regions, in terms of the roads. For me, that is not fair to the country.

That is not strategic, because we build roads where there are human beings and densely populated communities. We build roads which will connect economic centres that will drive economic development and economic growth. So, for him to say that it is concentrated on the densely populated region is not fair and it is not the kind of development that will bring collective development in the country.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, did you say there are no human beings?

Mr Asenso-Boakye: No, I said they are not densely populated regions—
[Some Hon Members: Ah!]—

Mr Speaker, let us not belittle the point I am making. The point I am making is that—

5.53 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, I just asked a question. My attention has been drawn to something. So, we can do the honourable thing.

Did you say there are no human beings?

Mr Asenso-Boakye: I did not hear—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Did you say there are no human beings in those regions?

Mr Asenso-Boakye: No. What I meant, if I—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No, Hon Member, did you say so or you did not say so?

Mr Asenso-Boakye: Let me speak. Mr Speaker, I do not want that to distract the very important point that I am making. If I said there are no human beings, that is not what I meant. I withdraw that. But listen to exactly what I mean—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The word is withdrawn.

Mr Asenso-Boakye: Let us not belittle the very important point I am trying to make. Mr Speaker, the work that I have done—*[Interruption]*—Mr Speaker, I hope you are noting the distractions. The work that I have done in this country, whether in public or private office, I have had the experience of travelling across the country. *[Uproar]*

There are some roads—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Order! Order!

Hon Members, apart from Hon Asenso-Boakye, all others should resume their seats. All others, kindly resume your seats. Kindly resume your seats, apart from Hon Asenso-Boakye.

Hon Asenso-Boakye, you have the floor.

Mr Asenso-Boakye: Mr Speaker, the work that I have done in my life, whether public or private, has taken me around this country. There are some places one can travel for 50 to 100 kilometres and one will not see communities and human beings. But there are some places that you travel 30 kilometres and you will see densely populated communities and economic centres. This is where we should build our roads when we have limited resources.

Mr Speaker, basic economic theory teaches us that when resources are scarce, when we are in financial

constraints, we prioritise and that is exactly what I am saying. If my opponents do not understand this, I do not know what else they will understand.

Mr Speaker, I also see abandonment of strategic ongoing roads under the Big Push Programme. Mr Speaker, the Hon Minister for Roads and Highways today rightly acknowledged that the Accra-Kumasi Road is the most—As a planner, I would call it the most important road in the country. The road with the most traffic. And already, as a result of efforts to bring interventions to increase mobility and enhance traffic flow, there are series of interventions on that corridor. One of such interventions is the rehabilitation of the existing road. Many parts are deteriorating. I am an MP from Kumasi, every week I am on the road. There are ongoing interventions on that particular road. As I speak, the Big Push did not capture that.

Mr Speaker, another area that the Big Bush did not capture is the ongoing bypasses. There are four important bypasses going on; one at Osino, one at Anyinam, one at Enyiresi, and one at Konongo. Mr Speaker, yesterday I came from Kumasi, and when I reached Konongo, I spent over two hours in traffic in Konongo. This is because the interventions are being implemented. Listen to me. As we speak, these bypasses have achieved very significant achievement rates. For instance, bypass from Osino, the south bound, has achieved 78 per cent. Osino north bound, 68 per cent. Anyinam bypass, 58 per cent. Anyinam bypass north bound, 100 per cent. So, they have all achieved

significant completion rates. Mr Speaker, what stops the Government from completing these bypasses that will reduce the travel time from Accra to Kumasi by three hours? Now the Minister is saying that they would construct a six-lane expressway which is totally different from the existing intervention.

First of all, with the greatest of respect to the President, he was in Kumasi a couple of weeks ago—*[Interruption]*—Will they listen to me? Listen to sense. Listen to wisdom— *[Uproar]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Asenso-Boakye,

Mr Asenso-Boakye: Listen to words of wisdom, and stop the heckling.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Order! Order!

Hon Asenso-Boakye, to say that they should “listen to sense”. Please, kindly withdraw “listen to sense”.

Mr Asenso-Boakye: What I mean is that they should listen to words of wisdom.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Kindly withdraw “listen to sense”.

Mr Asenso-Boakye: Mr Speaker, I am being distracted. They are not allowing it to flow, because they know I am making a good point. Because they know I am making a good point.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Asenso-Boakye, will you withdraw “listen to sense”?

Mr Asenso-Boakye: Mr Speaker, I withdraw “listen to sense” and replace it with “listen to words of wisdom”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. You can make progress.

Mr Asenso-Boakye: Mr Speaker, basic economic theory tells us that when resources are scarce, we have to prioritise and already, there are existing interventions. If we are able to complete these bypasses, it will reduce the travel time by three hours, then what will be left is 98 kilometres of undualised road. For me, that is where the Government should concentrate on and complete. Once that is completed, we will have a dualised road from Accra to Kumasi.

But the President was in Kumasi the other day. With the greatest of respect, he said that they would construct a new expressway and he went ahead to say that it will start next year and it will be completed at the end of his term. Mr Speaker, the Minister for Roads and Highways is here today and he told the media that they have now hired a consultant to do feasibility studies. If they have not conducted feasibility studies, it means they do not know the extent of the work and how much it will cost. On what basis did the President tell the nation that the project will start next year and complete at the end of his term? What it means is that the Minister did not brief the President well. He got the President confused and he made the President only make a path rather than a rational statement.

Mr Speaker, there are also some critical roads that have been started that this Big Push Programme has not captured. One of such roads is Kokoben-Anhwia Nkwanta Road. It is very important. Those of you who ply the Kumasi to Obuasi Road, you can sit in traffic for about five hours. And last year, we began the construction of this road and the Big Push refused to capture it.

There is also Sawla-Wa that the contract was signed last year. Sawla-Wa is a very important road. The Big Push did not capture the road. Atebubu-Kwame Danso, when I was a Minister, that road was under construction. Hon Twumasi is here, when I was a Minister, that road was under construction. It was not captured under the Big Push Programme. Mr Speaker, the impact of this neglect is not abstract. It will affect productivity. It will affect national growth and it will affect development.

Mr Speaker, another important one is the interchange. I have seen one or two interchanges that were not captured under the Big Push. One is the Takoradi PTC. Of course, that project stopped because of the Debt Exchange Programme. It is the same as the Nungua Interchange. I was hoping that given the importance of interchanges in unlocking mobility and helping in the development of the urbanised communities.

I thought Government will capture this in the Big Push, but it is not part of it.

6.03 p.m.

Mr Speaker, I have also seen a deliberate misinformation and repackaging of existing roads as part of the Big Push, as though they initiated it. I have no problem with that. The constitution of this country, enjoins every government to continue the projects of the previous government under the directive principle of state policy. But when they do so, they should recognise who started it. Development is a relay, it is not rivalry, that one package somebody's roads that they have started and say that they are the ones doing it.

Mr Speaker, before I resume my seat, there is one thing that I also want to correct. The Minister for Finance is on record to have said that government secured loans to construct the Suame and Ofankor interchanges and we used it for other things. I think that was quite unfortunate because we were all in this House when the government brought a loan facility of US\$750 million. At that time, the Hon Minister for Finance was either the Chair of the Finance Committee or the Minority Leader, so he was part and parcel of the process. That facility was not for Ofankor and Suame Interchange Project alone but was a multi—The rest of the funds were to come from Government of Ghana financing; it was not from loans. So, it was completely misleading —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up. I am not controlling the time. I am not the timekeeper.

I will then proceed to give the floor to Hon Kwame Agbodza, Minister for Roads and Highways. *[Hear! Hear!]* Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. I saw the way the Minister for Roads and Highways sat down quietly to listen to the submissions by the former Minister for Roads and Highways. The interjections were too many and under normal circumstances, respectfully, I would not think that, at least, we should have given him a minute to even round up. I expect our people to still sit in quietude to listen and that is how it should go.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, apart from requesting that unparliamentary words have been used, I do not think I have entertained any point of order. I have not, so nobody has interjected him. More so, I am not in control of the time in any manner whatsoever.

Yes, Hon Minister for Roads and Highways?

[Uproar]

Hon Members, why?

Hon Minister, you have the floor. You have 15 minutes.

Minister for Roads and Highways (Mr Kwame Govers Agbodza) (MP): Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity and I wish my good Friend, the former Minister for roads would have been in the Chamber to listen. I will start

from where he ended. The Minister for Finance was spot on when he said that part of the monies used for the Ofankor and Suame interchanges are loans. So, I am not even sure what NPP is arguing. This House approved a loan of US\$750 million from African Export-Import Bank (Afreximbank) and said that we should use part of that money to do a Akyiama bridge. They decided to divert that and took it to Kumasi for the Suame interchange when the loan agreement for the Suame interchange fell off. So, when they argue that we are not doing the Suame and Ofankor interchanges with loan, it is difficult for me to understand. Indeed, we took some of that money to those projects, yet the projects are not completed. So, he has not said anything different. The Minister for Finance did not say that those projects were turnkey projects to be done by a loan. He says that they took a loan, paid for those projects partly from the US\$750 million Afreximbank money and that is factual. So, he has not said anything that is wrong.

Mr Speaker, my Colleague also talked about why the Prestea Township and the Cape Coast Inner City (PTC) Roads are not part of the Big Push. He knows better than I do about this. When you came to this House about that so-called barter agreement with Hon Amoako Atta on Sinohydro, we told them that was not going to work, that no one was ready to take our bauxite and give us road. They said it was the most fantastic with former Vice President Bawumia holding a calabash in China, that we have gotten GH¢15 billion. It turns out that they came back here to

convert the so-called barter agreement to a loan. Guess what? Sinohydro got angry and stopped working because when they raise certificate, we are unable to pay them. So, we have to go to China and beg them that they should come back. And let me tell them this, it is true that Sinohydro has listened. They have decided to sign the agreement and they will be back to do the PTC roundabout project. So, you cannot put a project which is already with Sinohydro under the Big Push. That is why it is not part of it and he should know better about that.

Mr Speaker, I also heard him also saying that we are trying to rubbish President Akufo-Addo's record of 10,800 km. He was not here. He was standing here and said we have built 10,800 km of new roads and he was doing us like that and I fact-checked him. I was the Ranking Member and I fact-checked him. It was a lie. He never built 10,800 km.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, withdraw the word “it was a lie”.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, I will not even belabour the point. I withdraw the “lie”. What the President said here was untrue. He never built 10,800km of new roads. And guess what? He compelled the Ministry to issue a statement and the statement says that, let me read. Hon Asenso-Boakye can cross-check because he still has some people at the Ministry. And this is what the Ministry issued that “Road Ministry confirms construction of 10,875 km of new roads under President Akufo-Addo” by Joy FM. This is

because he compelled them to do that. Fortunately, the Public Relations Officer (PRO) who issued the statement is still my PRO today. I do not know how he feels today by issuing that statement and the reality of the day. You understand? So, your press statement was needless. In fact, they are confirming what I have said.

Mr Speaker, my Brother has been a Minister for Roads and Highways for the Republic of Ghana. I want to give him a small advice. It does not sit well where all his examples appear as if he has not been to any other place in the country. It does not look well. Yes, I agree, Accra-Kumasi has the biggest volume of traffic in the country. But when he gives the impression that just because that is the biggest volume, what about the farmer growing yam in Yendi? Do we not have to take a road there to convey the yam for us to consume in Accra? So, he thinks that just because there are more people in Accra and Kumasi, we should spend all our money on Accra and Kumasi? Okay, let me give him this, the reset of President Mahama means that we are not—My Brother—[Uproar]—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please, Hon Member, resume your seat.

Hon Minister, you have the floor?

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, my good Friend, the former Minister for Roads and Highways should just learn from his Leader. Before I took the podium, he advised that when he was speaking, I never even moved my body. I listened to him. I do not know why he is feeling

uncomfortable. He should just stay calm. Let me tell him this. And then he went as far as saying that we build roads where human beings are. I went round the 16 regions. When I got to the Oti region, there was no active road project going on in the Oti region. Is that fair? Guess what? Reset means that we are taking road infrastructure to every part of the country. And if he does not like it, he can do whatever he likes when he comes back, he can decide not to do road there.

We shall take road everywhere we like—*[Hear! Hear!]*

6.13 p.m.

Mr Speaker, they are not actually listening to themselves. In one vein, they are complaining that we are not taking on some projects on Big Push. On another vein, they are saying that some of the projects we are taking on as Big Push are their projects. Which is which? Do they want us to do the project or not? What the Minister for Finance said here was quite clear. We had our own plan for Big Push. Let me tell them this, every single region in our country is touched by the proposed Big Push project, unlike a few years ago when the former Minister for Finance, Hon Ken Ofori-Atta stood here and completely ignored Volta Region in the critical roads. *[Hear! Hear!]* Completely. Do they remember that? That happened here. All the 16 regions are touched by the Big Push.

Let me repeat once again, Big Push is not a constituency-specific project or a political gimmick. As Hon Member has been a former Minister for Roads and

Highways, he should take for instance, the road from Wenchi to Wa. He travels that road. How does he feel? It is completely neglected. He should take from Wa to Bolgatanga. The reason we do not find vehicles on Wa to Bolgatanga is because it is a death trap. Yes, I agree with him, one can drive for hours and one will not even see any vehicle. It is because the road is terrible. When the road is good, people ply it. So, if President Mahama decides that in about two years, we shall reconstruct the road from Bolgatanga to Wa, what is wrong with that? I agree that sections of that road are currently under contract; just sections. A vast majority of it is not under contract. So, Big Push is a national programme to address the inefficiencies along the major corridors. They talked about—Which region is not captured? So, when we want to do a bypass around Kumasi, the eastern quadrant—

Currently, when one is from Accra going to Kumasi or one is even going to the north, one needs to drive straight into Kumasi and get stuck in the traffic. We are saying that we are building a bypass. The first portion of the bypass is when one gets to Ejisu, one would do a detour at the back of Anita Hotel, and then take that quadrant all the way to hit the Mampong road. What is wrong with that? We started the Sunyani Ring Road and when the NPP came, they abandoned it. We are saying we are going to complete it. What is wrong with that? Tamale is one of the fastest-growing cities in West Africa. When one goes to Tamale now, moving around is a problem. We are saying we are

completing and expanding the third Ring Road. What is wrong with that?

Now, let us come to Accra. I agree that the exit and entry points of Accra are very bad. The Ofankor Road as of the time NPP was leaving office, the contractor had raised a certificate of US\$77 million. The NPP did not pay him; they left. Now people are doing demonstrations. Just this week, we paid that contractor over GHC300 million, so that he can continue the work. Why are they not commending us for that? And then we are saying that since we do not have any dedicated fund, we are putting that project as an additional burden on the Big Push and they do not like it?

They should go to Kasoa-Winneba. Of course, the money has run out. The worst that will happen is that the contractor will leave site. President Mahama does not want any of those projects to be abandoned. He said we should carry it on as additional Big Push Project. Do they not like that? What are we talking about here?

I also heard them talking about motorway to Central University. The Hon former Minister and I know that when he came to this House to give that contract to BHM Construction International Limited, I suggested that BHM Construction International Limited was not a construction firm; it was a management firm. It was only last year that that company bought a construction firm. That is why they were struggling to do the road. Phase one is what they are struggling to do. The phase two is not

even an NPP initiated project. The phase two is not under contract and we are carrying it on as a Big Push Project.

Mr Speaker, they should understand this thing: we are quite clear in our minds what we are doing. It is not politics. I agree with him, he did his best, but the contractors were not listening to him because maybe he was afraid of them. I say if one is a contractor, whether Ghanaian or foreign, and they breach our laws, we will deal with them. That is why when I stood here and said that I will not terminate the contract of the Indian company that took our US\$30 million—They either build a road worth US\$30 million or we would find ways of taking our money. They cannot take all of our money. It does not matter. We are taking our money. So, the Hon Member should help me retrieve the US\$30 million that was supposed to be used to do Savelugu-Walewale Road. Where is Dr Kabiru? He should help me retrieve the money because I need that money to pay contractors who have worked and are not being paid. I do not know why the Minority Side is not helping me to do this.

There is something I need to explain. Big Push is not the only road project we are doing. I want to say this to all our compatriots across the country; Big Push is a special vehicle to address the interconnectivity of our regions to our national capital. It is not about Adaklu or Suame or anything. In any case, I have also heard the Suame Interchange—*[Interruption]*—Yes, the loan for Suame Interchange is a turnkey and a commercial agreement. When the NPP

declared themselves bankrupt, the contractor decided that the bank said they will not give us the money. When they said we should complete it, with money from where? But even that, President Mahama says we should take it on. We are taking on the completion of the Suame Interchange as part of Big Push. What is their problem about that?

Mr Speaker, the other thing that we need to deal with is, there is this lack of understanding about some over 160 districts that we have identified as the most deprived of roads. We are saying that some of those districts are largely agrarian in terms of their economic activity: yam growing areas, rice growing areas, and other foods we consume. We are saying that, instead of spending 70 per cent of our road budget on building additional interchanges in Accra and Kumasi, the real economic value of our country comes from agriculture and mining and tourism, so let us tap into those things. So, we have identified those 160 districts, and we are saying that out of equity, we shall devote more resources to upgrade the roads in those districts. That is what we are talking about. It is Ken Ofori-Atta under the NPP who declared the country bankrupt.

Let me conclude with this, Hon former Minister for Roads and Highways. The situation of our roads in Ghana is a very terrible one and I want the House to join us address this. Everybody, including my Colleagues and myself, the road in our backyard is very terrible. There is nothing wrong if the Minister for Finance decides that

instead of sharing our oil resources, building Astroturfs here and there, mainly in our constituencies and districts—*[Interruption]*—Yes, the record is there. Instead of doing that, let us build roads that everybody can use. There is nothing wrong with that. Yes, Astroturf is good, but today, put Astroturf on one side and road on the other side—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, conclude.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, let me conclude by saying that, we are clear in our minds. President Mahama's reset means that the road network in our country must improve and we are making a commitment. Yes, in three weeks, we shall start the Big Push project. *[Hear! Hear!]* And indeed, *Inshallah*, the Dambai Bridge will be one of the projects that will be started. *[Hear! Hear!]* Nothing will stop it.

The last comment, Mr Speaker, is that, from now, if a contractor or a consultant partakes in road projects and does a shoddy work, the contractor or consultant will be forced to take an insurance and we shall cash the insurance if they do a bad job. All those who have taken Government money for works and have not done it, let me tell them, we are already investigating some of them. We are coming after them. *[Hear! Hear!]*. If they are thinking of doing a new project—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon, your time is up.

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, we have agreed that after doing four from each Side, we will pause the debate and take the Report of the joint Committee, the Finance and Budget Committees.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I am aware, so allow me to do four from each Side.

It is now the turn of Hon Daniel Nana Addo-Kenneth. You have 10 minutes.

6.23 p.m.

Mr Daniel Nana Addo-Kenneth (NPP — Okere): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, emanating from the last speaker, I would like to quote the Minister for Finance in his Mid-Year Budget and I want to read paragraph 575:

“To all of us who are privileged to serve in the leadership of our nation, let us unite and do this for ourselves, for our children, for our children’s children. It is our collective responsibility. Ghana needs us now more than ever and our people need us.”

Mr Speaker, I am a bit shocked that my very respected senior Minister, whom I also admire so much, would seek to raise some of the issues that he raised, especially on the Aflao Road. Mr Speaker, the Minister conceded that it was a 10-key project and BHC was a company that secured the funding, so they had to bring in their contractors. It is a bit inaccurate that BHC was just not

a contracting firm, they secured the funding, so they had to bring in their contractors.

Mr Speaker, on the Suame Interchange, at the time that we left office, the contractor was on site; Rango Construction Company Limited was on site. They never left the site until we left the office and the NDC came in. They came in to meet the contractor on-site on the Suame Interchange Project. As I read, the Minister for Finance called for unity and calling for unity means that we want to bring everybody on board. One major lamentation of this country is that successive governments tend to abandon projects that were started by the previous governments. The funding of the project is not the money of the political party in power; it is the money of Ghanaians.

Mr Speaker, for them to say that they are abandoning the ongoing Accra-Kumasi Road, which is left with just 96 kilometres for dualisation, to do a new express road, for me, is a waste of taxpayers’ money. And the Minister listed the percentage performance of this road, so why would we abandon a road that is left with only 96 kilometres of dualisation to complete and say that we would do a whole new express road while Ghanaians are using those roads? Those roads are not just leading to the Ashanti Region; they also link up north.

So Mr Speaker, if the Minister for Finance is calling all of us to come on board and unite to save this country, then I think that my Colleagues on the other Side, who are the overwhelming majority that Ghanaians have trust in

them, should not go the path that successive governments have gone by wasting the taxpayers' money. They should look at completing some of these projects.

Mr Speaker, I also want to associate with my earlier Colleague speakers on our Side. One of the major campaign messages of the NDC Government was providing employment for the teeming unemployed youth of this country. Mr Speaker, I want to be consistent; right from the inception of this Parliament to the Message on the State of the Nation and to the Budget reading, we have been consistent in talking about employment.

Mr Speaker, this Budget sought to create that Big Push, in the *Nkokɔ Nketenkete* projects, the Agriculture for Economic Transformation Agenda, the Women's Development Bank and all these programmes that are coming to create employment. Mr Speaker, the President came to this House and told the whole country that the Minister for Finance, during the presentation of the Budget, will bring the policy document for the 24-Hour Economy here, so that we will all get to know. We are seven months down the lane and Parliamentarians here do not know what the policy document for the 24-Hour Economy is.

Mr Speaker, the Minister for Finance came here, presented the Budget to us, and indicated that he will come later to this House to present the 24-Hour Economy policy document. Mr Speaker, I was expecting that, six months down the lane, when he was presenting the

Mid-Year Budget Review, he would have even added as an *addendum*, the policy statement for the 24-Hour Economy. The Mid-Year Review of the Budget Statement was read, but there was no sign of the 24-Hour Economy.

Mr Speaker, if one looks at the Budget, they termed it the Big Push. I was of the opinion that, having trumpeted the 24-Hour Economy and created one of the beautiful songs for the 24-Hour Economy, the Budget should have been named the 24-Hour Economy Budget, but they abandoned it. This is a clear indication that it was just a political campaign song and gimmick to deceive the teeming youth of this country, assuring them of jobs and employment. But coming here, they turned from the 24-Hour Economy and are now telling us that their Big Push is only purely in infrastructure and even that, for this year, it is purely 100 per cent on roads.

Mr Speaker, on the same employment, indeed, I agree with my respected Deputy Majority Leader, that in 70 years, things have happened in this country that have never happened before. Yes, we have seen the unprecedented sacking of Ghanaians from their jobs just because there is a change in government. Mr Speaker, the Minister for Finance said that we should not be divisive, but we have seen, in 70 years, the most divisive policy of sacking the young people who have received employment.

Mr Speaker, in the Budget, the Minister for Finance indicated that they were going to fully implement the net capping and freezing of net employment.

I was of the opinion that, after coming to office for six months and trumpeting all the glories of the Gold Board, the review would have talked about the fact that even the net freezing of employment would be reviewed. But the Minister for Finance was unable to tell us, as we have seen before, the number of jobs they have even created for the young people of this country— Meanwhile, they have trumpeted that they are going to create employment.

Mr Speaker, the Budget listed a number of interventions that were going to create employment. Their Budget talked about the Adwumawura Programme. The Minister for Finance came here to tell us that, out of the GH¢300 million allocated for the Adwumawura Programme, only a meagre GH¢21 million has been released. Mr Speaker, in six months, we are doing only 7 per cent of the initiatives that are going to create employment. If we want to multiply it and even give it a 20 per cent increase in the first half year, how can we hope to assure this country of?

The teeming youth of Ghana want jobs through the Adwumawura Programme, but obviously, they are all about promises and they are not talking at all because the books are telling us something else. Mr Speaker, the same Minister for Finance conceded that the programme that is going to create the Apprenticeship Programme, which is going to equip people with skills, had only a 7 per cent release.

Mr Speaker, again, the Agriculture for Economic Programme, which my very good Friend, A Plus likes talking about, the *Nkokɔ Nketenkete*, their Feed Ghana, their vegetable development and all that. Mr Speaker, as at now, GH¢1.5 billion was allocated and the Ghanaian youth were so happy, but as we speak, zero per cent has been released, not even one *kobo* has been released. Yet, we have assured this country of employment.

Mr Speaker, I am passionate about this employment issue. There are people in my constituency, the young men and women I grew up with, do not have employment. Those who have come before me, a lot of them do not have employment and this is a creation of successive governments. So, if the teeming youth and Ghanaians have so much confidence to believe that the way to go is the creation of employment, then this country will be let down by this NDC Government if they do not walk their talk.

Mr Speaker, six months down the lane, zero release has been given to the Women's Development Bank. Mr Speaker is a believer in affirmative action. The Eighth Parliament did so well by passing the Affirmative Action Bill. Yet, as we speak, Mr Speaker, there is a zero release and zero commitment to the Women's Development Bank. So, are they just paying lip service that they are going to create employment and empower women by giving them some support through loans and empowerment programmes, by creating a bank for them? Women were so happy; they were so enthusiastic about that with this

Budget that they were going to, at least, have a dedicated fund just for women. But Mr Speaker, six months down the lane, it is zero.

Mr Speaker, again, the One Million Coders Programme, in the world of artificial intelligence (AI) and Information, Communication and Technology (ICT), we all believe that one can sit in the comfort of their home and work. Mr Speaker, we have recently heard a very humorous way of defining coding by our Deputy Minister-designate for Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations which is trending on Twitter and all the social media platforms. But again, zero per cent has been released.

Mr Speaker, in concluding, what I am saying is that this Government should not pay lip service to its promises. The youth of this country need jobs. This Government promised the youth of this country jobs and jobs they must provide. And like I said, the Ghanaian youth will not forgive the NDC Government and the overwhelming 188 Majority if they do not oversee the Government to implement the policies that will create jobs for the teeming youth of this country for what they promised.

They promised to create jobs and Mr President, please, give us the jobs you promised.

6.33 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us come to page 4 of the Order Paper – Motion. Yes, Chairman of the Committee, the item numbered 9.

Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah: Mr Speaker, if they are not ready, I am ready to move the Motions numbered 11 and 12 on the Order Paper of today.

Suspension of Order 104(1)

Co-Chairman of the Committee (Mr Isaac Adongo): Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

That notwithstanding the provision of Order 104(1) of the Standing Orders which requires that a motion shall not be debated until at least two sitting days have elapsed after the notice to move the motion is given, the motion for the adoption of the Report of the Joint Committee on Budget and Finance on the Request for the Multi-Year Commitments for the Selected Road Projects under the “Big Push” Programme contained in the Mid-Year Fiscal Policy Review of the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana may be *moved* today.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Motion has been moved; any seconder?

Vice Chairman of the Committee (Mr Alexander Agyare): Mr Speaker, I rise to second the Motion.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved accordingly.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The Motion numbered 10 at page 5 of the Order Paper. Yes, Chairman of the Committee?

**Request for the Multi-Year
Commitments for the Selected
Road Projects Under the Big
Push Programme**

**Co-Chairman of the Committee
(Mr Isaac Adongo):** Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

That this honourable House adopts the Report of the Joint Committee on Budget and Finance on the Request for the Multi-Year Commitments for the Selected Road Projects under the “Big Push” Programme contained in the Mid-Year Fiscal Policy Review of the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana.

Mr Speaker, in so doing, I present the Report of the Committee.

1.0 Introduction

The Mid-Year Fiscal Policy Review of the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy Statement of the Government of Ghana (GoG) was presented to the House by the Hon Minister for Finance, Dr Cassiel Ato Forson on Thursday, 24th July, 2025, in accordance with Section 28 of the Public Financial Management Act, 2016 (Act 921). Included in the Mid-Year Fiscal

Policy Review Statement was a request by the Minister for Finance for the approval of Multi-Year Commitments in accordance with Section 33 of the Public Financial Management Act, 2016 (Act 921).

The Rt Hon Speaker referred the Mid-Year Review Statement to the Joint Committee on Budget and Finance on the same day Thursday, 24th July, 2025, for consideration and Report.

2.0 Deliberations

The Joint Committee met with the Hon Deputy Minister for Finance, Mr Thomas Nyarko Ampem, and the technical team from the Ministry of Finance to deliberate on the Report. The Committee is grateful to the Hon Deputy Minister and the officials for attending upon the Committee.

3.0 Reference Documents

The Committee referred to the following documents:

- i. The 1992 Constitution;
- ii. The Public Financial Management Act, 2016 (Act 921);
- iii. The Appropriation Act, 2025 (Act 1126);
- iv. The Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana for the year ended 31st December, 2025;

- v. The 2025 Mid-Year Fiscal Policy Review of the Government of Ghana for the 2025 Financial Year; and
- vi. The Standing Orders of Parliament.

- (a) is with the prior written approval of the Minister, and
- (b) authorised by Parliament in accordance with article 181 of the Constitution which here, refers to transactions that are financed from foreign loans.

4.0 Background

Further to the presentation of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana for the year ended 31st December, 2025, the Minister for Finance indicated to the House that Government will roll out its “Big Push” Programme. The Programme is intended for the continuation of massive national infrastructure development to boost growth and create sustainable jobs.

Government accordingly programmed activities under the Big Push Programme as part of the expenditure to be incurred in the year 2025. The activities were captured in the 2025 Budget Statement as multi-year expenditure.

Section 33 of the Public Financial Management Act, 2016 (Act 921) provides as follows:

“Multi-year expenditure commitments

33. (1) A covered entity shall not enter into any agreement with a financial commitment that binds the Government for more than one financial year or that results in a contingent liability except where the financial commitment or the contingent liability

- (2) Parliament may, in the annual budget, authorize a covered entity to make a multi-year expenditure commitment, and where Parliament so authorises, the annual budget shall indicate the commitment approved for the financial year and the approved multi-year commitments.
- (3) A multi-year expenditure commitment approved under subsection (2) shall be consistent with the objectives of the Fiscal Strategy Document.
- (4) The Minister shall, in accordance with section 25, submit to Parliament a report on the performance of the multi-year expenditure commitments made for each financial year.
- (5) A Principal Spending Officer may propose or commit to invest in a project only after expert assessment has been completed and the justification for the investment project and efficiency is established”.

It is in compliance with Section 33 of Act 921 that the Minister responsible for Finance has submitted the said Request to Parliament for approval.

4.1 Purpose of the Request

The purpose of the Request is to seek approval for Government's multi-year commitments under the Big Push for the years 2025, 2026, 2027 and 2028 under Domestic Financing.

5.0 Observations

5.1 Rationale for the Request

The Committee observed that as part of the 2025 Budget Statement, Government announced the commencement of the Big Push Programme for massive infrastructure development seeking to improve the road infrastructure in the Country.

To ensure successful implementation, Government has resolved and dedicated all oil revenues and mineral royalties to the Programme. The Deputy Minister for Finance informed the Committee that the amount of GH¢13.8 billion, allocated to the "Big Push" Programme, forms part of the 2025 Appropriation of GH¢293,118,026,137 already approved by the House in the Appropriation Act, 2025 (Act 1126).

The technical team informed the Committee that the Ministry of Roads and Highways had undertaken feasibility studies, prepared engineering interventions and cost estimates for the road projects under the Programme. The Ministry of Finance has also commenced the issuance of commencement authorisation for the projects. The road projects would span multiple calendar years and are expected to be completed in 2028.

In his Mid-Year Review Statement (paragraphs 469 to 477), the Minister requested the House to approve the multi-year commitments for the road projects to be undertaken under the Programme, in accordance with Section 33 of Act 921. As already stated, Section 33 of Act 921 requires Parliamentary approval before a covered entity can enter into a multi-year expenditure commitment and it is in line with the provision that the Request is being made. The Parliamentary approval being sought will enable the Ministry of Finance and the Ministry of Roads and Highways enter into multi-year contracts to undertake the road projects as indicated in the 2025 Budget for the financial year and the Mid-Year Review Statement.

5.2 List of Projects to be Undertaken

The Committee observed that the road projects to be undertaken under the Big Push Programme are listed in paragraph 475 of the 2025 Mid-year Review Statement.

The Deputy Minister indicated to the Committee that the list in the Mid-year Review Statement inadvertently omitted three projects under the Programme. They were,

- i. The construction of the 3' Ring Road, Tamale Ph 1 (1 km) Lot 1.
- ii. The construction of the 3' Ring Road, Tamale Ph 1 (1 km) — Lot 2.
- iii. The construction of the 3" Ring Road, Tamale Ph 1 (1km) Lot 3.

The Ministry subsequently submitted a revised list of road projects to be undertaken under the Big Push Programme. The revised list is attached to the Report as an Appendix.

5.3 Terms and Conditions for the Projects

The technical team informed the Committee that even though the Ministry of Roads had finished with its feasibility studies; the assessments only gave Government indicative costs but not the actuals. The team informed the Committee that the actual costs and other details of the contracts would be made available after tender processes have been completed and the contracts awarded.

The Deputy Minister assured the Committee that Government would not exceed the approved amount of GH¢ 13.8 billion allocated for the projects.

5.4 Reporting on the Progress of the Road Projects

The Committee noted that pursuant to Section 33(4) of the Public Financial Management Act, 2016, the Minister for Finance is to, in accordance with section 25, submit to Parliament, a report on the performance of the multi-year expenditure commitments made for each financial year.

The Committee therefore demands that the Minister for Finance briefs the House on the project execution in compliance with the provision in Section 33(4).

5.5 Funding for the Projects

The Committee was informed that the Big Push Programme will be funded domestically and not with external funding.

5.6 Approving the Mid-Year Review Statement

The Committee observed that from paragraphs 469 to 477 of the Mid-Year Review Statement, the Minister requested the House to approve the multi-year commitments for the road projects to be undertaken under the Programme, in accordance with Section 33 of Act 921. The Committee accordingly concerned itself with the Request as contained in the Mid-Year Review Statement.

5.7 The Minority Members' Reservations about the Request for Approval

The Minority Members on both Committees were of the view that if the Ministry is seeking to comply with Section 33 of the Public Financial Management Act, 2016 (Act 921), the proper thing to do is to bring the agreements (in which the said commitments are to be made) to Parliament for approval.

The Minority Members were also concerned that the Ministry was seeking approval of the names of the projects and not the actual financial commitments associated with the projects.

The Joint Committee accordingly agreed that when the various tender and award processes for the said projects

have been completed, the Ministry would have to submit the actual financial commitments to Parliament.

5.8 Requirement for Parliamentary Approval for multi-year commitments

The Ministry indicated that the request was being made pursuant to Section 33(2) of Act 921 which provides that "Parliament may, in the annual budget, authorise a covered entity to make a multi-year expenditure commitment, and where Parliament so authorises, the annual budget shall indicate the commitment approved for the financial year and the approved multi-year commitments."

The Deputy Minister explained that Parliamentary approval is a pre-requisite to enable covered entities commit the country into multi-year contracts. It was only after the grant of the approval before covered entities could enter into contractual agreements.

Consequently, the Majority's view was that no such agreement was intended by the provision in Section 33(2) of Act 921 *supra* and further that the request pursuant to paragraph 477 of the Minister's Statement was not seeking for approval of the terms and conditions of an agreement required under Article 181(5) of the 1992 Constitution and Section 33(1) (b) of the Public Financial Management Act, 2016, (Act 921).

5.9 Conclusion

The Committee has carefully considered the Referral and it is of the opinion that

the request is in the right direction. The Committee also noted that Parliament had already approved the policy and the allocation to the "Big Push" Programme in the 2025 Budget Statement. Granting the request would enable Government enter into multi-year contracts to execute the road infrastructure projects under the Programme.

The Committee accordingly recommends to the House to approve the Request for the multi-year commitments for the selected road projects under the "Big Push" Programme contained in the Mid-Year Fiscal Policy Review of the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana, in accordance with Section 33 of the Public Financial Management Act, 2016, (Act 921).

Respectfully submitted.

Mr Speaker, the intendment of this, is that, before the Government can proceed to implement the Budget in relation to matters that give rise to multi-year expenditures, that particular Budget should be approved. The Minority were of the view that the terms and conditions of the loans that would be pursuant to this approval should have been presented to this House, but, of course, the Majority were of the view that Section 33(2) did not intend that when we are approving the Budget, we would have any agreement to approve and that we are not approving loans of international nature which requires approval under Article 181. Therefore, this is purely in line with the provisions of Section 33(2) and is properly situated.

We also noticed that the request itself is properly situated because the Minister, in moving the main Budget, indicated that he would spend GH¢13.8 billion in 2025 on multi-year commitments, GH¢17 billion in 2026, GH¢19.2 billion in 2027, and GH¢21.2 billion in 2028. Therefore, the various commitments were already approved in the Budget, but the specific lists were not attached and those lists have now been made available under this request.

Mr Speaker, we want to indicate that the Big Push is for specific years. For 2025, we have dedicated the Big Push to the road sector, so one cannot talk about a hospital in Ashanti Region and claim that they have been deceived because the Big Push is not for only 2025—*[Interruption]*—In doing so, I have the right to make to comments.

Mr Speaker, the transactions that are being approved for GH¢13.8 billion is for road sector and not hospitals, so the road sector is being approved this year. If they want to see a hospital in Ashanti Region, they should wait till the following year. So that is what will happen—*[Interruption]*—They are uncomfortable when we catch them. When they do propaganda and we catch them, then they are running away. In presenting my Report, I have the right to make comments and my comments are to the effect—

Mr Speaker, I would request the *Hansard* to capture my Report as fully read in this House, but in doing so, I would like to make comments that reflect

this arrangement and I am saying that nobody is deceiving Ashanti Region. The region would be delivered that hospital and it is not this year.

In any case, the entire amount that was approved for “Big Push” amounts to GH¢71 billion. What we are approving here today, is GH¢13.8 billion and, therefore, they should restrict themselves to projects identified under the GH¢13.8 billion. It does not mean that other projects would not be done. Wait until we bring the projects for next year and then they would find out whether we are doing that or not.

6.43 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the Minister indicated to us at Committee that when they were presenting the list of projects, three specific projects under the Big Push Policy were inadvertently omitted and therefore he sought permission to include them in the list that was presented and that the total will not exceed the GH¢13.8 billion programme under the Big Push Policy for 2025. These projects are; the Construction of the Third Ring Road Tamale Phase I, the Construction of the Third Ring Road Tamale Phase II, and the construction of the Third Ring Road Tamale Phase III. When some people hear this, they start running around and do not even know what to do to themselves.

Mr Speaker, the Committee concludes that we have carefully considered the referral and in the opinion of the Committee, the request is founded

and we therefore request this House to approve this request to enable the Minister for Finance to release resources to the Minister for Roads and Highways to deliver the Big Push Policy and transform the road network of the people of Ghana.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

[Hear! Hear!]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Motion is moved. Any seconder?

Let us have some order!

Vice Chairman of the Committee (Mr Alexander Agyare): Mr Speaker, I beg to second the Motion and in doing so, I would like to comment.

Mr Speaker, when the Committee met, we had issues with the whole Big Push idea because we realised that the amount had already been approved somewhere in March in the main Budget. So, it was something we needed to consider and then what needed to be considered was a list of projects. Committee Members asked the Minister the values for those listed projects because the Committee could not approve names of roads and kilometres without the values. But we were assured that they were then going through the procurement processes after which they will come back to the House for approval.

Mr Speaker, I think by the application of the Public Financial Management Act (PFMA), it is the right

thing to do and I will advise that, going, the Minister for Finance should refer all multi-year projects to this House for approval. This is something that will actually help the House and also the taxpayers so that corruption will go down in the various entities.

Mr Speaker, I was wondering the criteria for selecting these roads. Now you look at them—we had a Colleague here yesterday pushing hard for the roads to be constructed. Mr Speaker, it looks as if these roads were selected in certain constituencies to favour the Majority, because in the Eastern Region, we have only two roads and ask me where those roads are located, they are located in the constituency of the Deputy Minister for Finance, Asuogyaman. So, with the 33 constituencies in the Eastern Region, the only two roads were allocated to the Minister's Constituency. Mr Speaker, I find it hard to understand but as the Minister for Roads and Highways is here, he knows that there are a lot of roads that need to be considered. So, I still question the criteria for selecting those roads.

Mr Speaker, I was also thinking about the fact that the Minister said that if GH¢13.8 billion is approved, the selected roads are going to be constructed, it is fine. We are still waiting to see if the values that will come will conform to the allocated budget. That is why we expect them to come back.

Another thing is the District Road Improvement Programme (DRIP) because these roads are not enough for Members.

Members keep asking for roads because road issues have been the biggest challenge in this country. Every Member of Parliament is looking for roads in their constituency. Now we have the DRIP. The NPP government purchased those equipment to make roads motorable and I remember on the Committee where we had the Minister for Roads and Highways then as a Ranking Member, all he kept pushing was that “Minister, it is not about doing asphalt, it is about making the roads motorable. Now my question is that, how are we going to make all roads motorable? Because this “Big Push” cannot solve all the road issues in this country. The DRIP that we purchased—the DRIP that the NPP Government supplied materials and fuel, are now all being packed. We do not know when they are going to be put into use. So, our advice is that the Minister considers the usage of the DRIP to make most roads motorable. I think that was even going to be bigger than the “Big Push” because with the DRIP, every district had the equipment to do their own roads or make their roads motorable. Every district in Ghana had one; I do not think the “Big Push” is covering every district in Ghana. That is why I said, even in the Eastern Region where we have only two roads selected for the first phase, yet we have the DRIP.

So, I will plead with the Minister to use the DRIP in fixing most of the roads in the country and also plead with him that there is a constituency called Kade where we also have roads to be constructed. So, in the second phase, he should try to consider the Kade to Asuom

roads for me. He should also try to do the Otumi to Abirem roads for me.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Ranking Member of the Committee (Mr Richard Acheampong): Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity to speak to the Report before the House.

Mr Speaker, before I make my comments, I have the authority of the Chairman of the Finance Committee to effect some changes. There were some mistakes and I think they did not take account of them. At page 4 of the Report, Mr Speaker, if you compare the list provided to us by the Ministry, the additional three roads that were added, you will see that—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Acheampong, hold on.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, the leader is seeking your leave to do certain things on the Report. This is a Committee’s Report signed and co-signed by the Leader of our Side. He is the Ranking Member for the Budget Committee and I am not sure on the floor, on his feet, the Hon Leader can change the content of this Report without the Committee first discussing—I know it is his Report. That is, the application he is making.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, is he the Vice Chairman of the Committee? If he makes an application, if what he wants to do is not what happened at the Committee level, then you can draw my

attention to it that that is not what happened at the Committee level.

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, sometimes Members need to be very careful because when we started the meeting, all of them [*Expunged by Order of Mr Speaker*]. But we took our time and went through the processes; we gave them a copy of the attachments. Mr Speaker, I am referring to the very document we gave them and, in that document, there are three additions that the Chairman talked about. The first one is the construction of the Third Ring Road, Tamale Phase I.

6.53 p.m.

It is supposed to be 11km; that is the lot one, but they have written 1 km. In the other one, it is 1 km. I do not know if they got confused with the 1 km. So, I am just reproducing the original information we provided. I do not want us to take the wrong information and tomorrow they will organise another press conference to tell us that we did not do the right thing. Mr Speaker, I am doing the right thing. The first one will be 11 km. The construction of the third Ring Road, Tamale —

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, the Vice-Chairperson of the Committee made a first statement which is not borne out of fact. The first statement he made was to the effect that we did not sit in the meeting and that [*---Expunged by leave of Mr Speaker*]. This is a House of records, so that should not be made to stand within —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, if we can all stay away from these tangential issues because of the volume of Business, I would be happy. So, I admonish that both Sides should stay away from tangential issues and then we can concentrate on the main Business.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, the advice is well taken, but the most important thing is that *Hansard* has captured what he stated. I sat through the meeting.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Let that be expunged from the *Hansard*. Please, let us continue.

Dr Mahama: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Acheampong: So, Mr Speaker, the phase 1, phase 2 and phase 3 of the construction of the Third Ring Road, Tamale should read 11 km each; it is not 1 km. Mr Speaker, I heard the Vice-Chairman of the Committee complaining about the selection formula or the processes and finally he begged the Minister for Roads and Highways to include his constituency in the second phase. I thank God the Minister for Roads and Highways is here. He has taken judicial notice of it.

The Big Push is not ending in 2025. The 2025 allocation is GH¢13.75 billion. And then 2026 is GH¢17 billion, 2027 is GH¢19.24 billion and 2028 is GH¢21 billion. So, every community will be served under this Big Push policy that we campaign with. The people bought the idea and they voted for the

NDC, so everybody must benefit from the Big Push project. It is not only Big the Push project we are going to use as a vehicle to construct roads. There will be other interventions. The Minister said it here that about 261 districts will get the 10 km project that he talked about. So, nobody will be neglected, including everyone here. It does not matter if one supported the NDC or voted for it. No, we are talking about Ghana. We are resettling Ghana.

So, at the end of the day, we will come back and say the NDC said it and they have done it. So, the only thing we need from them is to support us. We have the four-year mandate to reset this country. The mess created by the former administration is what we are dealing with. So, Mr Speaker, if you go through the Budget, we are financing this under domestic financing. If you check our debt portfolios, by the end of 2016, our debt stood at GH¢120 billion. At the end of 2020, it rose to GH¢350 billion. —

Dr Mahama — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Dr Mahama, are you standing on a point of order? So why do you want to the debate?

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, the Vice-Chairman of the Committee has made a statement again. You have advised and admonished us to avoid certain comments that are not based on the facts, and that will probably invoke further debate.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, Hon Member, you will have your time to

debate; take note. When you are coming to debate you can draw the attention of the House to those things. Order 122 is very clear as to how a debate is supposed to be interrupted. So, take note.

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, I am surprised that a government can take inflation to 54 per cent, end it at 23 per cent, and now we are talking about 13 per cent. I do not want to talk about it. What is that?

Mr Speaker, as I was saying, in 2016, the debt portfolio was GH¢120 billion. By the end of 2020, it rose to GH¢315 billion. In 2021, it rose to GH¢362 billion. In 2022, it was GH¢448 billion. In 2023, GH¢610 billion. And then in 2024, GH¢726 billion. Within six months, Mr Speaker, we brought it to GH¢613 billion. So, if we say we are financing the Big Push under domestic financing so that we will not put more burden on our national debt; if we do not want to support this, what again do we want to support? Because the debt to Gross Domestic Product (GDP) ratio has come down from 80.4 per cent to 43.8 per cent. This is the prudent way of managing an economy.

So, when people hear about Big Push, they think it is a big elephant which is chasing them and they want to run to the bush. No, this is a policy. This is a programme that is going to help deliver some road infrastructure within the two-year period for all of us.

They raised some issues that we should have got some indicative numbers to know that this will cost a, b,

c or d, and we relied on section 33 for all the Public Financial Management Act, 2016 that we all passed in 2016. They are now going to award the contract. They have not awarded the contract or done anything to suggest that at the end of the day, a road will cost us GH¢1 billion. How can we give them those numbers? But already, Mr Speaker, we have approved the global sum in the 2025 Budget. So, we thank the Minister and the Government for bringing this information back to the House for approval. They could have gone ahead and done whatever they wanted to do with it.

We take loans and say budget support, but at the end of the day, we do not even see what they use that money for. So, this is a transparent Government giving flesh to what the two of Sides approved in the 2025 budget. So, now, if we go to their constituency and somebody asks what entails in the Big Push programme, we will be in a better position to explain to them that the first phase has been brought to us and these are the roads they are going to construct. Let us thank the Government for being transparent with all of us.

We are in charge of the purse. Sometime ago, we gave approval, but we did not hear anything but they will come and perform —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, conclude.

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, paragraph 33.4 will give out the performance report, so that at the end of

the day we will know what the GH¢13.7 billion was used for. So, I call on Members to support the approval of this process. This is a multi-year programme and we are going to finance it with our own resources. We are not going to borrow to do this project.

Mr Speaker, with these few comments, I thank you very much for the opportunity.

Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama (NPP — Walewale): Mr Speaker, first and foremost, we have the Minister for Finance during the presentation of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy telling us about the Big Push. The Big Push, apparently, is an elephant, not an umbrella, and the conceptualisation of same has been difficult. It has been so difficult for the Government that six months down the line, they are still trying to get a firm grip of the anchor of the Big Push.

That is a problem some of us faced at the Committee level. It is difficult because the Big Push, we are told, is supposed to finance not just road infrastructure, but key infrastructure projects including the 24-hour economy. But seven months down the line the Minister for Finance comes back to tell us that in the next two years all moneys for Big Push is now going to go into road infrastructure development.

7.03 p.m.

Mr Speaker, it means that half of their tenure of the so-called “Big Push” is now going to be about road

construction which the Nana Akufo-Addo Government has done, without christening it with any name. For the next two years, whatever is going to be done under the Big Push is the normal road construction the Government has been doing since time immemorial. Mr Speaker, we do not need to give fancy terms or exotic terminologies to describe Government's normal execution of projects. The previous Government executed very important—For the first time, over 13,000 kilometres of roads were constructed without a fancy name called “Big Push”. And if we have a term like this, it gets the Members also confused. That is the first thing.

Mr Speaker, the second thing we had an issue with was the fact that, even the “Big Push”, the priority projects, speak to the priority of the Government. Even the selection of those particular projects tells us about the seriousness of the Government. Mr Speaker, I will not go far. The Ashanti Region, one of the biggest regions in the whole country, where we are supposed to have equitable distribution of resources, and for that matter, evenly and fairly distributed projects, they are only undertaking some very few projects there. The lists are there for us to see. Mr Speaker, where we have created new regions, and the directive principle of state policy requires that we do everything in fulfilment of the social and economic directive principle of the Government, the North East Region is getting only one road. Mr Speaker, that one road —*[Interruption]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, Order!

Hon Members, I will begin naming and applying the Rules.

Dr Mahama: Thank you, Mr Speaker. Mr Speaker, a whole region — a new region that the Government is supposed to prioritise, and in line with the commitment of the President that he was going to do everything to support these new regions—The Savannah Region, a very new region, only Sawla-Wenchi Road is in the Big Push, one project. Bono East, we labour to find any project significant in that region. Yet, these people queued and gave them massive votes in this particular region. Mr Speaker, we wonder whether these people's efforts are in vain. It is a question that baffles all of them. What will they get in return out of the lofty promises this Government gave them? So, we have a difficulty.

Mr Speaker, aside that, the Committee had another difficulty. The Speaker made a referral of a certain Mid-Year Budget presentation to us and the referral was clear and unambiguous, that we should go as a Joint Committee of Finance and Budget to examine the Statement by the Minister and write a Report. Then the Minister comes with other three projects that the Ghanaian people did not have the benefit of knowing during the presentation. We had a difficulty because we wanted to even know whether in line with the practices of the House, the Committee can decide to introduce any project or the Minister for Finance can bring any project to us for ratification. Because the referral of the Speaker was in line with the Mid-Year Budget presented. But he comes

with three different sets of projects. Mr Speaker, these three projects were basically on hindsight. Because our respected leader, Dr Amin Adam, raised an issue of the obvious exclusion of the Northern Region, the World Bank of the NDC, from the projects. The Northern Region did not even have one single project. This issue was raised and on hindsight, they brought some three projects. Even in the Report, they said one kilometre, but on hindsight, they are saying they will have to correct it to 11 kilometres. Mr Speaker, it includes the construction of Third Ring Road, Tamale Phase 2, Lot 1, Lot 2 and Lot 3 in the Northern Region. These were the new additions. And the issue we have is, those new additions were not contemplated within the original amount of GH¢13 billion that they said we should approve. So they brought some projects, excluding three projects, and now they introduce three projects without increasing the amount, that goes to the point that we needed to know, for each project, what amount is allocated. Because if those three projects were contemplated, we would have —

Mr Adongo —*rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Adongo?

Mr Isaac Adongo: Mr Speaker, the Hon Colleague is misleading this House. We are not responsible for him exiting the meeting and not hearing the full story. The full story is that; the Minister says the total amount of GH¢13.8 billion that he is requesting will not change. It will not change. That time he was not in

the meeting. So please, do not mislead the people of Ghana to think that we should have added any amount of money. That is the request that was made to us by the Minister when he sought to amend his request.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, I think that the Chairman of the Committee should have the patience and should open his ears to listen when I am talking. What he said is not different from what I said — *[Interruption]*. What I am saying, if he will listen, is that the Hon Minister gave us some projects with some GH¢13 billion and on hindsight, he added three projects without changing the amount. That is the point I am making, that if he brings us projects —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You see; I think we are speaking the same language. The Chairman in presenting the Report indicated that those three projects that were brought was an omission and that if these three projects are included, the ultimate figure will not change. So, you are bringing something based on a stated figure. Three has been omitted. And if the three are now being added, definitely, it cannot result into a change in the figure. Because they claim it was an omission which is now being added.

Hon Kabiru?

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, a government that is serious with its work would come to this House with full complements of projects. And on the

basis of that, we look at the projects and the resources and see whether they match. If as an afterthought, they bring us some projects, I think it is the most unfortunate thing that a serious Government would do.

Mr Speaker, the projects they are asking us to commit to, in line with section 33 of the Financial Management Act, the Minister is well within the laws of the country to come and ask us to approve. But the commitments that they were presenting to us, were not commitments. They were a list of projects. A list of projects that we cannot even say whether, if this House approves this Mid-Year Fiscal Statement, it amounts to the approval of those particular projects so herein stated.

Mr Speaker, it is not proper that they bring us a list of projects attached to their Statement, and say that by approving the Mid-Year Budget, we are invariably approving those particular projects. That is not proper. A proper thing for oversight of this House would have required that they bring us those particular projects, the Committee would sit on those particular projects, we would ask whether those particular projects would get value for money for them, before we would commit. But this is the case, we have given the Minister for Finance a blank cheque. The Minister is going to spend it on —

Mr Adongo — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Adongo?

Mr Adongo: Mr Speaker, I am sorry, I have to do this. Nobody brings contracts at the approval of Budget. Contract is implementation of Budget and we are here approving a Budget and he is saying that we should have brought contracts, even when we have not implemented the Budget.

Please, we debated this and it was clear.

7.13 p.m.

It was clear that the Committee agreed. If you read the Report, you would understand that we said under Section 33(4) of the Public Financial Management Act, 2016 (Act 921), the Minister must come back after implementing and contracting to report to us and give us those details that we want. But at this stage, we are approving Budget and nobody approves contracts at Budget time. It is at implementation of Budget that we will get that and we are now approving for him to implement and come back and report to us under section 33(4). So, Mr Speaker, this is just misleading the public. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, this is the first time I am learning that Budgets are approved in vacuum and that Budgets are not supposed to be approved with some items attached to them. This is the first time I am learning it. If it is the new economic management, then we have a long road. Mr Speaker—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I think we can all use the opportunity to get it right. What is a

budget? It is proposed expenditure and expected revenue. That is my basic understanding of what a budget is. So, at this particular level, it is true that the specifics that we would hold them accountable for cannot be outlined. So, it is just a proposal at this particular level.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, in the Budget Statement, on page 82, it is not for any reason that they are telling us that wages and compensation would be “A” amount, interest payment would be for “A” amount and subsidies would be “A” amount. There is every item attached to the figures mentioned; it is not for nothing. So, if a person says that budgets are revenue and expenditure projection, he or she is very right. But attached to those revenues are sources and attached to those expenditures are items and those are the points we are making and we have to make that point clearly because this is a House of records.

Mr Speaker, one cannot give estimates and expenditure items in vacuum; they must be tied to some items and we are saying that the GH¢13 billion they are tying was all right. We approved it in the Annual Budget that GH¢13 billion would be spent. But they are bringing us projects and we did not force them to bring those particular projects to us. They brought us projects and then we are asking to know the cost breakdown of those particular projects for this particular GH¢13.8 billion. It is not something difficult for the Minister to provide to us and it is not rocket science.

Mr Speaker, I think that, in conclusion, the multi-year commitment

presented by the Minister requires that, in line with Section 33(4) of the Public Financial Management Act, the Minister would have to come to this House with annual reports on the performance of those particular commitments. Even as we have our reservation about those particular projects, it is our hope and belief that the Minister would religiously abide by the tenets of this particular Public Financial Management Act, so that we can have answers to the questions that we are asking now.

With these few words, I thank you very much.

**Minister for Roads and Highways
(Mr Kwame Govers Agbodza) (MP):**

Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity and all the comments by Colleagues are taken in good faith. But I need to make these points; I know my Colleagues on the other Side are very much familiar with some of the projects they have mentioned. Komfo Anokye Teaching Hospital Maternity Project being stalled is a sad story, but it is stalled because of the debt restructuring. It is still under contract and Government is trying to restore the loan for that project to be completed. Indeed, the Minister for Finance mentioned that, so I am not sure why anybody in this House would make any comment. But I can only say that, because they were not here, they are peddling rumours. They were not here when the Budget was read, so they are actually arguing out of rumours.

Mr Speaker, we have already said that the Big Push is not the only road intervention. Graciously, this House

approved the Ghana Road Maintenance Trust Fund just last Friday. A lot of the interventions at the district levels, including how District Road Improvement Project (DRIP) is deployed, will be based on those things and we debated this during the formulation of that law, so everybody should rest assured. The formula for the distribution and the utilisation of that Fund would be determined here in this House. So, there is no need for anybody to ask anybody to do anything; we decide how much and what we give to every district, so they can rest assured.

In the last six months, we have been collecting data, analysing, designing and costing the Big Push. We do not want to rush and do what they did with the bypasses on the Accra-Kumasi Road. Because they rushed, a project that they said will cost GHC1.9 billion, you are demanding to pay additional variation of GHC1.7 billion. Is that what they expect me to do? That is not what they expect me to do as their Minister for Roads and Highways. So, we are being prudent by taking time to do those things; they should commend us for being prudent, not for saying things they want to say.

By the way, last week, Hon Kabiru Mahama argued vehemently that no road in the North East Region was added to the Big Push and I drew his attention to the fact that Gbintiri-Nakpanduri is in his region. Then, today, he said that it is not enough. At least, he has admitted that we are starting something; at least, 44 km will start—*[Interruption]*—Hold on. In fact, if the contractor their Government paid US\$30 million had delivered 44 km

between Savelugu and Walewale, we would not be here. So, they should help me retrieve the US\$30 million from the Indian company and we can do even more than the 44 km.

Mr Speaker, I heard Hon Kabiru Mahama say that they have constructed 13,000 km. He was not here when President Akufo-Addo made that statement; the Ministry came back to say that the 13,000 km included pothole patching, roadside weeding, and other things. What is he talking about? So, I do not fault him for that because that was the explanation for the 13,000 km.

Mr Speaker, Big Push has been well thought out. Let me tell you this: I explained that, with the Western Corridor, we are starting from Wenchi all the way to Wa. How do they say that there was no principle in selecting this? We want to complete the road and asphalted from Wenchi to Wa. We are clear in our minds and we have said that we want to complete Wa to Bolgatanga. What principle are they talking about? We want to complete the Sunyani Outer Ring Road. When we get to Kumasi, I said that we are now doing the design for the rest of the Kumasi Outer Ring Road. It is over 100 km.

Mr Speaker, so, we are doing the first quadrant; that is from Ejisu all the way to cross the road at Mampong, which will significantly reduce the traffic going into Kumasi, especially if one does not intend going to Kumasi. So, all the Big Push projects are well thought out. And then there is an additional project we took on, which is to complete the Ofankor

problem they left there and the INZAG project from Ashaiman Roundabout towards Atimpoku. Everything is thought out, so they should not make a mistake. We are not actually shooting in the dark; we know exactly what we are doing, so they should support us. We said that—You and I know—And I spent my Easter at Wa deliberately. I stayed there to see what people go through. If one drives from Wa to Bolgatanga, he or she will wonder why government after government neglected our people on the northern side of the country. It is not fair and President Mahama is determined that, in about two years, we fix that road. That is what we are talking about—*[Hear! Hear!]* So, they should support us to do that.

7.23 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the respected Chairman of the Committee has already determined that the ring roads around Tamale, for all you know—In fact, I have already obtained commencement certificate for it and the Minister for Finance said it here that commencement certificate has already been gotten; so, it is not an afterthought at all. It is an omission that we admitted to and it is fair, so it is not an additional road, what he was seeking to draw your attention to—

Mr Speaker, what I am happy about is that this Report has received bipartisan support and I want to thank Colleagues for this. I agree that the Minister for Finance might adhere to what we are approving, but the GHC13 billion is the allocation for the Big Push this year.

That is why it is a multi-year commitment. No one is saying that all these projects will cost GHC13 billion.

Mr Speaker, they are in excess of GHC70 billion, so the GHC13 billion is not the cost of the Big Push Project Phase I. Phase II will be other ones which will include the Ekye-Amanfrom Bridge, the rest of the Kumasi outer ring road, the Accra outer ring road and others and the Accra-Kumasi expressway. We want to build a new alignment to Kumasi. It is necessary and we are going to do that.

Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity and I would like to thank Colleagues for supporting this and together, we shall improve the road network in our country. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr First Deputy speaker: Yes, Minority Leader?

Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin (NPP — Effutu): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity.

I have enjoyed the submissions coming from both Sides, particularly from the Minister for Roads and Highways, but without sounding very partisan, I disagree with the aspect of the submissions to the effect that Government after Government did not do much for the northern sector, in terms of road construction, and that President Mahama is determined to fix this situation in two years.

Please, Mr Speaker, President Mahama has been president before—*[Interruption]*— Yes, but you made an absolute statement towards the end of

your submission. If you had been relative, then I would not come up to fault you, but President Mahama has been President before. He has been Vice President before and, in fact, your tradition has been in office before. From 1992, when we started this democracy, so from 1993 to 2000, then, again, they had the opportunity for another eight years. Prior to that, it was their tradition that was in office for almost 20 years, the PNDC; that is where they root their heritage.

So, Mr Speaker, if he is talking about a situation which I agree—Recently, when we attended the Northern Development Conference, it is a matter that came up, that a person somewhere in Bawku should be comfortable staying in Bawku because distribution of infrastructure is even. I think that should be the focus of the argument, but if he now wants to make it partisan, by even saying that a matter that is a matter of record is not the case.

Hon Minister, if somebody says that he is aggregating or putting everything together under his administration and he has done 13,000 km and as a result, even pothole patching have been included, what is wrong with it? He and I know that a lot of our roads are immotorable because of the state of the roads, so if a government fixes them and is adding that to their achievements, there is nothing wrong, with respects, and he will agree with me.

So, Mr Speaker, I think that the concerns of the Minority have to do with the uneven distribution of these roads. I

have seen the list, quite a number of them—Sometimes, we, politicians, try to pretend, but the reality is always a reality. Some of these roads were started under Akufo-Addo; they have not been completed and they are continuing. That is governance and I agree. I will not stand here and critique them for that, but the impression should not be created as though it is a certain Big Push. What are they pushing? [*Uproar*]

Mr Speaker, we have some regions that are not receiving attention. Volta Region, what serious roads are being constructed? Check it.

Alhaji Dauda —*rose*—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, senior Collins Dauda has been on his feet for long.

Alhaji Collins Dauda: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, the Hon Minority Leader said that he just looked at the roads listed by the Minister for Finance to be catered for under the Big Push and he realised that some of them were started by Nana Akufo-Addo. We want the Hon Minority Leader to mention one or two of the roads that he finds listed which were started by Nana Akufo-Addo.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, the Winneba road is there—[*Interruption*]**—**Mr Speaker, this is a house of records, with respect, it was President Kufuor who with a Japanese facility—[*Interruption*]**—**Yes, please,

Hon Collins Dauda, you are a very senior Member and you know how much I respect you. Fortunately for you, you spoke for your members to applaud you, but not into the microphone, so I cannot fault you because they heard you loud, but *Hansard* did not hear you.

It is my duty to remind you that President Kufuor started and completed from Mallam all the way to Yamoransa. It is a matter of record. Yes, the Japanese facility and then today, some of the roads—Mr Speaker, the Minister for Roads and Highways is here and he knows that I will not attempt to do any propaganda with that which is a matter of record and I am commending the Government for that effort.

Governance is a continuum. They came to meet some projects being constructed; they want to continue, that is good, but this Side of the House has a concern, the uneven distribution. Mr Speaker, in the Northern Region, we are seeing only 11 km. The Savannah Region, what we are seeing, at least, unless they are going to amend; I am praying that Government is able to raise the needed funds for contractors to get back to the road or to start those that are going to be awarded.

7.33 p.m.

But, Mr Speaker, again, the Minister for Roads and Highways makes another point. This is not the first time he has made that point, but I have some disagreement and I want the records to be properly put in context. He said that the Government pays a certain Indian some

US\$30 million. Mr Speaker, I have been working with some of our technocrats only yesterday. He is now working with technocrats. Hon Minister, perhaps, today, it is convenient to make such a statement, but you and I know that the final document that comes to you to sign, for it to go to the Ministry of Finance for payment originates from his technical men. It is not everything that he will be able to do himself as a person, because as the Minister for Roads and Highways, he works with a government structure, a civil service infrastructure, which is there.

And in fact, at his Ministry, which he knows, not a single director has left since the NPP left office. It is the same technocrats he is relying on to advise him to make payment. So sometimes when we are throwing some of these uppercuts, let us be careful, because tomorrow, he may not be there, and a technical advice will now be pushed on his head that Hon Kwame Agbodza did this, meanwhile, he did not do that.

So I will plead. This issue of our Government has done this, or people paid some 30 million—Hon Kwame Agbodza knows this; he has been there for six months. He knows how the Government functions. So I will plead with him to move away from the campaigns; the campaign is over and they have won big. This is the time for them to govern. They should stop this propaganda, or else give themselves up by December. Some contractors will get their certificate to his table, there may be a problem and we have to come and say Hon Kwame Agbodza is responsible. He may not be. So please, let us move away from this.

Mr Speaker, I would just conclude by urging our Colleagues to walk the talk. When a government comes into office, it comes with a lot of ambition. It is good. This is their time. Six months and they have made promises. We wish them well. We pray that they will align government finances and do away with the waste.

I am happy that they have come out with this new Road Fund Bill. I was not here to have supported, but it was something that was dear to my heart. When we were there, we worked on it. They have come to improve upon it because a lot of people made double claims. Some contractors will come and claim, and because the system is manual, they come again, and the Minister will sign. I am happy they have detected it. It is the same Ghanaians who do that. So if they are tightening the system, which was started, and want to improve upon it, so be it. It is good.

I only pray that they get the needed cooperation because it is not easy. If they get the needed cooperation, Ghana will benefit. And rest assured, this Side of the House is not just here to critique them. We are here to support. And if the roads are constructed well to last, Ghana benefits.

Mr Speaker, I will rest my case on that score.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Mahama Ayariga: Let me thank the House for expressing support and urging us to approve the Report of the Committee.

Mr Speaker, I think a lot has been said already. Definitely, this is not the first time roads have been constructed in this country, but I think that as a country, the major challenge that we are confronted with is efficiency; efficiency in the development of our infrastructure projects. We all always boast about that one government started, and another continued. Very often, we do not see a government actually start a road and complete the road; there are a few cases.

But governments have tended to spread themselves so thinly that we start so many roads when we know we do not have the finances for those routes. And the nature of road construction is such that when we put so many contractors on so many and they all perform halfway and bring certificates, and we do not pay the certificates, interest accumulates on the certificates. That is the first major source of inefficiency and wastage in road construction. Not only do interests accumulate on the certificates, but because we have not completed the road, the vagaries of the weather will also depreciate the quality of work done. When the contractor has compacted and is supposed to asphalt and the contractor is not paid and he stops at that stage, motorists plying on that road cause further damage to the road.

Now, when the contractor comes back, he is going to redo the part that has been damaged in order to continue where

he left off. And as a Government, we will have to pay for the additional work of redoing what he has redone before continuing where he left off. So two major sources of wastage which is the interest on what has not been paid and the redone work. And when the work is delayed, then they will come back and say that inflation has changed the cost of the inputs. And again, the Government will have to revise the contract sums. So we have been spending excessively on road construction and yet not getting value for money. That is the major problem in our infrastructure development.

Mr Speaker, I think that it is high time Parliament paid close attention to what is done at the Ministry of Roads and Highways so that when we are approving finances for road projects, we are assured that there is indeed funding for the road to be completed. And we must support the Ministers for Roads and Highways to be financed so that they can complete those projects.

I believe that this Big Push project is not the first time we are doing roads, but is an expression of the commitment of this Government to make a major dent in the road infrastructure deficit of this country. He just spoke about the north. Let me take him through memory lane. There are three major roads that we need to develop in the north. The road connecting Tamale to Bolgatanga, the road connecting Tamale to Wa, and the road connecting Wa to Bolgatanga.

I can say that the NDC tradition is the one party that has made a major dent in the road infrastructure of the north.

Because it was Jerry John Rawlings and the NDC who took on the task of constructing and asphaltting the road from Tamale to Bolgatanga— *[Hear! Hear!]*—up to Navrongo and the border with Burkina Faso at Paga. That was a major infrastructure development. And I remember this vividly because as a secondary school student, travelling from Bawku to Tamale to attend Ghana Secondary School, we used to travel, and halfway we would disembark and walk across streams and another vehicle would come and meet us on the other side of the bank of the stream so that we could attend school in Tamale.

It was President Jerry John Rawlings and the NDC who confronted that challenge and constructed the first most beautiful infrastructure road from Tamale to Bolgatanga, to Navrongo and to Paga. He did not stop there. Indeed, he had done the road from Tamale up to Kintampo, and I think Techiman. Yes, that was how far he went.

7.43 p.m.

John Dramani Mahama came as Vice President with Atta Mills. They then, with an African Development Bank facility, took on the challenge of connecting Tamale to Wa. The then Minister for Roads, the late Edward Salia, had done some work from Wa to Garu and other parts, going up to, I think, Sunyani.

So, when John Dramani Mahama and Atta Mills did the connection from Fufulso to Sawla, they then did the connection to Tamale. I am happy and

proud that the NDC is back and we are going to do the last connection, which is from Bolgatanga to Wa. *[Hear! Hear]* So, I can say confidently that NDC as a party in government has made a significant, a major mark when it comes to developing the road infrastructure of the north. But that is not all. I will say that when the NPP came in the last four eight years, we saw some infrastructure development connecting Tamale to Yendi and I am sure we can bear testimony that the Tamale to Yendi road was done by, I think, President Akufo-Addo. There are some roads that were done. Indeed, and then some parts of the Eastern Corridor, even though we also started the Eastern Corridor Road before we left office. If we take the Bolga-Bawku-Pulmakom Road, we started the contract. We engaged the contractor and the NPP came and then stopped it, did some audits and allowed the contractor to continue. They delayed it. So, I will say that they, during their period, contributed to the construction of the road from Bolga-Bawku-Pulmakom. But it was a contract that was awarded by the NDC Government.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Leader, why are you rising?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr. Speaker, my respected Colleague is being very patriotic. But the patriotism is getting diluted and I just felt that with your leave, I may have to draw his attention to the fact properly. The road from Bolga to his own Constituency and beyond, he is now telling us that, the contract was initiated by the—*[Interruption]*—if the Majority Leader would indulge me. He

says that it was initiated and Akufo-Addo Government actually ensured that the job was done.

Mr Speaker, that bit does not come out well. The Tamale all the way through Gushegu and Karaga, he has not mentioned that one. Yes, in the north. He knows them. So if he wants to add, I just want him to mention them in full.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, you had your turn.

Why do you want to speak for the Majority Leader?

Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, let me conclude by saying that we promised the Big Push. This is just the first year and given the damage that was done to the finances of this country, we can only afford to put GHC13 billion this year.

Mr Speaker, we plan to do more. He was asking where we are pushing.

We are pushing on all the roads of this country. That is where we are going to push. When we finally finish fixing the financial mess and sort out the debts that we have inherited, and we begin to make significant savings, I can assure them that their complaint about discrimination will be addressed.

We cannot start in all the regions at once and that is why I started by saying that a major failing of our past efforts in infrastructure development, has been trying to satisfy everybody at once. In the

end, we do not satisfy anybody. That is what we have done. It is better to focus on a few major roads, do them well, finish them, and let them contribute to the economic development of that corridor of the country and now move to the other corridors and also concentrate, if every regime, since 1992 had just focused on two or three major roads and finished them, I can assure Hon Members that today we would not be where we are. If we travel across the country, contractors have been littered on every single road that we can imagine yet nothing is being done. Nothing has been achieved. So I thank the Minister for the decision to focus. I also thank the Minister for Finance for his foresight. With all the 55 stalled road infrastructure projects, he has decided that he will take those that are just 70 per cent complete so that we can complete the 30 percent. That is focus. Then as resources come, we will take those that are closer to completion instead of spreading ourselves thinly and when we stay for four years, we will not achieve much. So I support that approach to our infrastructure development. It is the most reasonable way to go.

Mr Speaker, I thank Colleagues and I can only say that we have begun well. As the Hon Minority Leader has indicated, we have the support of our Colleagues in the minority. This is a national enterprise. We are not discriminating based on partisan considerations. Indeed, in this election, I wonder where the NDC can discriminate against.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Leader, please conclude.

Mr Ayariga: I am saying that in this election, I wonder where NDC can discriminate against. Is it the Western region? Is it Western North?

Is it Ashanti? Is it Eastern? Is it Greater Accra? Is it Volta? Is it North East? Is it Central? [**Some Hon Members: No!**]

Mr Speaker, we won everywhere. *Aduru bebiara*. Scent no, — [**Hon Members: Agye bebiara**] The smell is everywhere.

So, Mr Speaker, we are not discriminating because they supported us everywhere. We are just focussing and then we will get to the others. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved:

That this Honourable House adopts the Report of the Joint Committee on Budget and Finance on the Request for the Multi-Year Commitments for the Selected Road Projects under the "Big Push" Programme Contained in the Mid-Year Fiscal Policy Review of the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I will suspend sitting for two minutes.

7:51 p.m. — *Sitting suspended.*

7:54 p.m. — *Sitting resumed.*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we are coming back to item numbered 14 to take the rest of the clauses.

Hon Members, the Social Protection Bill, 2025 under consideration.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I have a little plea from the Minority Caucus on this matter.

In principle, we are not opposed to this Social Protection Bill, 2025. After all, we started it way back, but some unfortunate interventions could not allow us to finish it. I do not want to go the way my Friends decided to go. Mr Speaker, we were to deal with this Bill, and the Government Side indicated that they want it to be done under certificate of urgency. We agree; we will support them. But, Mr Speaker, our Side holds a view that we should not rush it. Mr Speaker, we are rising on Friday. For me, if we have done up to clause 45 today, the rest of the clauses are not that many. We have the Schedules attached and the Bill ends at clause 67 which is the interpretation. Mr Speaker, I would plead with Government Side—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is up to clause 71.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Clause 71. Very well; thank you. I saw the 67 being the Interpretation, so, Mr Speaker, I stand corrected.

Mr Speaker, I would want to plead with Government Side. I am told again by the Chair of the Committee that I am

right by saying that it ends at clause 67— Interpretation. Mr Speaker, perhaps you have the old one. The new one that they have—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: So, it ends at clause 67. After that, we have the first, second, and third Schedules.

Mr Speaker, if Government Side would oblige us, we are suggesting that we come back tomorrow to complete this. We have the debate— Because tomorrow we are taking the Leaders; tomorrow is for Leaders. So, we can use the first one hour or soon thereafter, to complete it.

Hon Colleagues, we must not be seen to be in a hurry without scrutiny. There is no such urgency that if we do not complete this today, something will stand in its way. So, I will plead, let us go by the spirit of cooperation between us. Tomorrow, let us come and complete it; tomorrow is Thursday. Let us complete it on Thursday, so that Friday, we do the Third Reading as we rise. Mr President will then receive the Bill and sign it over the weekend or same day. Let us take it easy, Mr Speaker.

I have signaled the Majority Leader that we are not trying to stampede and I do not see him having any serious objection to this. Let us go. Some Members say they want to file some amendments. Because, we did not even do winnowing on this because of the previous—Hon Helen Ntoso, the Majority Leader heads the Winnowing

Committee. We have not had winnowing on this one. But I am not pushing for that. Let us take it easy. We have some few clauses. Let us finish our debate tomorrow and then do it or do it as the first thing and close it up. Then the Leaders can have their turn.

That is all my plea, Mr Speaker.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, this is a Bill that was introduced in this House in the last Parliament, when he was Leader. He brought this Bill to this House and he took it up to Consideration Stage. We would have passed this Bill in the last Parliament, but for the litigation that attended to the question of who is Majority Leader, who is Minority Leader, and whether the Speaker had some rights or not, that closed the Parliament until the year ended and we could not finish the Bill. It was his Bill; he brought it to this House and we had gone as far as the Consideration Stage. I believe we had even gone beyond clause 46 that he is saying that we should stop at today.

We brought this Bill back into this House as far back as May, if not early June. I remember I was in Cabinet when the approval was given and I kept asking the Minister when she would bring the Bill, because Cabinet had written to me that the approval had been given and we did not have that much work to do, so why did she not bring the Bill so that we could take it. And she said it was being cleaned up and they were going through consultation.

Mr Speaker, last week, your Committee made up of both the Minority and Majority Side met; they went through the Bill and proposed many amendments. They brought it to me and given that there are so many amendments, they should not go and advertise it and then we would have to go through winnowing. They should send the amendments to the Attorney General's Department and let them incorporate the amendments, print a fresh Bill, come and then withdraw the older one and relay the new Bill that has captured all the amendments of the Committee and that is exactly what we did. Mr Speaker, as you can see, we do not have advertised amendments.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: In fact, it is not only the amendment of the Committee, but the amendments of other Members have also been captured and integrated into the Bill.

Mr Ayariga: Yes, because there were other advertised amendments, even before the Committee went into retreat to consider it. So, clearly, there are no proposed amendments. That is why today alone, we have been able to get to clause 47 and we are left with just a few clauses.

Mr Speaker, Government has an interest in this Bill being passed immediately and he knows. He knows that this Bill has some financial implications for Government; he knows. This matter came up as far back as the previous government, because it is one of the conditionalities for addressing our relationships with our international

financial institutions. They want to see how we are carrying along the vulnerable and the marginalised in society, even as we ask for money from them. They want us to legislate the support that should go to the vulnerable and the marginalised in society, before they give certain moneys. So, please, I think that my Colleague should allow us to just go through the rest of the clauses, finish it, and have the President give his assent to this Bill, so that we satisfy those requirements.

If we had not worked on it, that would have been a different matter. But the Committee met; in fact, the Speaker joined them and helped them to do a very diligent work on it. So, I do not see that there is any significant amendment, and it will not delay us. If we had even started, I am sure by now we would have finished. All this debate that we are involved in, given the speed that I saw earlier, by now we would have finished the Bill. So, I am pleading with my Colleague to allow us to continue the consideration of the Bill.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Let us just conclude it.

Yes, you can come in. Let us just conclude. They are touching the soft part of your heart.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the Leader of Government Business knows that having been there before, I am not difficult. I have never been difficult, he knows it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, of late I have taken note of that.

8.04 p.m.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: No, Mr Speaker. From day one, he knows.

He would not want to admit it for the cameras, but it is fine; I understand. Mr Speaker, it is true that, indeed, this Bill has some financial implications and I agree, but all I am saying is that because some of our Members—Mr Speaker, I was just conferring with the Deputy Leader and the Ranking Member and they have whispered a few things to me. That is why I was pleading with the Majority Leader that if we can take this first thing before our debate—Unless the Majority Leader is not ready for tomorrow—*[Interruption]*—Are you not ready?

Mr Speaker, if Government insists on doing what it wants to do, we have made a point and a strong appeal to you that let us come tomorrow. But if you insist, Mr Speaker, I will not litigate.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

BILL — CONSIDERATION STAGE

Social Protection Bill, 2025

[Resumption of Consideration from Column 43]

Clause 46 to 49 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 50 — Composition of the District Social Protection Implementation Team.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairperson of the Committee?

Rev Ntoso: Mr Speaker, there is no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of the House.

Mr John Darko: Mr Speaker, I am sorry; I think my amendment is in clause 50.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, we are now on clause 50.

Mr Darko: Mr Speaker, my suggestion was that we add Members of Parliament (MPs) to the team by way of new amendments, so that after (1)(m), we add MPs to the list.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please, propose an amendment.

Mr Darko: Mr Speaker, I propose that MPs are added to the team.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, do you want 276 Members of Parliament added to this committee?

Mr Darko: No, it is for every district.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Is it for every district?

Mr Darko: Yes, Mr Speaker, at least, one MP for every district is added.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The difficulty is that some districts are not

coterminous to a constituency and these are going to be meetings at a constituency, which may be in conflict with your Sittings in Parliament. We have been made members of the assemblies, but because of Sittings in Parliament, we mostly do not attend assembly meetings and are you proposing that MPs should be added to this committee meeting?

Well, it is for the consideration of the House.

Mr Ayariga: Let me plead with my Colleague to consider what the committee is about. If we look at it, it is an implementation team and because it is an implementation team, there is a conscious effort to take out political actors. So, we see that even the District Chief Executive is not there and assembly members are really not part of it. All right—

“(c) the chairperson of the Social Services Sub-Committee of the District Assembly;

(d) one other member of the Social Services Sub-Committee from among their number;”.

So, for an implementation team to reduce the Member of Parliament to sit in the district to implement social welfare programmes might just be lowering the status of the Member of Parliament. I think we should leave it to the various technical people who are being proposed at the district level. If we need to play a role, we need to find some other higher level to play a role, but at

that level of a technical implementing committee within the district, I do not think we want to reduce MPs—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, in addition, you are supposed to play an oversight over all these issues. How do you go to sit at the committee meeting and again be the one to oversee?

Dr Abdul Tiah Kabiru Mahama: Mr Speaker, the Bill is expected to cure a certain mischief. One of the things that I realise from the implementation of Livelihood Empowerment Against Poverty (LEAP) programme and social protection programme is the fact that there is a disconnect between the Member of Parliament and the implementation. That is the more reason the Ministry has started giving us updates and sending reports to us and giving us information ahead of disbursement. This is because they want to synchronise the participation of the Member of Parliament to that of the implementation.

As much as we play oversight roles, our role is also political. If we do not have insight as to the implementation, it becomes a bit problematic. It may not be the MP himself, but a representative, so-called, should be part of it. Even if the person is *ad hoc* and not part of decision making, we can make provision for that, so that the person may not, necessarily, be a part of decision making. But like we have, the Act has made provision that they may co-opt some members to join. But the issue about people belonging to different constituencies is all addressed.

We are members of the respective district assemblies and this sits well with the respective districts.

So, Mr Speaker, we both agree that some level of the MP's insight into implementation or whatever has to be done; at what level, the Act has not made provision for us in anyway.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, well, in order not to drag this matter, I will intend to put a Question if the Member who moved the Motion insists. So, I will put a Question on the proposal by Hon John Darko that Members of Parliament should be made members of the District Social Protection Implementation Team.

Mr Darko: Mr Speaker, with respect, Members of Parliament or their representatives.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: As a Member of Parliament, you are not appointed; you are elected, so how do you designate your representative? You are elected to perform a function, so how and who do you designate?

Mr Darko: I believe that Members of Parliament play a crucial role. For this particular programme, it is my belief that, at least, a Member of Parliament or his representative should be there to advocate for the MP. The MP must be aware. So, even if the MP is not going to be there, his representative should be there because the District Chief Executive would appoint some members to join the implementation committee.

So, I do not understand why my Colleagues here do not understand.

8.14 p.m.

I believe that, at least a representative of the Member of Parliament should be part of this. The leave can be given to the Member of Parliament to appoint or recommend people to the District Chief Executive (DCE) to add to the Implementation Committee and I believe that that will help the Members of Parliament here.

We should be careful; if we do not ensure that this amendment is carried, Members of Parliament will be seated here and decisions will be taken about this programme against their interest. The Hon Member was in support, so he should get up and support my cause. Members of Parliament here should support this cause because I believe that it is in our interest that our representatives are on this committee to also support and push our interests.

Mr Speaker, I believe that this is very important and it should be added.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I have listened to the submissions of the Colleague who proposed this amendment and I have also listened to the Majority Leader. The Majority Leader, basically, looked at the structure. He says that, well, an MP is high and above an Implementation Committee which is being constituted by a District Chief Executive. Much as I agree to some extent, Mr Speaker, I struggle to also appreciate the import of that *vis-à-vis*

local government administration. We all know that MPs who do a lot of the job at the Local Government level have been alienated completely either by the Constitution or by statute. We are members of the District Assembly; we go there and they tell us that by law, we are ex-officio. Because DCEs do not get to their offices through popular votes, the people do not see them as the people to go to. They come to us.

Mr Speaker, we are talking about a social protection law to address vulnerability issues, inequities, social imbalances, *et cetera*. If we turn to the next page, which has to do with clause 51, it tells us about the functions. If we read carefully the functions of the committee, we would be in no hesitation in supporting what our Colleague is saying. This is because, Mr Speaker, we cannot leave the Committee, then we are here and, again, we pass a law that we are detached from.

It is important that an MP or somebody authorised by him, his representative, is in there. The MP is in Parliament and may be seeing a government policy. When he or she gets in there, they can aid them with some information and actually lead the process because all those challenges are at the local government level is the burden of the Member of Parliament.

So, if we say that we should not be involved at all because they are being appointed by the DCE, perhaps, we can do an amendment and say the Minister shall do the appointment upon recommendation by the DCE. So, that it

does not appear as if it is a power given to DCE to appoint and MP is higher. We can look at the clause 2 and then amend that to give the power to the sector Minister who will do the appointments; of course, with the recommendation from the DCE.

Mr Speaker, I urge Colleagues to let us look at it in the beyond. We need to have our eye there and this Social Protection Committee that is going to implement, we should bear in mind that any support, any intervention, or anything that Government will budget for to be implemented, they are going to take charge. If I am not a Member of Parliament, for instance, and I know that there are some areas in my Constituency, such as Gyahadze and Nsuekyir, that need some support and Government has come with this intervention how would I direct that no, instead of taking it to Kojo Beedu, take it to Atekyedo? That is where you will need it because you are the Member of Parliament; you would have the data.

So, let us look at it broadly and support it. Otherwise, like you and I know, a lot happened in our district assemblies that we have no hand in it. They take decisions; they do not tell us. If you even go to their meetings, they tell you that you are not a member. So, let us consider that, Mr Speaker, and, at least, for the first time legislate and have the MPs.

Some years ago, if some senior Members in this House had not thought it wise to allocate for MPs to have a portion of the District Assemblies Common Fund, let us ask ourselves,

where would we stand now? Everything would have to come from our pockets because the Constitution only envisaged that MPs would be making laws. The Constitution did not envisage that MPs would be right there as stakeholders and agents of development, but, in practical terms, we are agents of development. So, any social intervention programme must have the full participation by law from the MP—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, I will guide the House to take a decision. So, I am going to put the Question on the proposal by Hon John Darko that Members of Parliament at their respective districts should be added to clause 50.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I will direct the drafters to put it in proper terms.

Clause 51 — Functions of the District Social Protection Implementation Team

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Chairperson of the Committee?

Rev Ntoso: Mr Speaker, there is no advertised amendment.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, on the appointments, at clause 50(2), I am sorry to take you back. Hon Minister, if it pleases you—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, am I coming back to clause 50?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: That is so, Mr Speaker. Mr Speaker, I was going to propose that we should do some amendment to clause 50(2), that

“The Minister shall appoint members of the District Social Protection Implementation Team upon recommendation by the District Chief Executive”.

Mr Speaker, that is the proposal I have. That the DCE recommends to the Minister for her to effect the appointment. When it comes to board appointments, recommendations are made, but the ultimate appointing authority is the President. On this one, she is the sector Minister, so I believe that the MCE or DCE should recommend to her to actually issue the instrument of appointment. That is my proposal just for you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, let me hear you, Hon Minister.

8.24 p.m.

Dr Lartey: Mr Speaker, I think all the suggestions and recommendations are well intended, but if we take it the way the Hon Minority Leader suggested, it would defeat the purpose of decentralising it.

My challenge with the earlier amendment made was the fact that at the substructure level, the MPs are not there. We do not sit in Executive Committee (EXCO) Meetings, we do not sit in public relations committee, and all of the decisions that are taken at that level come

back to the Assembly, where we are ex-official members. Even if we are made members of this committee, we will never be voting. And in fact, our contributions — looking at the technical staff there, might not necessarily make much impact. So, if I go ahead and accept the amendment as suggested or proposed, what it means is that it will be bringing or re-centralising, which we want to avoid, so that the powers will be with the district and they will take decisions that affect them. Thank you.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I do not want to litigate this matter. I am strongly persuaded by the very submission by the Hon Minister to the effect that she wants to do away with centralisation. And if she thinks that this would amount to still keeping the system centralised, then I would just pull back and then rest my case, Mr Speaker.

Mr Philip Fiifi Buckman: Mr Speaker, I am looking at clause 50(2). For clause 50(1), the membership is already established, and it is automatic membership. So, I am looking at—as we have, it is these persons who comprise the members. So, I do not think there is a need for the chief executive—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Composition of our boards. When our boards are statutory, why should they be appointed by the President under article 70? Why should an appointment be made under article 195, if it is static?

Mr Buckman: Very well, Mr Speaker, let me abandon that.

Clause 50 to 52 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 53 — Secretary to the District Social Protection Implementation Team

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairperson of the Committee?

Rev Ntoso: Mr Speaker, no advertised amendments.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minority Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Unless I am not reading correctly. Is there any provision for who is secretary at the clause where we are constituting the committee? Because if you go back to clause 50, where we are talking about the composition, we do not mention secretary, we mention chairperson. That is why I am saying I do not know, maybe I am not reading well. So, we may have to make provision for secretary. Otherwise, we just do not jump.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us look at it in line with the board composition. A secretary may be a member of the board or a secretary may not be a member of the board. So, it is not a good reason that in talking about the composition, you should make provision for secretary, because the secretary may not be a member of the committee at all. So, the position of secretary in all the laws that we have passed is a separate provision that deals with it.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, you will realise that in the new Companies Act, the provision on who becomes a secretary has been properly defined, and now it is supposed to be a lawyer. Previously, anybody at all could be company secretary or director, or anybody at all could be appointed a secretary to the board.

Mr Speaker, if you read clause 53 carefully, the term “Secretary to the District Social Protection Implementation Team” is being introduced the first time. It is the reason why I am proposing that to the extent that we have provided for who is to be the chairperson, if you come to 50(1)(a), the district coordinating director as chairperson is without any ambiguity. But we say nothing about secretary in clause 50.

So, if we come to clause 53 and we are now mentioning “secretary”, my view is that if you do not place something on something, there will be nothing to hold it, it will fall. Therefore, out of the tall list, we have the District Gender Desk Officer, and the focal person on issues of disability at the District Assembly. If in the spirit of inclusiveness, we want to even consider this, I would even propose that we further amend (m) to read that “the focal person on issues of disability at the District Assembly as secretary”. *[Interruption]* Hold on. Then if we introduce that in clause 50, then we would have laid a foundation. And if at clause 53, we are talking about the functions of secretary, there will be no problem because we have already

provided for it —No, clause 53 now talks about the secretary. But I am saying that we have to deal with it in clause 50. We would have to define it there so that it does not become superfluous introducing it at clause 53.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, so what is the proposed rendition?

Hon Members, for all laws that we have passed, we talk about the composition, the functions, then we make determination as to who should be the secretary and that is in line with the structure of all the laws that we have passed. That is why I am indicating to you that talking about clause 50, which talks about the composition of District Assembly Social Protection Implementation Team—Now clause 53 is telling us who should be the secretary for this particular —

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I will not want to litigate, but just let me make this last point. The clause 53 is introducing somebody as secretary. But my point is that it would have been a neater approach if, as we did in clause 50, we introduced the chairman right there. In 50, we said the District Coordinating Director as chairperson.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You see, if you look at it, it says that the District Co-ordinating Director as chairperson, it means that the District Co-ordinating Director is going to be a member of that particular committee. Now, the secretary here may be a member or not a member.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, check the 50(1)(b) which is the Head of the bDepartment of Social Welfare and Community Development. The person is already there as member. So that is why I am proposing that let us amend and add “as secretary” there.

8.34 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, that is why I am saying that, the secretary has a function to perform.

So, if you look at clause 54, it is talking about the function. Now if you craft the (b) as it is in the (a), where would you integrate the functions of the secretary? That is why it must be a separate provision.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, I am sure we would land safely on the point. Mr Speaker, on the functions, I am not against it. No. I am dealing with the superfluity of clause 53 and I see it in this context that we already have Chairperson defined. The head of Department of Social Welfare and Community Development is already in (b) so, I am saying that why do we not define, just as we have done for (a), that (a) as Chair, then when you come to (b), then you also add as secretary. You end it there. Then clause 53 becomes superfluous. You do not need it. That is the point I am making. That is all my point because you have already designated the coordinating director as Chairperson and you define it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: There are functions for all the Board Members

but this one, you have a specific function for the Secretary.

Mr Dominic Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, I have understood Leader. What the Minority Leader was saying is that because we designated the Chairman at clause 50, the number 2(b) should have been Secretary immediately. But I think that our attention has been drawn to the fact that, unlike the Chairman, the Secretary has specific functions that will be mentioned in the Bill that is why they want to put the two together so that it is tidier. So that you have the Secretary and his functions. So, who becomes the Secretary is designated, and immediately after that, you have the functions. Otherwise, we would have a situation where (b) is designated as Secretary, and we come to some other clause somewhere, then we are talking about functions. So that is what they are trying to say. I think this one is very tidy.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: This is in line with other Bills that we have passed in this particular House. Well, but if he feels so strong about it, the House must take a decision.

Hon Minority Leader, do you feel so strong about it, so I put a Question.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I would still push for my proposal that we should *delete* clause 53 completely, and rather amend clause 50(1) (b) to define the same person who has been introduced at clause 53 as Secretary. Just as we did for the Coordinating Director as Chairperson.

Mr Speaker, I hope my allies will come in.

Mr Ayariga: I think I support the Minority Leader on this.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Majority Leader, this would have been a complete departure—[Laughter]—From other laws that we have passed in this House.

Mr Ayariga: Not really. I think the first thing you do in legislating is to avoid verbosity as much as possible.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, I believe in the brevity principle.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, if in clause 50 we have designated the personnel, the district Coordinating Director, as Chairman, then subclause 1 (b), the head of the Department of Social Welfare and Community Development as Secretary, then nothing stops us. Because first and foremost, the following clause deals with the functions of the committee itself then, within the functions of the committee is the Secretary so, the succeeding clause will also spell out the functions of the Secretary.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, if it is done that way, and you do not have a separate function of the Chair—Because the essence of doing it this way is that the District Coordinating Director as the Chair together with all others, perform the function as in clause 51 together but the Secretary has a specific function. That is why you have a specific provision designating the person as a Secretary to

perform that specific function, and that function is not performed by the entirety of the committee, but only the designated Secretary. That is why it is crafted this way, and so it is in all our legislations. So, based on the principle of consistency, I think I would advise that we leave the provision as it is.

Mr Ayariga: My Colleague and I, the Minority Leader, will yield because we have seen that the Speaker is well entrenched in his position on this matter—[*Laughter*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You can check all the legislations that we have passed, I am to guide—

Mr Ayariga: Even though his job is to be a Speaker. We can see that he wants the clause to come out the way it is, and I am sure my Colleague and I know why—[*Laughter*]

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I think my Leader will stand it down. Since the Majority Leader cannot defend his Brother so well, he will just abandon it. He does not want to be left alone.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, it is.

Clause 53 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 54 — Functions of Secretary to the District Social Protection Implementation Team.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, clause 54(d), I propose the deletion of “move beneficiary into” and replacing with

“facilitate productive and gainful implement of beneficiary”.

Mr Speaker, the current rendition lacks clarity, and as far as possible, you must bring clarity to the law and if you say move beneficiaries into productive and gainful employment, how would that be done? And the proposal is that we replace that with another rendition, which is “facilitate productive and gainful employment of beneficiaries”.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: I think this is a technical stage of our work, and our young ones are getting into it, so we need to help them. If I understood him correctly, in legislation, the term delete and insert are the technical terms that distinguish us from non-legislators so, Mr Speaker, I would want Dr Kabiru Mahama to use those terminologies. Then, after that, he says ‘the new rendition shall be’, then he carries us along so, please he may try again. I know he will make it.

8.44 p.m.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, clause 54(d), *delete* “move beneficiaries into”, and *insert* “facilitate productive and gainful employment of beneficiaries”.

Mr Speaker, what we are deleting is “move beneficiaries into” and replacing that with “facilitate”. So, the new rendition would then read:

“...facilitate productive and gainful employment of beneficiaries.”

I so move, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Members, it is for the consideration of the House, I intend to put the question.

Yes, Hon Richard Acheampong.

Mr Richard Acheampong: Mr Speaker, I think the original rendition is in order, because this is a social protection scheme we are talking about, so we are graduating them—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Acheampong, tell me how you are moving beneficiaries into productive and gainful employment? The issue that he is raising is about the use of the word “move”. So, you can facilitate.

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, they are moving from one stage to another. The Secretary is moving the beneficiaries to a productive and gainful—That is the point he is making.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I think the use of the word “facilitate” is in order.

Mr Alexander Roosevelt Hottordze: Mr Speaker, I have a problem with the word “facilitate” that is being put there. One cannot facilitate beneficiaries. It is something that one must facilitate for beneficiaries.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, the rendition is to,

“...facilitate productive and gainful employment for beneficiaries”.

That is the rendition. Yes, Hon Majority Leader.

Mr Ayariga: I think we can *delete* that and *insert* “enable beneficiaries”. So it will be,

“...to enable beneficiaries to become gainfully employed and productive”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Leader, let us look at it from the operative word. The operative word is the Secretary shall—

Mr Ayariga: Enable.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No, I think the Secretary shall facilitate.

Mr Ayariga: How can one facilitate beneficiaries to be productive and gainfully employed?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The Secretary shall facilitate productive and gainful employment for beneficiaries.

Mr Ayariga: To enable, one enables the beneficiaries.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: The new rendition shall read:

“The Secretary shall facilitate productive and gainful employment of beneficiaries.”

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, this is neater. So, I intend to put a Question.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, this secretary, when the implementation team meets, I am sure one of his or her functions will be to take the minutes. We cannot assume that to be an implied function. We must be explicit in our legislation and bring clarity. I, therefore, propose that there should be a clause 54(g) introduced to say:

“...take minutes and records of all meetings of the implementation team”.

To make it neater:

“...of all meetings of the district social protection implementation team”.

Mr Speaker, I so move. For clause 54 (f), after that, we are bringing clause 54(g).

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, the Secretary shall take and keep minutes.

Yes, Hon Ayariga.

Mr Ayarifa: Well, before we get to introducing the new clause 54(g)—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We ask the drafters to rearrange the provision for us.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

I will direct the drafters to tidy it up by using the appropriate language.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, 54(e), in legislating, we have to assume that we are dealing with the one district assembly in which the implementation committee is residing. So, when we say work with district assemblies in 54(e), are we saying that the Secretary can go beyond his assembly and do sensitisation for other assemblies?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Leader, sometimes it is envisaged that the sensitisation programme may cut across districts.

Mr Ayariga: My assumption is that each committee is working within its district assembly. One cannot go beyond their district.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, the word should be assembly.

Mr Ayariga: Yes, so it has to be:

“...work with the District Assembly to undertake community sensitisation and public hearings as appropriate.”

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Clause 54 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 55—Community Facilitators.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairperson of the Committee.

Rev Ntoso: Mr Speaker, there is no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of the House. Hon Members, any proposed amendments?

Prof Kingsley Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I am on my feet, please.

Mr Speaker, 55 paragraph 3:

“A District Assembly shall, in engaging Community Facilitators, give priority to females to ensure gender inclusion and female participation.”

I suggest we *delete* “give priority to females”, so that the new rendition becomes:

“A District Assembly shall, in engaging Community Facilitators, ensure gender inclusion and female participation.”

This is to avoid the verbosity our Hon Majority Leader talked about. Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, I agree. This is more gender neutral. We capture the same sense, but in a very gender-neutral manner.

Yes, Hon Chairman for the Committee on Food, Agriculture and Cocoa Affairs.

Dr Godfred Seidu Jasaw: Mr Speaker, I just want to draw your attention that there appears to be too many repetitions of females there. And by the current rendition, it appears gender means female. Inclusion is

inclusion. Gender inclusion does not bring out the meaning clearly. We are enacting a law. So, I do not know if you can hear me.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, your Constitution, did it use the word gender or female?

Dr Jasaw: My Constitution?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes.

Dr Jasaw: Which part? *[Laughter]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, you realise that if you look at the Constitution, you cannot be wrong when you use the word gender, because it is a constitutional language. So, his amendment is appropriate.

Dr Jasaw: Female gender inclusion?

8.54 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No. You see, one of the guiding principles in drafting is that you must be gender neutral.

The use of the word “gender”, for instance, we say “gender equality”. Why can we not say female equality? But we all know what we mean by gender equality. We do not say male or female equality.

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, I think I am with you on the same page, except that if you heard me, the sentence says, “give priority to females to ensure gender inclusion and female participation.” So,

we are either ensuring gender inclusion or we are ensuring female participation. That is the end of story.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That style of drafting is not good, so the proposal by Dr Kingsley Nyarko—

Dr Lartey: Mr Speaker, inasmuch as I appreciate the new rendition, I know if we leave it as gender neutral and defining gender as it is, male and female, it will be solving the challenges we have at the local level where the inclusion of females is actually at a very low level. Granted that we are working towards affirmative actions that will bring men and women at par, in terms of some of these things, I would suggest, humbly and respectfully, that we leave the female there, so that the assemblies will be very conscious of that. Having participated in the elections at the local level—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, I am not cutting you short, but you are likely to cause a problem that occurred in the passage of the Domestic Violence law. We, at that time, advised that it should be a Domestic Violence Bill which would be passed into a Domestic Violence Act. They said no; it should be domestic violence against women and children. But, today, they intimated to me they are coming to Parliament to amend the law because there are evidences of domestic violence against men. Therefore, if we use the word “female”, and, in future, the situation changes you will also have to come back to this House to amend.

So, in order to avoid those situations, we just draft in gender neutrality. I believe the drafters would agree with us that we draft in gender neutrality. So, the rendition proposed by Dr Kingsley Nyarko is apt. So, I will put a Question on it. The rendition is for us to delete, “give priority to female”, so that it will be to ensure gender inclusion and participation. So, delete “female”—

Dr Lartey: Mr Speaker, without meaning to belabour the point, I think affirmative action is meant to be a corrective tool. So, as the situation is, if we leave it to the local level, they will have very little or no women—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, have you seen any clause referring to male or female in the Affirmative Action Bill that passed? It is all talking about gender, so using the word male or female here would not accord with the principle of drafting in gender equality. As a result of which they say, even in drafting, we do not use “he or she”. So, Prof Nyarko, propose your rendition and let me put the Question on it.

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I beg to move, *delete*, “give priority to females”, so that the new rendition becomes:

“A District Assembly shall, in engaging Community Facilitators, ensure gender inclusion and female participation.”

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Dr Kingsley Nyarko, I think—

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I think we can exclude the second “female”, but the point is that we need to emphasise—Because gender equality—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I think the rendition should be delete “give priority to females,” and in the same line, delete “females”, so that the rendition will be:

“A District Assembly shall, in engaging Community Facilitators, ensure gender inclusion and participation”.

Prof Nyarko: That is right.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, should I put the Question on the entire clause 55?

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, there is another proposed amendment. Clause 55(4) reads:

“A Community Facilitator shall serve on the terms and conditions specified in the letter of engagement.”

Mr Speaker, if you look at most of the Bills, even though engagement is appropriate, the word “appointment” is what is used in most of them.

So, Mr Speaker, I am proposing that we delete “engagement” and insert “appointment”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We have to come back and look at it because the operative clause in 55(1) used the word “engagement.” Yes, everywhere is engaged—No, this one is not an appointment *per se*; it is an engagement. So, the proposed amendment will not be proper and then we drop it in sub-clause (4).

So, Prof Nyarko, abandon that amendment.

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, it is abandoned.

Clause 55 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 56 — Qualification for Community Facilitator

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairperson of the Committee?

Rev Ntoso: Mr Speaker, there is no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, it for the consideration of the House.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, on clause 56(d), *delete* “and known” and the new rendition will be:

“A person is qualified to engage as a community facilitator if the person

(d) is resident in the community;”

The “and known”, how will one be able to determine who is known and who is unknown? But “...is resident in the community” is enough.

Mr Speaker, if we say “known”, how do we—If the person is resident in the community, it means that the person is already known.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, you can be resident in your community, but you are not known to your community members.

9.04 p.m.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, the proposal moved by the First Deputy Minority Whip is to cure a certain problem: the difficulty of people being subjective with the law and if we are drafting and give discretion for people to say one is known and the other is unknown—Even with the definition of the known, how long should it be known? Who should be those determining whether one is known or not known? Is it the one going to engage or the community are those who are going to determine that or it is going to be done in consultation between the one engaging and the community?

They are all issues of operation and I think that in engagement, those can be ancillary to the engagement of the person, but to legislate it and say that someone is not known and thus, disqualified from getting the engagement because in your determination, the person is not known, I think that it will

be a difficult thing for the Ministry or the one engaging to involve in.

But if we leave it at “resident”, in the engagement process, you would be very amenable to saying that all right, we are selecting one because one is known and that is quite acceptable or you live in that community, but even in the engagement process, that will come in. So, I side with the proposal by the Hon Deputy Minority Whip, to the effect that resident should suffice.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Kabiru, when you get to your constituency, are you known?

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, it depends on the one you are talking to.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: This is rather to cure a problem, in view of the fact that they want the community facilitator to possess certain—

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, we are not talking of a country; we are talking of a community. The community members typically know each other. There is a reason they want one to be known. There is a reason they first want one to be resident and one must be known by the community members, so that one is effective. If we talk of residence, I could be resident in the community because I come from there.

I go there once every three years and I have a house there; I am a resident, but I am not known by the community. I will not be effective. So, they want one to be resident and one must also be known by

the community members, so that people are not imposed on them from somewhere or say they are residents because they want to.

I think that if one is going to be engaged, they must be known by the community; otherwise, they will not be accepted.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Let me give an example. Hon Habib, you are not known in Lamashegu, but you are known in Tolon; meanwhile, you are resident in Lamashegu.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, who determines that?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The community members.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, we are talking about engaging someone as a community facilitator. We are making a law, so if we give discretionary powers to some people, they will abuse it. So, if it reads that:

“A person is qualified to be engaged as a Community Facilitator if the person

(d) is resident in the community;”

Mr Speaker, even in the Constitution, if we are talking about somebody who is qualified to be a Member of Parliament, it says that the person is a resident of the community, but it did not say—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That is not what we are talking about. We are going beyond that.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I was also thinking of a different dimension, that can we not add a certain period, that a person should have been resident in the community for, at least, five years. If a person is in a community for five years and they are not known, then they cannot be known and that deals with what is—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You see; if you are in a community and you are known, it will depend upon your involvement in the activities and affairs within the community. You can be resident in the community for 10 years, but if you do not involve yourself in community activities, in matters affecting the community and in the affairs of the community, for this particular purpose, you will not be eligible. That is what I understand it to be.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, that is the case, but you know, where there are instances within the community where I play football, so among my peers, they see me play football, so they know me, but the market women, they do not come watching football, so they do not know me. Those who drink *pito*, who are also at a different joint may not. Mr Speaker, that was why Dr Kabiru Mahama was raising an issue with—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: For you to be known, it will cut across. So that it can really help in identifying those who are economically poor, socially vulnerable and are at risk. Not somebody who is confined to a corner.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, having heard the views of Members, I would like to try to fine-tune it to read:

“A person is qualified to be engaged as a Community Facilitator if the person

(d) is resident in the community and participates in community activities”

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You see, to be able to handle issues of social matters, you must be a known person. So, I do not think there is a problem with the rendition, but I will put the Question.

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, I think that you are right in the spirit of “known”. My problem is with the law; how do we measure “known”? That is subject to abuse; that is subjective. Somebody can decide that, yes, he is known and another will say, no, he is not known, so how do we judge that, really, this person we are proposing as a Facilitator is known or not known?

That is why, if we would not go by the time for being a resident, I will yield to what Hon Habib has proposed. It is a better rendition because the fellow participates and once the fellow participates—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Let me hear the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection, then I will put the Question, so that we can truncate the debate.

Dr Lartey: Mr Speaker, if we go by the number of years the person has stayed there, that will not suffice. In the sense that somebody can stay in a community, move out and come again and nobody will know the person. If we

are looking at it within the context of social activities, then we are looking at somebody who participates in all of the community activities and I think we should not restrict ourselves to the cities.

Let us think of the typical areas where unit committee members and assembly members are actively involved in the development of their communities. When you look at the functions of the Community Facilitator, it should be somebody who is known. If you are living in the community and you go out in the morning, when everybody is asleep, and you come back in the evening, when everybody is asleep, you could have stayed there for 10 years, but nobody would know you. So, it is important that that stays as it is because there would be so many assumptions if we change it.

Mr First Deputy: You must be somebody who is known and people can bring their social problems to you.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I think Hon Jasaw and our respected Lady Minister are saying the same thing. I think the language that runs through their two submissions is very simple. The person should be seen to be participating because you talked about not only residence there, in terms of number of years, but you are known to be participating.

So, I think it is the reason the proposer came back with a better rendition to say that instead of staying on that “known” language, that phraseology must be known; it is likely to be subjected to some abuse in one way or the other at the community level.

9.14 p.m.

So, the cure to me is found in what you said and what he said thereafter, which has already been taken care of by the proposer, to now say that “a person is qualified to be engaged as a community facilitator if the person is resident and participates in community activities”. So, it answers your question, and it answers his question. I think that this one would be very open and help.

Because one of the things we should have in mind—Colleagues lend me your ears, one of the things we should bear in mind is to ensure, as much as possible, clarity in the laws we pass. Mr Speaker, some of us who are practitioners in the court—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, can we resolve the problem by saying “the person is a known resident and participates in the activities of the community”?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, from what the Minister said and what Hon Jasaw said, we are curing it with the addition of “participate in community activities” so that we do away with the “known” word which may be abused. What you said earlier, Mr Speaker, was that the person must be seen to be participating in community activities to qualify.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, I said that to indicate the process by which the person will be known to the people.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: All right. Mr Speaker, we can build the process.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, the understanding that I have is that this is a person who knows those who are vulnerable and those who are economically poor. The category here would know that Dr Jasaw lives in that particular community and they can tell him their problems. Now we should also be in the community and we should be able to know and identify those people; that is the understanding I am having.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, we have listened to ourselves. The proposal is that “a person is qualified to be engaged as a community facilitator if the person is resident and participates in community activities”. Mr Speaker, may put a question on this?

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Let me put the question on the entire clause.

Dr Thomas Winsum Anabah: Mr Speaker, we are not done with clause 56.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Dr Anabah: Thank you Mr Speaker. I am looking at clause 56(f). After all these debates, “who is known and actively participating”, if we say anybody who plays partisan politics should not be considered, some of us come from communities where the very active people in our communities are all politicians and they are saying we should not put them there? Whom are we going to put there? —No, all—teachers have

cards. All of them belong to either NDC, NPP or something.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, Hon Member—

Dr Anabah: So, what I am going to say is that I am proposing that—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: They say chiefs are not to take part in partisan politics. Does it mean they do not have cards?

Dr Anabah: But the chief may not be able to read. No, they are saying the condition is there.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I am speaking to you with a view of the partisan politics that is being used here. What this is seeking to avoid is for me to say that you are economically poor, but because you belong to party A, I will not do the facilitation for you. That is the mischief this particular provision is trying to cure.

Dr Anabah: Mr Speaker, most of these people who are active in politics in our rural communities relate with everybody. It is only election time that they are different. I am telling you. They are even family members. The same family can have people in different parties who are the only active and educated people. There is a whole community where the educated people are few and all of them belong to different parties.

If we want to say that those who have party cards—Virtually in my community, I

can tell you that there is no house and there is nobody who is an adult and does not have a party card. So, if we do this it will bring problems.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That is why I am telling you that the word used here has nothing to do with party card. It says “partisan politics”. Hon Member, what is partisan politics?

Dr Anabah: Anybody who participates actively in supporting a particular ideology is partisan. It is politics.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Alexander Afenyo-Markin?

Dr Anabah: We will not get people in communities to fulfil the other clauses.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, we do not do this in Parliament. Once another person has been recognised, you resume your seat. Yes?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I support my Colleague. I say so because somewhere in 2015, I tested this law. If Members would listen to me, I would try to explain. Mr Speaker, I tested the constitutional provision under Article 94(2) (b), if we recall, the matter of Kwadjoga Adra. Mr Speaker, this matter had to do with a situation where some Ghana Education Service (GES) and Ghana Highway Authority officials were contesting for constituency positions for the NDC in my constituency. My view was that to the extent that somebody at the Ministry of Education was being prohibited by article 94(2) (b) and somebody at GES claims that he has not

been mentioned so he would go, would be discriminatory. Therefore, the law should be applied *mutatis mutandis* to those who have not been listed but by way of their actions they are in the same category.

Mr Speaker, the Supreme Court said no. If the constitution had envisaged those at GES, the constitution would have stated so. So, although somebody at Ghana Highways Authority reports to the Ministry of Roads and Highways, once that Ghana Highway Authority has not been mentioned but it is only Ministry of Roads and Highways that falls under the civil service category, indeed, I cannot say that those people at Ghana Highways should also be prohibited.

Mr Speaker, on that score, my argument simply is that the Constitution has provided for those to be prohibited from partisan politics and it is constitutional. We cannot use an enactment to introduce a new category or prohibit people from community engagement merely because they are involved in partisan politics. So, we should pay attention to what our respected Colleague is saying.

Mr Speaker, this is community. There may be communities where the total numbers are just about 20 or 30, and the only educated person is one who has completed West African Senior Secondary Certificate Examination (WASSCE) or its equivalent, can read and write, participate in activities and can lead the community to realise its social protection dreams. If, say, the NPP

constituency secretary, immediately we say he is prohibited, then we create a problem. So, Mr Speaker —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Let us take the rendition and put a question. So that we can truncate the argument a little faster.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Very well. I am supporting his—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, Hon Member, go ahead and propose your rendition—

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: No, he says to delete. Mr Speaker, the proposal is that we should *delete* (f) “does not participate in partisan politics”.

9.24 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, then the rendition will be “is a person of high moral character and proven integrity”,

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, no. Mr Speaker is right to some extent, we cannot say, Mr Speaker is wrong. Mr Speaker can never be wrong, but, Mr Speaker, I am dealing with the technicalities of lawmaking.

We are proposing that subclause (f) be deleted.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So now, if you are deleting (f) then the “and” cannot stay.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: That is so.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That is why I am saying that *delete* “and” and “does not participate in a partisan politics”.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Yes. Mr Speaker, that was not what you said.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Then the rendition will end at “character and moral integrity”. Is it not the same thing?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, you can never be wrong. It is the approach. So, Mr Speaker, we will get to the same destination.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: But you and I know, when we were learning this whole thing, under the Rt Hon Doe Adjaho and under Deputy Speaker Joe Ghartey, we were taken through the rudiments of the technicalities. So, I was thinking that we will first put a Question on the prayer for us to *delete* (e) in full, together with the “and” because the “and” is at (e).

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, that is exactly what I am putting the Question on. That is why I am saying that then the (e) would then end after character and integrity.

Yes, Hon Majority Leader.

Mr Mahama Ayariga: I fully concur and support the proposed deletion of (f). But let us be mindful of the policy

underpinning the inclusion of (f), which is to not have facilitators using that role to engage in partisan politics. That is the underlying consideration. And so, even though you are deleting it in clause 56 (f), we will need to introduce it in clause 57, in a way that prohibits the facilitator, when he has become a facilitator, from utilising that office for partisan politics.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I think I agree with the Leader of Government Business, that when we get there, he would have to lead that charge. And we will support him. I agree.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Let me put the Question on the proposed amendment to *delete* “and does not participate in partisan politics”, so that the rendition of (e) will end at “integrity” and the whole (f), together with “and”, will go.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: I would want to take leave of you. It is 9.30 p.m. I need to go and prepare fully for tomorrow. My able Deputies are here. I need to prepare tomorrow for the Majority Leader.

But, Mr Speaker, before I leave, I want the Minister in charge of this Bill to acknowledge the industry of the House. Mr Speaker has been sitting all day. I want you to find time to acknowledge Mr Speaker's industry in facilitating this whole process. So, that is all I want to say to you.

Mr Speaker, I thank you and I want to take my leave. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Alhaji Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I am proposing that 56(a) and (b) should be deleted.

Mr Speaker, I was not aware that you had put the Question on the entire clause 56 because I wanted—Maybe we might go for second Consideration because I wanted to propose that both (a) and (b) should be deleted because it is an affront to the Constitution and it is discriminatory and I wanted to propose that but if you have put the Question already, no problem.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: What is discriminatory?

Alhaji Iddrisu: Mr Speaker if it says:

“(a) possesses the West African Senior School Certificate or an equivalent.

(b) is proficient in reading and writing English language.”

Mr Speaker, even if you read the Constitution in Article 94—Members of Parliament qualification, we know definitely what we do here—

Mr Speaker if you read Article 94(1) of the Constitution it says:

“Subject to the provisions of this article, a person shall not be qualified to be a member of parliament unless-

(a) he is a citizen of Ghana, has attained the age of twenty-one years and is a registered voter”; —

We do not even see an academic qualification there.

Mr Speaker, I wanted clause 56 to rather start because in my community, I might have somebody who may be a very good facilitator, who you may not necessarily legislate it but at least when the person finishes whatever he is doing, he can put things together, but the person can be a good facilitator.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I understand the sense.

In a district where they speak multiple languages and they have a District Chief Executive or the implementation committee transmitted something in English to the community so that the facilitator is going to use same to do the facilitation and at the end of the day the facilitator is also writing back to the community and they do not possess these characters, how are they going to do the work?

Alhaji Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I do not think that we should legislate educational qualifications.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Because this is not the representational function that they are going to perform, so the eligibility is determined by the people that you are going to represent. The social protection is going to engage you in the community as a facilitator, and if

you cannot speak the local language, how are you going to facilitate within the community?

Let me pick the thought of Hon Terlabi.

Mr Ebenezer Okletey Terlabi: Mr Speaker, I think that every job has its requirement of skill set. If you go into the laws that we have, we have a prescription for who becomes a registrar, for instance, because the job requires a certain skill set. This position is being given to a particular person to execute and you need a certain skill set to do that.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I am sorry, if you go by that principle, if you are legislating a health Bill you may not put a qualification criterion for a medical doctor.

9.34 p.m.

Alhaji Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, our Standing Orders say that the Business of Parliament should be conducted in English.

But the qualification to be a Member of this House has not stated qualification under Article 94. It did not, but our Standing Orders say that Business in Parliament should be conducted in English language. But Article 94 of the Constitution does not even give a qualification to be in this House. So, I wanted clause 56 to rather start from (c).

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Let me hear the Hon Minister and I will put a Question on your proposal.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, originally when my boss started, I was not at the same level with him. But, if we look at the qualification to be a Member of Parliament, and even that of a municipal or a district chief executive, the moment we even talk about language, then we are going back to the issue of whether or not one is known in the community. Because if I live in Chorkor or Gbawe or Weija and you cannot tell me that you know me, or you agree that you know me, but I cannot express myself in the Ga language or the very usual language, then I cannot be known. It is the same thing for a community facilitator.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, do you agree that the category of the person we are talking about in Chorkor should be able to speak the Ga language?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, respectfully, yes.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Respectfully, yes? All right, let me hear the Hon Minister.

Mr Shaib: Very well, thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, I will give you the floor, but let me listen to Hon Jasaw.

Dr Jasaw: My question is, how about if tomorrow the West African Senior School Certificate changes in name? Will we come back to amend the law?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Did you read the complete rendition in clause 56(a)?

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, “...or an equivalent? All right, I am persuaded.

Dr Lartey: When we look at clause 57, which talks about the functions, this is somebody that is going to be more or less employed, with some allowance, and every job that the person goes into, there are some criteria or some qualifications that are expected of the person. When we look at clause 57(j), it talks about the person being able to prepare and submit quarterly reports, as required by the District Social Protection Implementation Committee. So how will the person write, prepare and submit the report? So, I think it is important that it stands as it is if the issue is not with the level.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Habib Iddrisu, having listened to the Minister, do you still insist on your proposed amendment?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I cited Parliament as an example.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, do you insist on your amendment, so that I will put the Question for the House to take decision.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Yes, Mr Speaker, I insist on my amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I will put the Question on the amendment proposed by Hon Habib Iddrisu that the (a) and (b) of clause 56 be deleted.

Question put and amendment negated.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Prof Nyarko?

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, with respect, clause 56(b) says:

“...is proficient in reading and writing the English language.”

But when we go to (c), it says:

“...is able to communicate effectively in the local language of the community”.

I have a proposed amendment that, instead of saying “proficient”, we can *delete* “is proficient in reading and writing” and *insert* “able to read and write the English language” or “can read and write the English language”. That is simple than to say “proficient”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Sometimes, what I do not like is Hon Members sitting down after putting the Question on the clause, then they get up. No, this particular clause has been debated for long. So, what is your proposal for the (b)?

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I am saying that we should *delete* “is proficient in reading and writing” and *insert* “can read and write the English language” or “is able to read and write the English language”, than to say, “proficient” —[*Interruption*—]When it came to our own local language, we did not talk about proficient. Why do we do injustice to our own languages.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Nyarko, when we say “proficient”, what do we mean?

Prof Nyarko: Why do we do injustice to our own languages? When it came to local language, we did not say proficient. We said, “is able to communicate” and I am saying that it is proper for us to say the person can read and write the English language or is able to read and write, than to say proficient. So, Mr Speaker, with respect, this is a proposed amendment, and it is not an imposition. It is just a suggestion.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I will put the Question on his proposed amendment.

Yes, are we going to debate this?

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, maybe a little bit of persuasion may let him abandon it. We may not be interested in voting all the time in a partisan nature. This is a divided House. What the Hon Member is seeking to do is that, if we are treating local language and foreign language, we must treat them in equal wavelengths. That is basically the gravamen of his argument. And that if we are minded and are using “proficient” and “able”, it may seem discriminatory.

The explanation is that, whereas in English language, there is a system of measuring proficiency clearly established, most local languages do not have that system. And without the benefit of that system, it is difficult to qualify it. But if there is assurance that we can have that system, then we can just

replace the other one with proficient, and then we can address the concern therein. But I think that the point made is a very valid point. We should not be seen to be jettisoning our local language for the foreign language. The only explanation I can give is that, because English language is structured with a system of measuring proficiency, but our local languages do not have such a system, it is alright to say “to be able to communicate in our local language”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: More so, the local language does not require you to write. It is only communication. So, for me, I do not see any big deal for us to be—But I will put a Question on your amendment.

Question put and amendment negatived.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes? I hope you are not taking me back to what I have put the Question on. If that is the case, kindly resume your seat?

Dr Fred Kyei Asamoah: Yes, Mr Speaker, with your leave.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I ask, are you taking me back to what I have put the Question on? Because you are supposed to take part in that debate, but you cannot wait till after putting the Question before you get up. I am not inclined to grant my leave if you are taking me back to what I put the Question on.

Clause 56 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let me place this on record. I have been in this House for a very long time. I know how a clause can be delayed, so when those tactics are being played, I know it.

Clause 57 — Functions of Community Facilitator.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairperson of the Committee?

Rev Ntoso: Mr Speaker, there is no proposed amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of the House. Hon Members, let us consider clause 57.

Yes, Hon Jerry Ahmed Shaib?

Mr Shaib: Sorry, Mr Speaker. The Majority Leader made an intervention on clause 57 to the extent that—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, propose that amendment and it will be carried.

9.44 p.m.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, it has to do with the view of partisan politics that whoever the community facilitator is, should not come into that office engaging in partisan politics, so we should just have a clause or something for that. I am just reminding us because he made it—He says a community facilitator and all of that, so, maybe, a new paragraph (g) could be, “a community facilitator should not hold

that office in a partisan manner”. I do not know, you can—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, I would ask the drafters to give us the rendition.

Mr Shaib: Yes, so they can.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, so it will be taken as 57(2), so that it will be a proviso. So, we will then have 57(1) and 57(2) and the drafters will give us the rendition.

Any more proposed amendments on 57?

Mr Shaib: So, are they going to give us the rendition?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, they will do the rendition. If there are no amendments, I will put the Question on clause 57.

Clause 57 to 62 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 63 — Conflict of interest.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Chairperson of the Committee?

Rev Ntoso: Mr Speaker, there is no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the consideration of the House.

Hon Members, any proposed amendments?

Mr Addo-Kenneth: Mr Speaker, with respect, if you indulge me, I just wanted to seek—Because at the time for the District Social Protection Implementation Team, I wanted to seek information on who would pay the allowances. It would inform me in terms of the consultation because I heard the Minister talk—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, if you take about 10 Bills of this House, you will see this particular provision. It is a settled provision.

Mr Addo-Kenneth: Because of the decentralised nature and the Local Governance and Decentralisation Act, that is why I want to ask the Minister.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, it says:

“A member of the National Social Protection Committee, a District Social Protection Implementation Team and a Community Facilitator shall be paid an allowance approved by the Minister in consultation with the Minister responsible for Finance”.

Under what condition will the Minister for Finance approve payment?

Mr Addo-Kenneth: Mr Speaker, I just wanted guidance from the Minister whether they would be paid by the district assemblies or they will receive the allowance—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, if the districts are going to be paid by the

district assembly, does the Minister for Finance determine that? Payments that are made at the district level, does the Minister for Finance determine that?

Mr Addo-Kenneth: Yes, the Minister for Finance issues guidance and have lower ceilings and upper ceilings.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That is not true. Payment of allowance to district assembly members has never been determined by the Minister for Finance.

Mr Addo-Kenneth: Respectfully, Mr Speaker, there are ranges and it is based on internally generated fund (IGF), but there are lower ceilings. If you check the guidance, there are lower ceilings for allowances. There are lower ceilings for end-of-service benefits. That is why when the Adenta issue came up, they indicated that they were challenging the Ministry on the ceiling that the Minister for Finance had released.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us look at Article 250(2), so that we do not throw dust into the eyes of the people.

“The emoluments of Presiding Member of a District Assembly and other members of the Assembly shall be determined by the District Assembly and paid out of the Assembly’s own resources”.

So why are you saying these are determined by the Minister for Finance?

Mr Addo-Kenneth: Mr Speaker, I indicated that the Ministry of Finance

issues guidance. I do not have the guidance, but if you look at the last emolument—*[Interruption]*—Please, even at the end of the year, there was a case, where the members of the Adentan Municipal Assembly were challenging the ceilings that had been brought for their end-of-service benefits because they had more to pay and the ceilings that the Ministry had released were too low for them. These are facts, so I wanted to enquire whether the allowances would be borne by the central government, the Ministry or at the local level and based on that, it would have informed my proposal, but this is not a matter for us to litigate, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, that is why I indicated to you that if you take 1,001 Bills passed by this House, this is a regular rendition and it is only when payment would be approved by the Minister for Finance that the Minister does the determination with approval—But the Constitution is clear as to what happened at the district level, so I cannot be convinced that, at the district level, it is determined by the Minister for Finance when the Constitution is clear, so you cannot be correct in that regard.

Yes, I think I have to put a Question on the entire 63, but before putting the Question on the entire 63, let us look at 63(5):

“Where the Ministry becomes aware that a public officer under the Ministry has an interest in a matter before the Ministry, the Chief Director shall, in

consultation with the Minister, make a determination as to whether the interest is likely to interfere significantly with a social protection programme”.

So, what if the interest does not significantly interfere?

9.54 p.m.

In law, we say the *res ipsa loquitur*, the matter speaks for itself. Do we *delete* “significantly”? The proposal is that “significantly” should be deleted from the second to the last line of clause 63(5). I will put the Question.

Question put and amendment agreed to.

Mr A. Alhassan: Mr Speaker, then we will have to look at the following sub-clause as well, which is clause 63(6), because it also uses the same word “significantly”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, propose the amendment.

Mr A. Alhassan: Where the Minister determines that, yes—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, so it is consequential. It should be deleted in clause 63(6) as well.

Clause 63 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clauses 64 and 65 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 66 — Regulations.

Rev Ntoso: Mr Speaker, there is no advertised amendment.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, maybe, with this one, I will seek clarity first. This proposed Bill establishes the Social Protection Fund, but in the contemplation of the “Regulation”, we have only envisioned the Livelihood Empowerment Against Poverty Programme, the National Household Registry and the regulation made to that effect to regulate that. But I have not seen any expression of how the regulation also reflects how we administer the Fund accordingly.

I do not have off the top of my head any amendment, but, maybe, for the reflection of the drafting unit, if it is something that has to be contemplated. If it is already there, I am guided. Otherwise, I think that the Fund—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Would your concern not be addressed by clause 66(1)?

Dr Mahama: “For the effective and efficient implementation of this Act”. I think that, maybe, everything in the Act, but the specific mention of the Livelihood Empowerment Against Poverty Programme is within the Act and the Fund, too, is within the Act. So, once we mention—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Have you also looked at clause 66(c)?

Dr Mahama: I am well guided, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: May I put the Question?

Prof Beyuo: Mr Speaker, may I, respectfully, suggest that we give some time limit within which the Ministry should bring this L. I.?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Did you read the provision? It is copiously stated here that:

“The Minister shall, within 12 months after coming into force of this Act, by legislative instrument, make Regulations”.

So, the time is there. Should I put the Question?

Clause 66 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 67 — Interpretation.

Rev Ntoso: Mr Speaker, there is no advertised amendment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: There was a proposal that a “vulnerable society” should be defined.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, it is rather “vulnerable communities”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, vulnerable communities. So, do you have the rendition for the definition?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I have a proposal; I do not know whether

they have a rendition. Do you have a rendition, Chairperson?

Rev Ntoso: Yes, Mr Speaker. Clause 67, the definition of “vulnerable communities” is:

“Vulnerable communities mean communities with a significant number of people who are in need of social protection and are eligible to receive social protection”.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, with the greatest of respect, that definition does not come out clearly as one vulnerable community.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, bring us the one that will come out.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, I think that vulnerable communities mean communities that are at risk of poverty, social inequality and susceptible to national and local emergencies.

Mr Speaker, this definition reflects on the object of the Bill, which talks about providing for chronic poverty and providing for communities or people that are affected by national and local emergencies. I think that definition of vulnerable communities reflects the object of the Bill.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You see, if you look at clause 1, it says:

“This Act applies to a person who falls within the following category of vulnerability:

(a) chronically poor;

(b) economically at-risk;

(c) socially vulnerable; and

(d) a person affected by national or local emergencies.”

So, at least, for clause 1(a), (b), and (c), we should be looking at the definition of vulnerable communities along that.

Yes, is there a further amendment? Let us hear the further amendment then we will come to you.

Rev Ntoso: Mr Speaker,

“Vulnerable communities mean communities with a significant number of people who are chronically poor, socially and economically at-risk and in need of social protection and are eligible to receive social protection”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well, that is the new rendition and it is for the consideration of the House.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I was thinking that we could look at it from a different angle. I just worked on one and I just wanted to share. It is on the definition of the “vulnerable community”. Just a second, Mr Speaker, I lost it, so I am going back to it. Please, pardon me—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, do I direct that we see the drafters to help in coming out with a definition of a vulnerable community?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, let me bring my rendition.

It says that it is a group of people with characteristics or circumstances that make them more susceptible to harm, disadvantage or exploitation. This could be due to factors like age, income, health, social status or living conditions.

Mr Speaker, that is the one I agree with.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Drafters, take note.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, I think that both definitions come out clearly in defining what a vulnerable community is. It is safe to say that if we are adopting the rendition by the Chairperson, we should *delete* the last part, which says “and are eligible to receive social protection”. We should just terminate it at the definition and not add that bit.

So, once the draftspersons are contemplating both definitions, I strongly propose that we *delete* the part that says, “and are eligible to receive social protection”. That part is not necessary.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Drafters, take note.

10.04 p.m.

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, I think the drafters of the definitions should fine-tune it. If not, everybody will bring out their own definitions I know.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any more on clause 67?

Mr Alhassan: I would like us to take a look at the definition given to residents on page 41. I just need clarification because the way it defines resident; I do not get it. “Resident means a person who is not a citizen of Ghana but lives in Ghana.” Is that a definition we want to have?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, are we talking about non-resident or rather resident?

Yes, Chairperson, that is the issue being raised at page 41 on the definition of resident. How can the definition of a resident mean “a person who is not a citizen of Ghana but lives in Ghana?” Then they are non-citizens but not a resident. So, drafters, I think the definition of resident features in several laws. So, let us pick the appropriate rendition and put it there. So, Hon Member for Yendi, thank you very much for your observation.

Any more on clause 67?

Clause 67 as amended ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Yes, so they may use the word “include” instead of “mean”.

Hon Members, let us turn to page 44, the first schedule.

First Schedule — Criteria for Social Assistance.

The First Schedule ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Second Schedule — Flagship Social Protection Programmes.

Dr Jasaw: Mr Speaker, on the Second Schedule, “productive inclusion”. Is that correct? Is that a term of art or what does it mean?

Could the Hon Chairperson help?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It has been used in the Bill several times.

The Second Schedule ordered to stand part of the Bill.

The Third Schedule — Specialised agencies and the role of the specialised agencies in social protection.

Yes, Dr Asamoah?

Hon Members, let me use the opportunity to state that you can even draw my attention to it. If I ask, “it is for the consideration of the House.” That is the point that we should make the amendment. But I realise that instead of reading the Bill and making our notes ahead of the Consideration, we rather read the Bill while we are here. That is what is partly causing the problem. So sometimes after I put the Question, then Hon Members get up. Because I recall

that, I put the Question on a particular clause two times.

Yes, Hon Asamoah, you have the floor.

Dr Asamoah: Mr Speaker, for the Third Schedule, this House just passed the Medical Trust Fund Bill and here we only have the National Health Insurance Authority (NHIA). So, if we can make provisions for that one as well.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We make provisions for?

Dr Asamoah: The Medical Trust Fund. Because most of the vulnerable people that will be benefiting from this fund will also be captured here.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So which particular schedule are you referring to?

Dr Asamoah: The Third Schedule.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, the Third Schedule, which provision?

Dr Asamoah: Well, we can have another slot just right after the National Health Insurance Authority. Because not everybody will be covered by the National Health Insurance Authority as it stands right now.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, drafters, can we consider using the word “include”? Chairperson of the Committee, can we consider using the word “include”? “Specialised Agency and the role of the Specialised Agency in Social

Protection, including...” So that we do not limit it to those listed here.

Ms Ntoso: Yes, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Dr Asamoah, has what you are talking about been mentioned in the Bill?

Dr Asamoah: No, Mr Speaker, this Act has just been passed by the House and the beneficiaries will have to come through. Most of the beneficiaries of this vulnerable society will also have to benefit from that. So, it should find its expression here.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: But you realise that the Bill made mention of the National Disaster Management Organisation (NADMO), the Community Water and Sanitation Agency and the Commission for Technical and Vocational Education and Training. So, all those that are provided by the Schedule here are mentioned specifically in the Bill. But I have not seen that mentioned in the Bill.

Dr Asamoah: Mr Speaker, I believe as of the time of the drafting of this Bill, that Bill had not been passed by the House yet. Now that the House has already passed the Medical Trust Fund Bill, it should find its expression here as well.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, I will direct the drafters to liaise with the Minister to include it in the Schedule. Having regard to clause 8 of the Bill.

Yes?

10.14 p.m.

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, if we check the Third Schedule, all the institutions mentioned here; we have National Disaster Management Organisation (NADMO), Community Water and Sanitation Agency (CWSA), Commission for Technical and Vocational Education and Training (TVET), National Health Insurance Authority (NHIA), Youth Employment Agency (YEA) and the Ghana Enterprise Agency (GEA) but what he is referring to is a fund and not an agency. All the institutions mentioned here are agencies. So I want us to include the Trust Fund.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Is the Trust Fund not established as a body corporate?

Mr Acheampong: It is, but here we did not include the National Health Insurance Fund, it was the agency that we included and not the Fund. The Youth Employment Agency as well. We cannot find any Fund included in the Third Schedule.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I would direct the draftspersons to liaise with the sector Minister to see whether or not the Fund, in the circumstances, could be included, having regard to the fact that Clause 8 is talking about collaboration with specialised agencies and agencies responsible for flagship programme. If so, then the draftspersons would include it accordingly.

Mr Addo-Kenneth: Mr Speaker, you have made a very important observation in terms of the delays when you are putting the question after the House has finished the consideration.

Mr Speaker, consistently, I have been informing you and asking that—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Do you have a proposed amendment?

Third Schedule ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Long Title ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we have come to the end of the Consideration Stage of the Social Protection Bill, 2025.

Deputy Majority Leader, any indication?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, we are taking item number 15.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I think the agreement we had was that we will finish the Consideration Stage and then we would take the item numbered 15 tomorrow.

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, you are right, but after that, we had an engagement among ourselves and we agreed to take the Third Reading.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. You have to communicate those

engagements to me because I was part of the decision at the pre-Sitting.

MOTION

Request for the Second Consideration of the Social Protection Bill, 2025

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu (NPP — Tolon): Mr Speaker, I am coming under Standing Order 171(1). Mr Speaker, with your permission, I read:

“(1) Where a Member intends to delete, amend or introduce a provision in a Bill which has passed through the Consideration Stage, the Member may, immediately before a sponsor rises to move the motion for the Third Reading of the Bill, move that the Bill passes through a second Consideration either wholly or in respect of a particular part or parts of the Bill or some proposed new clause or the new Schedule.”

Mr Speaker, I beg to move that the Social Protection Bill, 2025 be taken through a Second Consideration Stage.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you should have added the provisions that you want to be taken through a second consideration.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, clause 32(b).

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Only clause 32(b)?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Yes, only clause 32(b).

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, the Motion is moved for the second consideration of Clause 32(b) of the Bill.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, I second the Motion.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved accordingly.

BILL — SECOND CONSIDERATION STAGE

Social Protection Bill, 2025

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Clause 32(b) is to be taken through Second Consideration.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I beg to move, clause 32(1)(b), *delete* “for social protection interventions” and *insert* “make specific allocation for the Social Protection Fund”.

Mr Speaker, because the Ministry of Finance does allocations to the Ministry of Gender and Social Protection—If this particular provision stands, as it will read, “The Ministry responsible for Finance shall make specific allocation for social protection interventions and the Social Protection Fund.” This will be a duplication of “the release of the fund” because there will be one for social protection interventions which will be different. So, the new rendition should read, “The Ministry responsible for Finance shall make specific allocations for the Social Protection Fund.”

10.24 p.m.

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, I support the proposed amendment on the back of the fact that this Bill creates the Social Protection Fund. And this Fund is supposed to be funded and if you read clause 34, it means moneys approved by Parliament which are moneys passing through the Consolidated Fund to support this particular Bill. The mischief that the proposed amendment seeks to cure is to avoid the fear of duplication of social intervention.

This is because in line with the object of the of the Bill, we say we want to integrate social protection funding which was even debated in the earlier part of the Consideration Stage.

So, when we delete the social protection intervention, it makes it tidier—The Ministry’s role in terms of this Bill is to contribute money to the social protection fund and that will avoid the duplication. When we leave it this way, that means we are treating social protection intervention differently from social protection under the Social Protection Fund. Meanwhile the fund is created to provide social protection intervention. So, once we just leave it as providing funding to the Fund, it cures the matter, so that there will not be that sense of repetition.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Dr Jasaw. Mr Speaker, I am not persuaded by the arguments put by my Colleagues on the other Side. Here, the current rendition presupposes that the Minister for Finance, based on a specific

government policy, may give some emphasis and therefore, additional financing to social protection interventions, different from the funds allocated to the Social Protection Fund. So, it does not necessarily mean that if the Minister for Finance is providing additional social intervention financing, it is a repetition. No, it may be additional financing for specific prioritised projects that are of social nature.

So, I think that this should give more leverage and allow for possibly, more financing for the social intervention needs of this country. This will allow it, but if we restrict it to just the Fund—I think we are rather restricting it and that is counterproductive, especially for us as social democrats; we reject this completely.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us look at the application of the Fund in clause 1, particularly (d):

“...person affected by a national or a local emergency”.

Now, this may be an unforeseen contingency, and you know how budgets are prepared. Once it is an unforeseen contingency, in an event where the budget is prepared, and budgets should be for specific activities, it can only make a small provision for miscellaneous, and there is this kind of national or local emergency, are we saying that the Ministry of Finance cannot make allocations for these interventions?

Dr Mahama: Mr Speaker, this point actually supports the point we are making, that there may be emergencies, local or national, that demands that the Ministry of Finance make allocations of resources to support those social protection interventions. But that money cannot be spent outside of the Social Protection Fund. This is because if we read clause 5 (d), the Ministry of Gender, Children and Social Protection shall:

“develop linkages among social protection programmes to

(i) enable the integrated delivery of social protection programmes.”

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, that is between agencies. Do you understand? That is why those collaborations will come. Let us say this House is supposed to approve funds for the social protection in the country. The fund will be approved without knowing the emergency situation that will confront us. So, if the law does not make provision for the Minister, then it means when those situations crop up, the hands of the Minister will be tied. This is because he has already made releases from the approved money for the social protection programmes.

But these emergencies can occur. For instance, we were in this country and did not know the country would be hit with COVID-19, and all of a sudden there was COVID. One cannot hold the Minister to the approved budget because at the time one is giving the approval to the budget, such unforeseen contingency—Do you understand? That is why in the main

Budget, we make provision for Contingency Fund. But in this specific budget to sector ministries, we do not make such provision. It is only the Minister for Finance, in situations of that nature, that can come to this particular House to seek for an approval to use money from the Contingency Fund for those social interventions, which will definitely not be coming from the allocation to the social protection fund. It is a legitimate point that you have raised, but that is how we are also looking at it.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I think you have thrown more light on the issue and it is clearer now. I just adverted my mind to National Disaster Management Organisation (NADMO). If there is a disaster, it is supposed to go through some social intervention, we do not necessarily have to come to the Fund. But my thinking was that, if there are other social interventions, why do we not use the Fund? But with your explanation, it is clearer. So, I will abandon —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, NADMO will be given an allocation, but there can be a disaster beyond the intake of NADMO. The Minister should be able to intervene by making funds available.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I am abandoning it because of your explanation, not because of what Dr Jasaw said, that they are a socialist party. So, Mr Speaker, I am abandoning it because of your explanation.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. We have again come to the end of the Second Consideration Stage of the

Social Protection Bill, 2025. Do we then take the item numbered 15 and wash our hands from it?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: No, Mr Speaker. At the moment, we are constrained. We cannot do Motion 15. We would rather go back to continue the debates. Mr Speaker, we still have three people—[Uproar]—I do not know why they are saying “ah” when they are talking about 24-Hour economy. I do not understand. It is just 10 p.m. and they are already tired.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, Order! Hon Members, it may interest you to know that he is justified. I have been in this House and when we are getting to the end of the Meeting, sometimes we spend day and night here. So, if the pleasure is that we should conclude the number of people who are to speak today and go back to—

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, because, we said tomorrow our Leaders are concluding, we have already informed people that they would debate today, so they have still been waiting up till now. It cannot be the case that we are just going to abandon it. So, Mr Speaker, we are constrained on Motion 15 because of obvious reasons, but we can continue with the debate. The Third Reading is less than one or two minutes, so we can take that tomorrow. So let us continue with the debate.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Habib Iddrisu, today I was going to highly commend you for your cooperation. I know the challenge of the

Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection. If you could allow the Motion to be taken for five minutes, then we come back to the debate, I will be happy.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I have abandoned my earlier position that we should take Motion 15 tomorrow. I also want to make amends and agree that we can take it today, subject to the fact that we conclude with the three people left on the debate and do the Third Reading.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I promise you that we are left with three each to speak. If we take the Motion, I will be in the Chair, even if the Hon Second Deputy Speaker is not around, to take those three. I give my words to it.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I cannot litigate this further.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Motion number 15. Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection.

10.34 p.m.

BILLS — THIRD READING

Social Protection Bill, 2025

Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection (Dr Agnes Naa Momo Lartey): Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

That the Social Protection Bill, 2025 be now read for the Third time.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Motion moved for the Third Reading. Any seconder?

First Deputy Minority Whip (Alhaji Habib Iddrisu): Mr Speaker, there is a difficulty here on the Third Reading of this Bill. Mr Speaker, ordinarily, you know I have related with you. With respect to you, if it will please you—Mr Speaker, we are in a difficulty here. If we can do it tomorrow — *[Interruption]*

Mr Speaker, I say so in all—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, the Motion has been moved already by the consensus of the House. It is just a matter of seconding the Motion and then we will put the Question.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I am drawing your attention to something. Mr Speaker, as you said today, I have—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, today I observe you are on point.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker—

Chairperson of the Committee (Rev Helen Adjoa Ntoso): Mr Speaker, I second the Motion.

Alhaji Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, like I told you early on, I am just in a difficulty here and I do not want to say certain things on the Floor. But I want to still plead with you that we should leave it for tomorrow morning. Mr Speaker, considering what is happening in the

Chamber, if you go ahead to put the Question—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, let us be clear. We have been holding on to the Minister to be with us and not to travel for official business. Do we agree that in her absence, any available Minister can move the Motion for and on her behalf?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Yes, Mr Speaker, we are in agreement. Because if we go now to put the Question, we will not satisfy Article 104 of the Constitution. And in the case of *Justice Abdulai vs the Republic*, it would be a problem. It is not good for the image of Parliament. Mr Speaker, I urge that—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, there is no case like *Justice Abdulai vs the Republic*. Justice Abdulai has not committed any crime to be prosecuted by the Republic. So, it is Attorney-General.

Second Deputy Majority Whip (Mr Richard Acheampong): Mr Speaker, we will still plead with the Hon Habib Iddrisu because initially, we agreed among ourselves. You called the Minister to move the Motion, and she did that and he turned around that—Either he received a call or a text message—It is not fair. We do not treat human beings this way. No, it is not fair.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, time is being spent. Sometimes we agree and disagree. So, if the sense of the House is to take that Motion—

Mr Acheampong: The Chairperson for the Committee has seconded the Motion.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us just not cause any further confusion. What do we do? Should I adjourn the House? Because if we cannot agree on—

Second Deputy Minority Whip (Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib): Mr Speaker, I think that you will bear with us that we have shown total cooperation and we are very minded to get all of these things sorted. Mr Speaker, sometimes it is just for our Colleagues on the other Side to appreciate that we are not fighting. We are working together. As far as we are doing so, we should do that with so much honesty and love. It is not just about always going on this tangent.

Mr Speaker, it is almost 11 p.m. For some of the people making noise —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Shaib, I am telling you that by experience in this House, when I was here, sometimes we would leave the Chamber at 3 a.m., particularly when we are getting to the end of the Meeting like this. So, as for that one, it is something that is usual with the practice of Parliament. But if we decide to take adjournment at this point, what will happen is that we will have to agree that tomorrow, the list to be exhausted here—We would take these three debaters on each Side and the Leaders will conclude. Because there are outstanding Motions, including the current Motion that is supposed to be taken. Hon Patrick

Boamah has about two or three Motions on the subsidiary legislation. Probably if you add this one, we will have those four Motions. We can curtail the debate to three people each, and then the Leaders will conclude.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I think it would be a good idea, so that we can call it a day till tomorrow. Third Reading is less than two minutes, so we will do it in the morning and zoom into the debate.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Deputy Majority Leader?

Deputy Majority Leader (Mr George Kweku Ricketts-Hagan): Mr Speaker, I think what has happened this evening is really unfair. If Hon Member has agreed that we can move the Motion and the Motion has already been moved, if there is any consultation to be done outside this Chamber, that consultation should be done before decisions are made in the Chamber, but not to put us in a position where we have to go and do some consultation and decide to change our mind in the middle of the procedure.

Mr Speaker, we have gone past five hours, so we are actually in your hands.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us not drag this particular issue.

Yes, Hon Acheampong.

Mr Acheampong: Mr Speaker, I am told the Leader did say that we are in your hands, but I think we can still take the Motion numbered 15—

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, we have come to you. You are the bosom of wisdom. At this point in time, I do not understand why we are going back and forth on this matter.

10.44 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, for me, we need to be decisive. It is either we are taking the Motion or we are not. You cannot assure that we are taking the Motion, then the Motion will be moved, I will call for the secondment of the Motion, and it is at that stage that you will be saying that we should not take the Motion.

This is a House that the Leaders agree and disagree, but our agreement and disagreement on certain things are at the pre-sitting meeting or leaders can even engage.

Yes?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, you will recall that a similar incident occurred during the consideration of the Gold Board Act. We agreed with all the Leadership on that row and the Majority Leader came in and disagreed saying, he was not a part of that agreement. So, whatever clause we were supposed to have stopped at, we did not and we proceeded.

Mr Speaker, society is dynamic. Somebody thought about something and

decided that let us reconsider it and come back tomorrow—*[Interruption]* It is only, with all due deference—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: And Jerry, these days, you have not been attending pre-sitting meetings, why?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, sometimes it is a matter of lorry fare. Since this Government came in, it has been very difficult for me to even get money for lorry fare. So, Mr Speaker, that could be the situation.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No, with this one, Hon Jerry Ahmed Shaib, you have a very legitimate point, in the sense that I do not know; they have started deductions—*[Laughter]* They have started the deductions for the car loans and the Hon Member is still complaining about transport. Deputy Majority Leader, do you have something to say in response?

Mr Ricketts-Hagan: Mr Speaker, you are absolutely right. The deductions have already started and the money, I believe, is also in. That is all. I think we were told precisely how long the deductions will take for Members to be able to cover the full amount. So, it has to be started at some point. It has been a practice for quite some time.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, Hon Jerry Ahmed Shaib, very soon, your concern will be addressed. It is a legitimate concern, so I agree perfectly with you. As a first-timer, I know what I went through, the challenges with the transportation issues; particularly, if

your car boot was not big those days. This was because we were operating from our car boots; we did not even have offices at that time.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I thank you very much for thinking about the welfare of myself and my Colleagues. I appreciate that, but since we are still talking about welfare, Mr Speaker, you have been in this chair for so long and it is not as if you have moved in and out. Think about it and especially, against the backdrop that we have some of our Colleagues visiting the hospitals and coming back with some serious situations of health.

Mr Speaker, thank you. It is just tomorrow.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the Majority Leader and I had a gentleman's understanding to proceed with the Consideration Stage. We are done with consideration. The Third Reading is consequential, once we are done with the Consideration Stage and there is no further application to take us to the Second Consideration Stage—*[Interruption]*—I am talking about now, that there is no further application, by way of clarity.

With Third reading, tomorrow morning or afternoon we are coming. Colleagues, when we all talk—And I do not like us making things difficult for our Speaker. It is like NPP–NDC matter. That was not the understanding we had. My respected Chair, that was not the understanding we had. Our position earlier was that having done the

Consideration up to a point—Hon Deputy Majority Whip, you do not have the numbers to take a decision. We are trying to—*[Interruption]* All right, that is what you—Colleagues, if you act this way, you breach good faith—*[Interruption]*—You are now tired. If we have an understanding, let us go by it to the letter.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us have some order.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I needed to conclude; unless, you are cutting—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, when we reach an agreement to do certain things, I am personally not happy when we go back and we are placing certain things on the record. So, let us further engage.

Hon Minority Leader, I am ordinarily not supposed to hold brief for the Minister, but the Minister is trying to engage because she has a programme to attend tomorrow.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, we heard all—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Before you come in, the Clerks-at-the-Table will talk to you.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I agree. I will hold back and listen while you place this matter on ice. No problem, I will listen to him. We can start the debate and then finish the engagement, if we are able to reach a consensus—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, in fact, going back to the Motion numbered 8 to continue the debate, I will then give the floor to Hon Fred Agbenyo. I think you are the Vice Chairman—Then it means that you are speaking for only five minutes.

So, we are back to Business. Hon Members, let us have some order.

Hon Fred Agbenyo, the floor is now yours.

MOTION

Mid-Year Budget Review, 2025

[Resumption of debate from Column 109]

Mr Fred Kwesi Agbenyo (NDC — Guan): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the Motion on the Mid-Year Review of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana.

Mr Speaker, as the Akans will say, *s3 agrɔ nu b3 sɔ aa, efiri anopa*. To wit, the introduction of every event tells how the event will eventually end. I sat in the Chamber and listened to the Minister for Finance when he presented the Mid-Year Budget Review and in paragraph 314, he spoke about the state of the economy that we inherited and with your leave, I quote:

“314. Upon assumption of office in January this year:

- i. we were handed an economy in deep distress;

- ii. a country with dispirited citizens;
- iii. trust and faith in our leaders were at an all-time low;
- iv. the fundamentals were not only weak, but broken; and
- v. the misery and suffering were palpable.”

10.54 p.m.

That is the state of the economy that we inherited.

Mr Speaker, it is obvious that we have turned the corner. Ghanaians can breathe a sense of hope that not too long ago, our Colleagues on the other Side when in government spent over GH¢30 billion in the name of cleaning the banking sector challenges. They created huge unemployment, closed down all the financial institutions and today we barely can mention of any bank that is in the hands of Ghanaians.

Mr Speaker, under our watch, we have succeeded in reviving the NIB that had almost gone down completely. We have maintained employment and we have kept that bank in the hands of Ghanaians.

Mr Speaker, as I listened to the Minister for Finance, that God willing this year the Government is going to build a bridge over River Oti, there was joy and total celebration among the people who used that corridor. If you have ever travelled to Krachi and

beyond, to Bimbilla, to Yendi, to Tamale and then you get to Dambai after six o'clock only to be told that you cannot cross over the river and that you have to sleep at a river bank, then you appreciate what it means for a government to want to put a bridge over that river.

Mr Speaker, as I was walking in this morning, assembly members from my Constituency called me and they were very excited that since we began this local government system in 1998, for the first time, a government has recognised the work that assembly members are doing in our communities and that Government has decided to pay them some allowances at the end of every month. Mr Speaker, the amount of money they are paying them as allowances is far higher than money that they paid to Nation Builders Corps (NABCO) workers under the erstwhile administration.

Mr Speaker, the chiefs and opinion leaders in our communities are happy that for the first time, the money that comes to the District Assemblies, I am talking about the District Assemblies Common Fund, hitherto, the entire money will be depleted in Accra and something very little will get to the Assemblies.

On this occasion, more than 80 per cent of the money are going to the Assemblies for specific projects and activities within the districts. For the first time, we will see new markets coming up in the districts. For the first time, we are going to see Community Health Planning and Services (CHPS)

compounds completed in the Districts. For the first time, we are going to see local economy —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, well, your time is up. I will proceed to give the floor to Hon Nana Osei-Adjei. You also have five minutes.

Nana Osei-Adjei (NPP — New Juaben North): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. It surprises me that this time around, the Hon Minister for Finance did not go to the market to go and see the market women before preparing the Mid-Year Budget Review. Because in his first Budget, he was all over the market; Agbogbloshie, Makola, I think he even went to the Koforidua market. Mr Speaker, if he had gone to the market, I think he would have taken national security operatives with him to the market because he would not have found it easy with the market women.

Mr Speaker, these are market women, our sisters, our aunties, who were promised of a brilliant idea to serve them through a well-crafted Women's Development Bank. Mr Speaker, I do not know when this bank will come to fruition; whether it is going to be a rural bank. Mr Speaker, the NDC Government has established a social contract with the market women to establish this bank and it is something they have to take upon themselves and establish. They rather suggested that they are going to bring GHC51 million to start the bank. Mr Speaker, the GHC51 million is not even in. The GHC51 million they promised, out of the GHC400 million or GHC 800 million, according to the Act that set up

banks in this country—We have the Banks and Specialised Deposit-Taking Institutions Act, 2016 (Act 930) that requires GHC400 million and we have the Development Finance Institutions Act, 2020 (Act 1032) that requires between GHC600 million to GHC1 billion to set up the bank. Mr Speaker, they brought GHC51 million which has still has not found its way in the Budget.

Mr Speaker, what we are hearing now is that they want to set up women's desks across the banks. Mr Speaker, that was not what they promised the good people of Ghana. The good people of Ghana gave them overwhelming majority, all through these policies and projects they said they are going to bring.

So, Mr Speaker, I take this opportunity to inform the Minister for Finance that we actually need our Women's Development Bank, *enye saa a ɔde asem aba*. [Laughter] Mr Speaker, you are not setting up a bank —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you know the rule. You have to translate into English.

Nana Osei-Adjei: To wit, there will be trouble. Mr Speaker, setting up a bank, the New Patriotic Party headed by His Excellency Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo has done it before. We set up the Development Bank Ghana and the bank is still thriving. It is one of the best banks in Ghana so, we have the mandate. We have the way to set up a bank so, I am informing the Minister for Finance, that when he sets up those desks, we are pleading with him that the credit rates of

this funding that he is going to give to the banks, should not sit with the banks, so that he creates further Non-Performing Loans (NPLs) within our banking sector so, he can set up these banks for the New Patriotic Party to come back to power in 2028 and we will set up the Women's Development Bank for the country. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, with these few words, I thank you for the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I will now proceed to give the floor to Hon Alajor Seidu. You have five minutes.

11.04 p.m.

Mr Seidu Alhassan Alajor (NDC — Chereponi): Thank you, Mr Speaker for giving me the opportunity to contribute to this Mid-Year Budget Statement ably made by the Minister for Finance, Hon Dr Ato Baah Forson.

Mr Speaker, listening to my Colleagues from the other Side, throughout the debate, it seems their absence in the House has affected their contribution to the Budget debate. From the beginning, it looks like they are not ready to contribute to or debate this Budget. Mr Speaker, it is very clear from the Budget that Ghana is going to see a lot of growth in the coming days and in the coming months.

Mr Speaker, we have seen several good policies in this Budget that will transform the economy and put Ghana at the level of growth and development. When the President came here on 27th

February to deliver the Message on the State of the Nation, he mentioned emphatically that the economy was in a bad shape and he, John Dramani Mahama, would fix it for the betterment of Ghanaians. Today, we are seeing the results. Today, exchange rates have fallen from 17 cedis to 10 cedis to the dollar.

Interest rates have reduced drastically in this short period of John Dramani Mahama's Administration. That is the mess that he promised he was going to correct. Inflation, we all know—Just last week, during the weekend, I went to Agbogbloshie market to get two bags of yam for my family. I bought GH¢500 for two bags of yam. I could not carry it in the boot of my car — *[Hear! Hear!]*— That is the reward of good governance. The food price today, when we go to my constituency, Chereponi, people can feed three square meals with just GH¢100. That is the policy that we are talking about.

We were here when they promised Ghanaians a year of roads. I hear my Colleague, my good Brother, from Walewale, saying that in the North-East Region, we only have one road that is under the Big Push. We were here when they promised twice a year, of roads. I did not see one single road in my constituency, Chereponi, constructed during that period. We also did not see any road in the entire North-East Region during the period of the year of roads. Meanwhile, we had the Vice-President from the North-East.

He, my Colleague, was advisor to the Vice-President. It baffles me why that person would make a statement saying that we only have one single road under the Big Push in the North-East Region. Mr Speaker, I believe that the Minister for Roads and Highways has taken his time and assessed all the roads in the country. I can assure him that our region, the North-East Region, will benefit from it; about 166 constituencies will also benefit from the Road Fund. That is something that has never happened under their watch.

So, we are looking forward, Mr Speaker, to the benefit of this Budget so that Ghanaians will continue to see the good work of John Dramani Mahama. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, it is now the turn of Dr Fred Kyei Asamoah. As Chairman, you have 15 minutes.

Dr Fred Kyei Asamoah (NPP—Offinso North): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the Mid-Year Review of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy.

Mr Speaker earlier said nobody can use “419” because when he used it in the previous Parliament, he was asked to withdraw. So, today I am not going to use “419”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, I consequently direct that everything you said about “419” be expunged. We are not kidding here.

Dr Asamoah: Mr Speaker, if we look at the Mid-Year Budget Review as was presented by the Hon Minister for Finance, he made a profound statement, and I think is true because if we look at what the NPP government, Nana Addo/Bawumia Government did in recovering our economy, it shows and has been confirmed here.

If we look at chapter 3, paragraph 65, he said,

“Despite the global economic uncertainties, Ghana’s economy demonstrated robust growth in the first quarter of 2025, and the economy expanded by 5.3 per cent”.

Mr Speaker, this is true. Why? Because the first quarter was when the new Government was putting in place its Ministers. So, that means that this robust performance could not be attributed to the current Government. It is because the previous Government, Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo/Bawumia Government, had put all the things in place.

We are talking about agriculture, Mr Speaker, how long does it take one to grow cocoa and pluck it? Agriculture gave us a growth of 6.6 per cent. Mr Speaker, three months. How long does it take one to grow maize, harvest it, process it, and sell it? How long does it take one to grow rice, process it, and sell it? So, this tells us that the robust economy, which is being built on, is what the NPP Government had put in place. That is what is manifesting itself, and it has been conspicuously stated here that

the real sector performance was 5.3 per cent for the first quarter.

Even when it comes down to the service sector, it says 5.9. Definitely, it is because of the good things, the good policies that were put in place by the New Patriotic Party governance that led to this performance. I am happy that he even went further to talk about industry, which gave us 3.4 per cent. Mr Speaker, economic growth has to be sustained. And if we want to sustain economic growth, there are five top things one looks at. One, increasing physical capital goods; two, technological improvement; three, growth of the labour force; four, an increase in human capital, and five, natural resources and trade.

Natural resources and trade, Mr Speaker, we have them. Human capital, the NPP Government initiated a lot of investment into our human capital growth. So, it saddens my heart that during the Eighth Parliament, the previous Government got a Bill laid in this hallowed Chamber that was to establish the University of Local Governance and Development. Unfortunately, Mr Speaker, we are in the seventh month, and we have not seen the Bill in this House. And the Hon Minister did not talk about it.

Mr Speaker, we are talking about sustained economic growth, the NPP economic growth that they initiated, needs to be sustained. If we can do that, that means we have to increase our labour force. That means we have to increase our human capital, quality human capital. Mr Speaker, it is quite

unfortunate that we have issues in Bawku.

11.14 p.m.

As the chairperson of the Chieftaincy Committee, I would not want to talk about this because it is very sensitive and I would not want to dwell on it. As such, we were expecting that Government could have talked about codification of our chieftaincy system, so that we can prevent similar things like this in future. We know this has been lingering for years; it is very sensitive. We cannot go there.

Mr Speaker, unfortunately, as we speak, five schools have been closed down and West African Examination Council (WAEC) examination is just around the corner, from 4th August to 19th September, 2025. What is going to happen? We were hoping and expecting that Minister for Finance would have talked about this and the plans the Government has in place for our students because they are our future.

Mr Speaker, I am happy that Ghana Education Trust Fund (GETFund) has been uncapped because that is what has been put in place and that is what the New Patriotic Party (NPP) Government would have done anyway. If we look at the 2025 Budget, we budgeted GHC3.5 billion for Free SHS, an initiative that the NPP Government did that would serve this country and take us to the levels we never thought of.

Mr Speaker, I was hoping that now that GETFund had been capped, we

would see close to 70 per cent because we are almost coming to the end of the year. We are in the seventh month, but the Free SHS policy has been given just 28 per cent. That means some contractors are suffering and some have not been paid.

Mr Speaker, they all say the sweetness of the pudding is in the eating. So, if Free SHS has been given GHC3.5 billion, why are we releasing only GHC 1 billion to the Free SHS? It is quite unfortunate. There is a slow disbursement. The question is, why? It is because, maybe, the economy is shrinking. Even though the NPP Government expanded the economy to the extent that they appropriated the first quarter Budget and made provision for resources to be used by the current Government, that is what led to the robust macroeconomic indicators that we see in the Mid-Year Budget Review. So, what is happening? Maybe the economy is shrinking; we do not know. We will see at the end of the year.

Mr Speaker, I would also like to see some update on the—The previous Government initiated digital textbooks and we are hoping that we will feed more money into these digital books, so that about 1.5 million students can have access to these tablets. So, the payment should go, so that we can have the schools using these tablets that have the digital textbooks.

Mr Speaker, my senior Colleague, Hon Minister for Education, Mr Haruna Iddrisu, on 25th June, in this Chamber, in responding to Mr Atta-Mills, said that

the Government would recruit 50,000 new teachers. He did not say over the four years. He said the Government, this year, would recruit 50,000 new teachers. Mr Speaker, there are some words that I used that you asked me to withdraw, so I would not use them. But is it wishy-washy? I know if the Hon Minister for Finance makes the money or the clearance available to my good Friend, Mr Haruna Iddrisu, he would do the recruitment, but he has not. In fact, not even one recruitment clearance was given.

Mr Speaker, remember that to sustain that good work that was left in 2024, we need to continue to grow our labour force and we need to continue to increase our human capital. Unfortunately, nothing has been heard about that 50,000 recruitment that was said. But what saddens my heart is that we have a need. Now, as we are talking, the Ghana Education Service needs no less than 40,000 teachers. The classrooms are hollow; the classrooms need teaching and non-teaching staff. So, where is the 50,000 recruitments? We all know that, in 2024, both the third and fourth quarter, there was recruitment of approximately 5,000 teachers and when the new Government came in—I believe in education and I want the Government to succeed in terms of education—5,000 teachers who were supposed to go through validation have worked for almost one year without salary and some do not even know their fate. We do not know what is happening to 5,000 teachers who were recruited under the guise of validation. They have not been paid for one year, but they have been working so hard. It is quite unfortunate.

Mr Speaker, then let me come here: I am from the Technical and Vocational Education and Training (TVET), so I have information and updates. It is quite unfortunate that a lot of institutions that are training for TVET sector have not been paid. Those who were awarded projects under Ghana Skill Development Fund (GSDF) have not been paid; it is unfortunate. Training institutions that are going through the apprenticeship programme have not been paid.

Mr Speaker, the Hon Minister talked about things in the Budget. When we go to paragraph 537 of the Budget Review, it talks about a lot of things, but I want to dwell on three issues: the National Apprenticeship Policy, the Adwumawura Programme and the One Million Coders Programme. The question we are asking ourselves is, if we really want to improve on the human capital base of this country and want to grow labour force, what is happening? We budgeted GH¢300 million for the National Apprenticeship Programme, and how much has been paid? It is GH¢21 million that has been paid. The question we ask ourselves is, where are the policies? Because if one does not have a plan, one would not know where one is going. Where are the policies? The policies that are informing our National Apprenticeship Policy.

We had a National Apprenticeship Policy that was established by the previous Government. Governance is continuum, so why are we winding around? Today, this National Apprenticeship Policy is at the Ministry of Trade, Agribusiness and Industry; tomorrow, it is at the Ministry of Youth

Development and Empowerment. We really want to have some focus. There should be some focus on what we are doing as a nation. So, that we can put our money where our mouth is.

Mr Speaker, we can properly invest in this National Apprenticeship Programme for a proper return on our investment. We talk about repackaging National Entrepreneurship and Innovation Programme (NEIP); it is good, but let us invest in it. This is the seventh month. Let us have the policies, interrogate it and help Government. We at the opposite Side want to help Government to succeed. We need the policies with proper guidelines, so that we can support.

Mr Speaker, now, let us come to the US\$3 billion for the One Million Coders Programme. There are one million people to be trained and, as we speak, we cannot even boast of 5,000 and they say they have four years. We are here. I raised some of these things when we were doing the Budget debate and we are back to it. What are we expecting to see? The previous Government set up ICT centres and we are talking about 30 specialised programmes developed. In fact, in the world of work, we need proper certifications, so that our certifications will have no bounds. What is the work of the One Million Coders Programme? What have we been able to put in? What are the structures? Let us interrogate the policies and let us support the Government to be successful; other than that four or five years will come and nothing will be done. For me, I do not really mind whatever they do. I believe that governance is continuum and the

NPP Government will come back in 2028 to support.

Mr Speaker, thank you very much.

11.24 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I will now give the floor to Hon Dickson Kyere-Duah for five minutes.

Mr Dickson Kyere-Duah (NDC — Berekum West): Thank you very much Mr Speaker, for indulging me to comment on the Mid-Year Fiscal Policy Review, which was ably delivered by the Minister for Finance.

Mr Speaker, permit me to convey to this honourable House the utmost appreciation of the good people of Berekum West and, ultimately, to the President, H. E. John Dramani Mahama, the Minister for Finance, and the Minister for Roads and Highways, for including the almighty Jinijini-Sampa Road on the list of projects to be undertaken by the Big Push Policy.

Mr Speaker, our Friends from the other Side have tried strenuously to take credit for the economic gains we are making at the moment. Mr Speaker, I beg to ask, what credit are they asking for? Are they asking for credit for the arrears of the GHC67 billion in contract areas and GHC194 billion they bequeathed to this Government in terms of the commitments they made? Are they asking for credit for the GHC1.5 billion shortfalls in the energy sector financing? Are they asking for credit for the GHC32 billion debt they left in the cocoa sector?

Are they proud of the inflation rate of 24 per cent they bequeathed to this Government? Are they celebrating the international rating of restricted default that they left when they were leaving office? Mr Speaker, are they proud of the dollar that was sprinting at horse pace, leaving the cedi on its trail at US\$1 to GH¢17?

Mr Speaker, thankfully, as a result of the prudent economic management anchored on fiscal discipline and, of course, devoid of profligate spending, the economy is back on track even though we are not completely out of the woods. Contrary to the narrative that our Friends are pushing to the effect that this Government is not spending, it is obvious, in the Mid-Year Review, that this Government is spending prudently. This Government is investing in the right areas.

Between January to June, we all know that about GH¢114 billion has been paid from the Consolidated Fund. I am very happy to announce and the good people of Berekum West are very happy that they have gotten their share of the GH¢2.7 billion released from the District Assemblies Common Fund. Mr Speaker, once again, I want to draw the attention of the House to the fact that the GH¢9.1 billion paid to the energy sector is the reason we are having the lights on.

Mr Speaker, prior to the elections, our Friends were taunting us that H. E. John Dramani Mahama, and for that matter, NDC Government would abandon the Free Senior High School (Free SHS). What they misconstrued as reviewing the

Free SHS is what we are seeing today. Between January and now, this Government has released GH¢1 billion into the Free SHS Programme, not to talk about the GH¢477 million that has been released to Livelihood Empowerment Against Poverty (LEAP) Programme for my old men in Fetentaa, Pruso, and Nkyenkyemam, benefiting from the LEAP. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, it is also important to touch on the fact that this Government really is spending in the right areas. We are very confident we are on the right track due to the trajectory that this economy is moving and we commend, once again, the leadership of this Government, H. E. John Dramani Mahama, the Minister for Finance, and the managers of this economy. Once again, thank you for indulging me. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Michael Kwasi Aidoo (NPP — Oforikrom): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the 2025 Budget Statement. I dare say that one does not flog a dead horse. Some of us knew from the beginning that the Mid-Year Budget Review did not have anything new other than the continuation of the lamentations in the main Budget. Today, I have heard our Colleagues on the other Side reiterate the point that we were not in the Chamber during the Mid-Year Budget Review and, based on that, we do not have anything to say in contribution to the Budget. Let me remind them that smart analysis does not require physical presence and that the real debate is out there. They should go out there and listen

to the people. It surprises me that they have soon forgotten the promises that they made to the Ghanaians.

Mr Speaker, they should go out there and listen to the gold dealers. The gold dealers are already crying over the price of gold. They should go out there and listen to the cocoa farmers. They are expectant of the GH¢6,000 to GH¢7,000 price per bag of cocoa and, as it stands now, it does not look so. They should go out there and listen to the cry of the public. Whenever we say anything about issues of the economy, our Colleagues will refer us to the dollar that the dollar has reduced. As I speak to you today, it has not reflected in the pockets of anybody.

Mr Speaker, we have a huge number of our population who are youth. If my Colleagues will refer to chapter 2 of their own manifesto, I refer them to page 19. On page 19 of their own the 2024 manifesto, which is the resetting agenda, they state that 30 per cent of our youth are unemployed and I was hopeful that we will find expression of opportunities that they had stated in their manifesto in the main Budget and the Mid-Year Budget. But as it stands now, if you look at the Mid-Year Budget Review, policies like the 24-Hour Economy are just policies on paper.

Mr Speaker, they have the Women's Development Bank, which my Colleagues have reiterated that the funding is woefully inadequate. They have the National Apprenticeship Programme, which pathetically, if you look at page 57 of the Mid-Year Budget

Review, all the agencies under the Ministry of Youth Development and Empowerment are struggling because they do not have the funding. If you speak to the agencies under the Ministry of Youth Development and Empowerment, their major challenge is funding and the Government did not even resource them enough to consider that our youth are unemployed.

Mr Speaker, now, there is this critical issue that I want us to look at. My attention is on the rapid industrialisation of the 24-Hour Economy, which is in the resetting agenda manifesto. Under the rapid industrialisation for jobs programme, they said they will set up agro-industrial zones in all regions, emphasis “in all regions”, based on their comparative advantage.

Establish mini-processing plants for cassava, tomatoes, fruits and vegetables.

11.34 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, where are you reading from?

Mr Aidoo: From the 2024 manifesto of the NDC, page 19, chapter—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Is that what you are holding?

Mr Aidoo: Yes. I can table it, Mr Speaker. I have it here.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Then proceed to table it. You are holding a phone and saying it is a manifesto.

Mr Aidoo: It is a Portable Document Format (PDF) full document that I am reading from, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, they said they will establish cocoa processing factories in the Western North, Eastern, Central, Ashanti, Bono, East, Ahafo, Volta and Oti Regions. They said they will revamp the textiles and cotton allied industry, facilitate the construction of, at least, 20 medium-scale animal feed processing plants, revamp the collapsing poultry industry, promote the establishment of factories for the brewing of local beers in the Upper East, Upper West and other regions.

Sadly, Mr Speaker, for all these industrial opportunities that they mentioned here, as it stands now, if we look at the Budget presented, there is zero, *zilch, hwee*, nothing in the Budget. Mr Speaker, let me tell my Colleagues that there is an Akan adage that says that *kasa tenten entɔ pɔnkɔ*. Let me translate.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Why is it that everybody wants to speak Twi in Parliament?

Mr Aidoo: Mr Speaker, let me translate. *Kasa tenten entɔ pɔnkɔ* means that long speeches do not give results. For those who do not understand, the fact that the Minister for Finance came here to read the long Mid-Year Budget Review does not mean we are seeing these things on the ground. As it stands now, none of the chocolate factories that we are expecting in these regions have been established, initiated or even

factored in the Budget. All of them are *hwee*; there is nothing there.

Mr Speaker, today, I sat here and watched my venerable Leader, Hon Ricketts-Hagan, mention that, and I quote him “nobody in their right senses would trade gold for oil”. Let me remind my senior Colleague that when the Russia-Ukraine war started, the Russians were trading gold for oil. Also, gold is a globally recognised store of value and can be traded with oil. Even on the Reuters trading platform, there is an exchange for gold and oil. So, Mr Speaker, for the record, gold can be traded for oil. For anybody to say that it does not make sense for us to trade gold for oil, the person would be disingenuous to the facts.

Mr Speaker, today, I have listened to a lot of things here. Recently, the IMF published a report in July as part of their review. In that report—I took the opportunity to read the Budget, at page 28, where the Minister for Finance also talks about the IMF gains and where we have reached. Mr Speaker, conspicuously, the Minister for Finance failed to bring forth some of the issues that the IMF had reported in their July report. Let me read. At page 18 of the IMF report as published in July 2025, the IMF says that on cocoa,

“Production during the 2024/25 season has recovered thanks to a more favorable climate and ongoing interventions to enhance productivity. (e.g., artificial pollination, mass pruning, mass spraying and hi-tech).”

The artificial pollination and mass pruning were introduced by the Akufo-Addo-Bawumia Government. It goes on to say:

“International cocoa prices have remained high...The new financing model...”

Today, I heard our senior Member say on this Floor that what the NPP Government did was to go for syndicated loans and contracting loans. Mr Speaker, the IMF says that:

“The new financing model—which reduces reliance on syndicated loans in favor of other trade financing options—appears to have reduced liquidity constraints, delivering faster payments to the farmers. Cocobod’s cash flow is expected to remain balanced during the current season.”

Mr Speaker, those who were in the Eighth Parliament will remember that in the last season, Ghana Cocoa Board did not go for syndication. So, it would be disingenuous for anybody to stand in this Chamber and say that all that the NPP Government did was to contract syndicated loans for COCOBOD. We also know, today, that one of the reasons the economy is standing on its feet is because of inflows from our cocoa proceeds. Everybody who understands cocoa knows that the main crop season started from August 2024. Currently, we are in the light crop season, so most of the gains in the main crop season were achieved under the Akufo-Addo Government.

Mr Speaker, as I end, today, I have heard my Colleagues say a lot of things. But let me remind them that, even with the energy sector, if they tell us that they are paying all the debt of the energy sector, they are taking GHC1 from my pocket. They are taking GHC1 per litre from the pockets of every Ghanaian who buys fuel. They have increased my electricity bill by 14 per cent. They have increased my water bill by 3 per cent. They have increased my insurance by over 20 per cent. While taking all this money, they come here and tell me that they are paying. To whom much is given, much is expected.

On that note—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we have exhausted the list of the debaters for today. We have sat in excess of five hours, so I will proceed to adjourn the House. The House is, accordingly, adjourned till Thursday, 31st July, 2025, at two o'clock.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was adjourned at 11.41 p.m. till Thursday, 31st July, 2025 at 2.00 p.m.

APPENDIX

MULTI-YEAR COMMITMENT AUTHORISATION ISSUED FOR ROAD PROJECT

SIN	PROJECT DESCRIPTION
1	Rehabilitation of Wa - Han Road (Km 0 - 54)
2	Upgrading of Tumu - Hamile Road (Km 40.00 - 55.00)
3	Upgrading of Tumu - Han - Lawra Road (Km 0 - 10)
4	Partial Reconstruction of Navrongo - Tumu Road (27km)
5	Rehabilitation of Wenchi- Sawla Road (Km 0+000 - Km 25+000)
6	Rehabilitation of Wenchi- Sawla Road (Km 25+000 - Km 50+000)
7	Rehabilitation of Wenchi- Sawla Road (Km 50+000 - Km 75+000)
8	Rehabilitation of Wenchi- Sawla Road (Km 75+000 - Km 100+000) Including Bamboi (3km) and Banda Nkwanta (2km) Town Roads
9	Rehabilitation of Wenchi - Sawla (Km 100+000 - 125+000) Including Tinga Town Roads (3km)
10	Rehabilitation of Wenchi - Sawla (Km 125+000 - 150+000)
11	Rehabilitation of Wenchi - Sawla (km 150+000 - 195+000) and Others (7km)
12	Rehabilitation of Techiman - Nkonsia - Wenchi Road (32.6km)
13	Construction of Dambai Bridge
14	Construction of Sunyani Outer Ring Road (17km) - Lot 1
15	Construction of Sunyani Outer Ring Road (17km) - Lot 2
16	Construction of 3rd Ring Road, Tamale -Ph. 1 (11km) - Lot 1
17	Construction of 3rd Ring Road, Tamale -Ph. 1 (11km) - Lot 2
18	Construction of 3rd Ring Road, Tamale -Ph. 1 (11km) - Lot 3
19	Construction of Kumasi Outer Ring Road Project (15km) - Lot 1
20	Construction of Kumasi Outer Ring Road Project (15km) - Lot 2

21	Construction of Kumasi Outer Ring Road Project (15km) - Lot 3
22	Rehabilitation of Gbintri - Nakpanduri Road (44km)
23	Rehabilitation of Dodo Pepesu - Nkwanta (46km)
24	Rehabilitation of Atimpoku - Asikuma Junction(0-26km)
25	Rehabilitation of Asikuma Junction - Anyirawasi (Km 26.0 - 49.4)
26	Reconstruction of Anyirawasi - Ho Tritrinu (Km 49.4 - 70.0), Ho (Guinness Deport) Ho Airport 2nd Gate (Km 0-7.7)
27	Upgrading of Akosombo-Gyakiti-Kudikope Feeder Road
28	Upgrading of Asikuma to Kpalime Feeder Road
29	Upgrading of Akwamufie Feeder Road
30	Rehabilitation of Ho - Kpetoe Road (Km 7.70 - Km 27.60)
31	Rehabilitation of Kpetoe - Aveafiadenyigba Road (Km 27+600 - Km 62+600) Including Ziope Towns Roads
32	Rehabilitation of Afiadenyigba - Penyi Road (Km 62.60 - Km 85.0) Including Dualisation of Dzodze Town Road (3.5km) And Internal Link Roads Within Dzodze and Penyi Township (3km)
33	Rehabilitation of Penyi - Aflao (Km 85+000 - 107+000)
34	Construction of Interchange at Winneba Roundabout (Km 28+200); 10 No. Footbridges; And Dualization into Winneba and Swedru Towns (4.0km)
35	Dualisation of Winneba - Cape Coast Road (30 - 54 Km)
36	Dualisation of Winneba - Cape Coast Road (54 - 79 Km)
37	Dualisation Of Cape Coast- Takoradi Road (114 - 139 Km)
38	Dualisation Of Cape Coast- Takoradi Road (139 - 164 Km)
39	Dualisation of Cape Coast- Takoradi Road (164 - 187.6km)
40	Rehabilitation of Mankessim - Ajumako - Agona Swedru Road and Others Total Length = 111km
41	Rehabilitation of Tema - Aflao Road (Km 1 - 18.30)

42	Reconstruction of Dodowa - Afiencya-Dawhenya Road (0-24.80km) & Selected Town Roads 3.0km
43	Upgrading Of Oyibi-Appolonia-Afiencya Road (21.0km)
44	Construction of Enchi - Elubo Road (71.25 Km)
45	Construction of Dadieso - Akontombra Road (Km 4.0 - Km 26.30)
46	Upgrading of Adwofua — Oseikojokrom Road (Km16-41)
47	Upgrading of Enchi - Kudjouru Pekyi (Km 0.00 Km30,00)
48	Upgrading of Enchi - Kudjouru - Pekyi (Km30.00 - Km 62.00)
49	Upgrading of Bediako Junction - Camp 15 - Sefwi Adabokrom (55km)
50	Upgrading of Bediako Junction - Camp 15 - Sefwi Adabokrom (9.5km)
51	Construction of National Route N18 - Wa - Han Road (Km 54 - 76)
52	Upgrading of Tumu - Han - Lawra Road (Km 45 - 70)
53	Upgrading of Tumu - Han - Lawra Road (Km 30 - 45)
54	Upgrading of Tumu - Han - Lawra Road (Km 10 - 30)
55	Upgrading of Tumu - Han - Lawra Road (Km 0 - 10)
56	Upgrading of Tumu - Sissili - Navrongo Road (Km 0 - 15)
57	Upgrading of Tumu - Chuchuliga - Navrongo (km 15-47) including construction of 36m span reinforced concrete bridge over Kanyibie River and 24m span reinforced concrete bridge over bechelihi river. - 32.6km
58	Partial Reconstruction of Navrongo Chuchuliga - Tumu Road; (34,23km) Including Partial Reconstruction of Navrongo Chuchuliga - Sandema Road (16km)
59	Rehabilitation of Tapa (Mabang) - Goaso Road (39.0km)
60	Rehabilitation of Hohoe - Jasikan 30km
61	Upgrading of Nkwanta - Oti Damanko (0-50.3km)
62	Upgrading of Nkwanta - Oti Damanko (50.3km - 62km)

63	Reconstruction of Have - Hohoe (Km 0 - 53.35)
64	Design and Construction of Suame Interchange and Ancillary Works Component Phase 1
65	Design and Construction of Suame Interchange- Local Roads Component - Phase 2
66	Rehabilitation and Upgrading of Kasoa Winneba Road (30km) Lot 1: Rehabilitation and Upgrading of Kasoa - Akoti Road (Km 0+000 — Km 12+000
67	Rehabilitation and Upgrading of Kasoa — Winneba Road (30.Km) - Lot 2: Rehabilitation and Upgrading of Akoti Junction - Winneba Roundabout (Km 12.00 - 30.00)
68	Rehabilitation and Upgrading of Kasoa — Winneba Road (30.0km) - Lot IA: Construction of Interchanges at Sapato (Km 1+800), Buduburam (Km 3+200) Awutu Breku (Km 7+200), Akoti (Km 9+800) and 2No. Footbridges
69	Rehabilitation and Upgrading of Kasoa — Winneba Road (30Km) - Lot 2A: Construction of Interchanges at Km 15+900 (Onion Market); Km 18+900 (Potsin); Twin River Bridge at Km 22+900 (Okyereko); and 3No. Footbridges.
70	Rehabilitation of Ofankor — Nsawam Road (Dual Carriageway) 33.0km
71	Design Build for the Dualization of Adenta Dodowa Road (R40) - 22km
72	Takoradi - Agona Rehabilitation and Dualization of Takoradi — Agona Junction Road (23km) Including 2No. Dual Carriageway Bridges
73	Reconstruction of Jinijini - Sampa Road Project (80km)

